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Hosea - Introduction

Hosea

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Part 1: General Introduction

Outline of Hosea

1. God tells Hosea to marry Gomer as a picture of how Israel relates to Yahweh (1:1–3:5)
2. Israel betrays, wanders, and sins; Yahweh appeals and pleas for them to return to him (4:1–7:3)
3. The conflict between Yahweh and Israel explained in various ways (7:4–13:8)
4. Israel is hostile to Yahweh (13:9–16)
5. Yahweh's last appeals to Israel (14:1–9)

What is the Book of Hosea about?

This book contains the prophecies of Hosea, son of Beeri. Hosea lived in the northern kingdom of Israel. He often called this kingdom Ephraim or Samaria. Hosea prophesied for about 38 years and predicted that Assyria would destroy the northern kingdom of Israel.

Hosea began to prophesy around 753 B.C., just before King Jeroboam II died. At this time, the kingdom of Israel was prosperous but spiritually weak. Hosea warned how Yahweh would punish Israel unless the people turned back to Yahweh and were faithful to him.

How should the title of this book be translated?

This book is traditionally named "The Book of Hosea" or just "Hosea." Translators may also call it "The Book About Hosea" or "The Sayings of Hosea."

Who wrote the Book of Hosea?

Although this book tells what Hosea prophesied, it is uncertain whether Hosea wrote the book himself. It was probably written after Samaria, the capital of the northern kingdom, was destroyed in 721 B.C.

Part 2: Important Religious and Cultural Concepts

Prostitution and adultery

During the time of Hosea, the people had combined the worship of Yahweh with the worship of Baal and other false gods. Part of worshiping these false gods was having sexual relations with both male and female prostitutes at the pagan shrines. So even though Hosea uses prostitution and marital unfaithfulness to represent abandonment of Yahweh and unfaithfulness to him, the people were also doing this literally. So in the UST of Hosea, rather than translating the terms for prostitution and adultery as idol worship and unfaithfulness to Yahweh, we will most often translate these terms literally, since the people were doing them literally, but the reader must remember that these things are also a symbol of unfaithfulness to Yahweh.

Why did God command Hosea to marry a prostitute?

God told Hosea to marry the prostitute Gomer. This represented how the kingdom of Israel related to Yahweh. Israel was unfaithful to Yahweh and broke the covenant with him. This is compared to how a woman who is unfaithful to her husband breaks her marriage agreement with him.

What is a lawsuit?

Many cultures have a process for resolving disputes through law courts. These legal disputes are called lawsuits. The Book of Hosea contains some legal terms. This is because Yahweh is spoken of as if he were a husband accusing his wife in court of being unfaithful to him. Part of the Book of Hosea follows the form of a lawsuit. A problem is identified (4:1), someone is accused (4:4), someone is found guilty (4:15), and the guilty ones will be punished (5:1).

Who did the people of the kingdom of Israel worship?

Israel was supposed to worship Yahweh alone. But they worshiped both Yahweh and the Canaanite gods such as Baal. This was a major reason why Yahweh judged the kingdom of Israel.

Part 3: Important Translation Issues

What does the phrase "the declaration of Yahweh" mean?

When the prophet uses the phrase "the declaration of Yahweh," he is attesting that what he has just said comes from Yahweh, not from him, and so Yahweh's authority is behind it. In some cases, Yahweh himself uses the phrase to attest to the origins and authority of his own speech. Decide as a team how you will represent this phrase in your translation.

Why are English translations of Hosea very different?

Hosea 4–14 has many problems of interpretation. Some phrases in Hosea are beyond how we currently understand the Hebrew language. Many English versions have translated these difficult sections very differently.

What does the term "Israel" mean in Hosea?

Throughout Hosea, "Israel" and "Ephraim" are used to refer to the northern kingdom of Israel while "Judah" is used to refer to the southern kingdom.

Hosea - Chapter 1 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

1. Yahweh commands Hosea to marry Gomer (1–3)
2. The children's names symbolize judgment on Israel (4–9)

3 Yahweh promises future restoration and mercy (10–11)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

The day of Jezreel
Jezreel means "God scatters." In 1:4 it refers to God scattering the people of Israel to other nations as a punishment. In 1:11 it refers to God scattering Israel as seeds in their own land as a blessing. You could explain that in the text or in a footnote if that would be helpful to your readers.

Prophetic sign-acts and symbolic names
Yahweh commands Hosea to give his three children symbolic names—Jezreel, Lo Ruhamah, and Lo Ammi—each embodying a message of divine judgment. These names function as prophetic acts communicating Israel's covenant unfaithfulness and the withdrawal of compassion.

Hosea 1:1 (#1)

דְּבַר־יְהוָה ׀ אֲשֶׁר הָיָה אֶל־הוֹשֵׁעַ

"The word of Yahweh that was to Hosea"

The speaker is using the term **word** to represent what Yahweh said by using words. If it would be clearer in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [This is the message that Yahweh communicated to Hosea]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 1:1 (#2)

הוֹשֵׁעַ בֶּן־בְּאֵרִי

"Hosea, the son of Beeri"

Here Hosea is introducing **Hosea, the son of Beeri** as a new participant in the story. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [a man named Hosea, the son of Beeri]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

Hosea 1:1 (#3)

בִּימֵי עֻזִּיָּה יוֹתָם אָחָז יְחִזְקִיָּה מַלְכֵי יְהוּדָה וּבִימֵי יָרָבְעָם

"in the days of Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, {and} Hezekiah, kings of Judah, and in the days of Jeroboam"

Here, **in the days** represents the time period during which each king reigned. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [during the reigns of Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah, kings of Judah, and of Jeroboam]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 1:2 (#1)

תְּחִלַּת דִּבֶּר־יְהוָה בְּהוֹשֵׁעַ

"The beginning of {when} Yahweh spoke through Hosea"

Hosea is using the phrase translated as **The beginning of** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event. Alternate translation: [There was a time when Yahweh spoke through Hosea]

See: Introduction of a New Event

Hosea 1:2 (#2)

אֵשֶׁת זְנוּנִים וְיַלְדֵי זְנוּנִים

"a wife of prostitutions and children of prostitutions"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **prostitutions**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a promiscuous wife and children born from promiscuity]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 1:2 (#3)

כִּי־זָנֹה תִּזְנֶה הָאָרֶץ מֵאַחֲרֵי יְהוָה

"for prostituting, the land prostitutes {itself} from after Yahweh"

The word translated as **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because the land prostitutes itself from after Yahweh]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Hosea 1:2 (#4)

תִּזְנֶה הָאָרֶץ מֵאַחֲרֵי יְהוָה

“the land prostitutes {itself} from after Yahweh”

Here, **land** represents the people of who lived in the land. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of the land have been unfaithful to Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 1:2 (#5)

מֵאַחֲרֵי יְהוָה

“from after Yahweh”

Yahweh is speaking as if the Israelites had been walking behind God but then turned away from following **after Yahweh** to walk in a different direction from him. He means that they were unfaithful to him as a wife who is unfaithful to her husband. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [by being unfaithful to Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 1:3 (#1)

אֶת־גֹּמֶר בַּת־דִּבְלָיִם

“Gomer, the daughter of Diblaim”

Here Hosea is introducing **Gomer, the daughter of Diblaim** as a new participant in the story. Your language may have its own way of introducing new participants that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [a woman named Gomer who was the daughter of Diblaim,]

See: Introduction of New and Old Participants

Hosea 1:3 (#2)

וַתַּתַּהַר וַתֵּלֶד־לֹו בֵּן

“and she conceived and bore a son to him”

This event did not happen right after Hosea married Gomer. Your language may have a connecting phrase that you can use to show this. Alternate translation: [and after some time, she conceived and bore a son to him]

See: Connect — Sequential Time Relationship

Hosea 1:4 (#1)

יִזְרְעֶאל

“Jezreel”

The name **Jezreel** means “God sows” or “God scatters.” See the introduction to this chapter for more information about these meanings. You may want to include this information in a footnote.

See: How to Translate Names

Hosea 1:4 (#2)

וּפָקַדְתִּי אֶת־דְּמֵי יִזְרְעֶאל עַל־בֵּית יֵהוּא

“and I will visit the bloodshed of Jezreel on the house of Jehu”

Yahweh is using **visit the bloodshed of** as a common expression of the culture to mean “punish for the violence of.” This refers to what happened in 2 Kings 9 and 10. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will punish the house of Jehu because of the massacre at Jezreel]

See: Idiom

Hosea 1:4 (#3)

וּפָקַדְתִּי אֶת־דְּמֵי יִזְרְעֶאל עַל־בֵּית יֵהוּא

“and I will visit the bloodshed of Jezreel on the house of Jehu”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **bloodshed**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and I will punish the house of Jehu because of all the people that he killed at Jezreel]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 1:4 (#4)

בֵּית יֵהוּא

“the house of Jehu”

Yahweh is speaking as if the descendants of Jehu were a **house** in which they all lived together. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the family of Jehu]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 1:4 (#5)

מַמְלְכוּת בֵּית יִשְׂרָאֵל

“the kingdom of the house of Israel”

Yahweh is speaking as if the descendants of Israel were a **house** in which they all lived together. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the rule of the descendants of Israel]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 1:5 (#1)

וְהָיָה בַּיּוֹם הַהוּא וְשָׁבַרְתִּי

“And it will be on that day that I will break”

Yahweh is using the term **day** to refer to a time that is coming. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [But when that time comes, I will break]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 1:5 (#2)

וְשָׁבַרְתִּי אֶת־קֶשֶׁת יִשְׂרָאֵל

“that I will break the bow of Israel”

Here, **the bow** represents the military power of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [that I will break the military power of Israel]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 1:6 (#1)

לֹ֣א רֻחָמָ֔ה

“Lo Ruhamah”

The word **Lo Ruhamah** is a name that means “not pitied.” See the introduction to this chapter for more information about the symbolic meaning of this name. You may want to include this information in a footnote.

See: How to Translate Names

Hosea 1:6 (#2)

אֲרַחֵם

“to have compassion on”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **compassion**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [to pity]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 1:6 (#3)

אֶת־בֵּ֣ית יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“the house of Israel”

Yahweh is speaking as if the people of Israel were a **house** in which they all lived together. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the nation of Israel]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 1:6 (#4)

כִּי־נָשֹׂא אֶשָּׂא לָהֶם

“but carrying away, I will carry them away”

Yahweh is repeating forms of the verb **carry** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [but rather, I will surely carry them away]

See: Reduplication

Hosea 1:7 (#1)

וְאֶת־בֵּ֣ית יְהוּדָ֔ה אֲרַחֵ֖ם

“But the house of Judah I will have compassion on”

Yahweh uses the word **But** here to indicate a contrast between what he will do to Israel, the northern kingdom, and what he will do to Judah, of the southern kingdom. In your translation, indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [In contrast, I will have compassion on the house of Judah]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Hosea 1:7 (#2)

בֵּ֣ית יְהוּדָ֔ה

“the house of Judah”

Yahweh is speaking as if the people of Judah were a **house** in which they all lived together. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those who belong to the tribe of Judah]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 1:7 (#3)

אֲרַחֵ֖ם

“I will have compassion on”

See how you translated the similar phrase “to have compassion on” in 1:6.

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 1:7 (#4)

וְהוֹשַׁעְתִּ֥ים בַּיהוָ֖ה אֱלֹהֵיהֶ֑ם

“and I will save them by Yahweh their God”

Yahweh is speaking of himself in the third person as **Yahweh their God**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [and I myself will save them as their God]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Hosea 1:7 (#5)

אֱלֹהֵיהֶ֑ם

“their God”

Yahweh is not using the possessive form **their God** to indicate that the people of Judah possess or control Yahweh but rather to emphasize that Yahweh is the God that they worship. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the God whom the people of Judah worship]

See: Possession

Hosea 1:7 (#6)

בְּקֶ֖שֶׁת וּבְחֶ֣רֶב וּבְמִלְחָמָ֔ה בְּסוּסִ֖ים וּבְפָרָשִֽׁים

“by bow and by sword and by battle, by horses, and by horsemen”

Here the list of words, **bow**, **sword**, **battle**, **horses,** and **horsemen** all represent warfare and military strength. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [by warfare or by military strength]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 1:8 (#1)

וַתִּגְמֹ֖ל אֶת־לֹ֣א רֻחָמָ֑ה וַתַּ֖הַר

“And she weaned Lo Ruhamah, and she conceived”

The pronoun **she** refers to Gomer in both instances. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [When Gomer weaned Lo Ruhamah, she conceived]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 1:9 (#1)

וַיֹּ֖אמֶר

“And he said”

The pronoun **he** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And Yahweh said]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 1:9 (#2)

לֹ֥א עַמִּ֖י

“Lo Ammi”

The word **Lo Ammi** is a name that means “not my people.” See the introduction to this chapter for more information about the symbolic meaning of this name. You may want to include this information in a footnote.

See: How to Translate Names

Hosea 1:9 (#3)

לֹֽא־אֶהְיֶ֥ה

“not ‘I am”

When Yahweh uses the phrase **not I am**, he is referring to the words that he said to Moses in Exodus 3:14. In Exodus 3:10, he referred to the Israelites as “my people,” and in 3:14 he told Moses to call him “I am.” Here he is saying that they are no longer his people and that they may no longer call him that. You could explain that in a footnote if that would be helpful to your readers.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 1:10 (#1)

בְּנֵ֥י־יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל

“the sons of Israel”

Hosea is speaking as if the people who would become so numerous were actually the **sons of** the patriarch Jacob, who was also known as **Israel**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the Israelites]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 1:10 (#2)

אֲשֶׁ֤ר לֹא־יִמַּ֙ד וְלֹ֣א יִסָּפֵ֔ר

“which cannot be measured and cannot be counted”

Hosea says **which cannot be measured and cannot be counted** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [so vast that it would be difficult to count them all]

See: Hyperbole

Hosea 1:10 (#3)

אֲשֶׁ֤ר לֹא־יִמַּ֙ד וְלֹ֣א יִסָּפֵ֔ר

“which cannot be measured and cannot be counted”

The expression **be measured** and **be counted** are a passive verbal forms. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [which no one can measure or count]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 1:10 (#4)

יֵאָמֵ֥ר לָהֶ֖ם

“it was said to them”

The expression **it was said to them** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God had told them]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 1:10 (#5)

אֲשֶׁר־יֵאָמֵ֥ר לָהֶ֖ם לֹא־עַמִּ֣י אַתֶּ֑ם

“where it was said to them, “You {are} not my people”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [where it was said that they were not his people]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Hosea 1:10 (#6)

יֵאָמֵ֥ר לָהֶ֖ם בְּנֵ֣י אֵ֑ל־חָֽי

“it will be said to them, “Sons of the living God”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [it will be said that they have become sons of the living God]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Hosea 1:10 (#7)

יֵאָמֵ֥ר לָהֶ֖ם

“it will be said to them”

The expression **it will be said to them** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [God will say to them]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 1:10 (#8)

בְּנֵ֥י אֵ֑ל־חָֽי

“Sons of the living God”

Hosea is speaking as if those who belong to God were actually his **Sons**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You are the people who belong to the living God]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 1:10 (#9)

בְּנֵ֥י אֵ֑ל־חָֽי

“Sons of the living God”

Here the masculine term **Sons** has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [You are all children of the living God]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Hosea 1:11 (#1)

וְנִקְבְּצ֤וּ בְנֵֽי־יְהוּדָה֙ וּבְנֵ֣י־יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל יַחְדָּ֖ו

“And the sons of Judah and the sons of Israel will be gathered together”

The expression **will be gathered together** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And the sons of Judah and the sons of Israel will gather together]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 1:11 (#2)

בְּנֵי־יְהוּדָה וּבְנֵי־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“the sons of Judah and the sons of Israel”

Hosea is speaking as if the people of **Judah** and **Israel** were actually the **sons** of the patriarchs Judah and Israel. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the descendants of Judah and the descendants of Israel]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 1:11 (#3)

רֹאשׁ אֶחָד

“one head”

Hosea is speaking of a leader or ruler of the people as if they were the **head** of a body. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [one ruler]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 1:11 (#4)

וְעָלוּ מִן־הָאָרֶץ

“and they will arise from the land”

The phrase, **and they will arise from the land** could refer to: (1) the people of Israel growing and prospering in the land, pictured as growing plants, as in 2:23, Alternate translation: [and they will sprout up from the land] or (2) the people of Israel coming back from foreign lands where they had been exiled. Alternate translation: [and they will return from the land where their captors had taken them]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 1:11 (#5)

יוֹם יִזְרְעֶאל

“the day of Jezreel”

See the introduction to this chapter for further details about **the day of Jezreel**. Alternate translation: [the time when God plants his people in the land]

Hosea - Chapter 2 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter is prophetic poetry. Yahweh announces judgment on Israel using an extended marriage metaphor of Israel as an unfaithful wife (v. 1) then promises restoration through a renewed covenant betrothal (v. 14).

1. Yahweh exposes Israel’s unfaithfulness and judgment (1–13)
2. Yahweh promises to restore and renew his people (14–23)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Marriage as covenant metaphor

Yahweh depicts Israel’s worship of Baal as prostitution and adultery. His promised restoration is described as a new betrothal with faithfulness and compassion.

Symbolic names

The chapter frames rejection and restoration through meaningful Hebrew names: Ammi (“my people”), Ruhamah (“pitied”), Lo Ammi (“not my people”), Lo Ruhamah (“not pitied”), and Jezreel (“God sows”).

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Blended complaint of Hosea and Yahweh

In Chapter 1, Hosea marries Gomer, who is an unfaithful wife who bears children from her prostitution whom Hosea names Lo Ruhamah (“not pitied”) and Lo Ammi (“not my people”). In Chapter 2, beginning at verse 2, Hosea begins telling his children to plead with their mother to stop her prostitution, and then describes the punishments that he will do to her to bring her back to himself. But at some point in this description, it becomes clear that this is not just about Hosea and Gomer, but it is about Yahweh and his people, Israel. In verse 8 we get a strong hint that Yahweh is talking about his people when there is a switch from saying “her” to saying “they” in the last clause of the verse. The description of punishment continues using “her,” but it ends in verse 13 with “the declaration of Yahweh.” The rest of the chapter is then clearly about Israel. In this way, Hosea makes it clear that Yahweh intended his experience with Gomer to be a painful illustration of Yahweh’s experience with Israel, and we are to see them as blended and overlapping stories. Therefore, it is not possible to strictly identify who the verbs and pronouns in this chapter refer to. They are intended to tell both stories at the same time. If possible, do the same in your translation, with an explanation in a footnote, if necessary.

Person shifts and embedded quotes
Yahweh's speech shifts between second and third person for Israel and contains embedded quotes from the unfaithful wife who represents Israel. Translators need to decide what to do with these shifts in order to avoid confusion about who is speaking or being addressed.

"the declaration of Yahweh"
Hosea uses the phrase "the declaration of Yahweh" throughout this chapter. When he does, he is attesting that what he has just said comes from Yahweh, not from him, and so Yahweh's authority is behind it. In some cases, Yahweh himself uses the phrase to attest to the origins and authority of his own speech. Decide as a team how you will represent this phrase in your translation.

Hosea 2:1 (#1)

עַמִּי

"Ammi"

The word **Ammi** is a name that means "my people". You may want to include this information in a footnote.

See: How to Translate Names

Hosea 2:1 (#2)

רֻחָמָה

"Ruhamah"

The word **Ruhamah** is a name that means "pitied" or "loved." You may want to include this information in a footnote.

See: How to Translate Names

Hosea 2:2 (#1)

רִיבוּ בְאִמְּכֶם֙ רִ֣יבוּ

"Contend with your mother, contend"

As the introduction to this chapter explains, throughout this book Hosea represents Yahweh and his wife represents Israel. So as Hosea is speaking to his children about his wife, Yahweh is using him to represent his attitude toward Israel. Translate in such a way that either Hosea or Yahweh could be saying these things.

See: Metaphor

Hosea 2:2 (#2)

זְנוּנֶ֖יהָ

"her prostitutions"

If your language does not use abstract noun for the idea of **prostitutions** you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [prostituting]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 2:2 (#3)

מִפָּנֶ֔יהָ

"from her face"

Here, **her face** represents who she is. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from who she is]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 2:2 (#4)

וְנַאֲפוּפֶ֖יהָ מִבֵּ֥ין שָׁדֶֽיהָ

"and her adulteries from between her breasts"

The speaker is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and let her remove her adulteries from between her breasts]

See: Ellipsis

Hosea 2:2 (#5)

וְנַאֲפוּפֶ֖יהָ מִבֵּ֥ין שָׁדֶֽיהָ

"and her adulteries from between her breasts"

Here, **adulteries from between her breasts** represents "her adulterous behavior." If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and stop her adulterous behavior]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 2:2 (#6)

וְנַאֲפוּפֶ֖יהָ

"and her adulteries"

If your language does not use abstract noun for the idea of **adulteries**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and her unfaithful behavior]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 2:3 (#1)

פֶּן

“lest”

The word translated as **lest** indicates that what follows is a negative result of the mother not doing what was commanded in the previous verse. Use a connector in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [or else]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Hosea 2:3 (#2)

פֶּן־אַפְשִׁיטֶנָּה עֲרֻמָּה וְהִצַּגְתִּיהָ כְּיוֹם הִוָּלְדָהּ

“lest I strip her naked, and place her as {on} the day of her being born”

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way as modeled in the UST. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word other than **and** in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [indeed, place her as on the day of her being born]

See: Parallelism

Hosea 2:3 (#3)

וְשַׂמְתִּיהָ כַמִּדְבָּר

“and I make her like the wilderness”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the wilderness** is barren and desolate, so Yahweh will make Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and I make her barren and desolate as the wilderness]

See: Simile

Hosea 2:3 (#4)

וְשַׁתִּתִּהָ כְּאֶרֶץ צִיָּה

“and set her like a land of dryness”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a land of dryness** is lifeless and unproductive, so Yahweh will make Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and make her as lifeless and unproductive as a dry land]

See: Simile

Hosea 2:4 (#1)

לֹ֣א אֲרַחֵ֔ם

“I will not have compassion on”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **compassion**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I will not feel sorry for]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 2:4 (#2)

בְּנֵי זְנוּנִים

“children of prostitutions”

There is a double meaning here, because **children of prostitutions** means “children that result from prostitution” (as Gomer’s children were) as well as being a common expression of the culture to indicate that a person has a certain characteristic. In this case, the children (representing Israel) have the characteristic of being unfaithful to Yahweh. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [children who are unfaithful]

See: Idiom

Hosea 2:5 (#1)

אָמְרָה֙ אֵלְכָ֣ה אַחֲרֵ֔י מְאַהֲבַ֖י נֹתְנֵ֣י לַחְמִ֑י וּמֵימַ֕י צַמְרִ֥י וּפִשְׁתִּ֖י שַׁמְנִ֥י וְשִׁקּוּיָֽי

“she said, “Let me go after my lovers, the givers of my bread and my water, my wool and my linen, my oil and my drink”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [she said that she wants to go after her lovers who were the givers of her bread, water, wool, linen, oil, and drink]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Hosea 2:5 (#2)

כִּֽי

“for”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [you see]

Hosea 2:6 (#1)

הִנְנִי־שָׂשָׂךְ אֶת־דַּרְכֵּךְ

“behold me blocking your way”

Yahweh is using **behold me** as a common expression of the culture to announce that he is about to perform the action that follows. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Look, I am going to block your way] or [I will surely block your way]

See: Idiom

Hosea 2:6 (#2)

שָׂשָׂךְ אֶת־דַּרְכֵּךְ בַּסִּירִים

“blocking your way with the thorns”

The speaker is speaking as if the obstacles Yahweh places before Israel were **blocking** her **way with the thorns**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [preventing you from finding your way]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 2:6 (#3)

אֶת־דַּרְכֵּךְ

“your way”

While here the speaker refers to the wife or Israel directly in the second person, **your way**, in the rest of this section, he speaks of her in the third person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use third person throughout. Alternate translation: [her way]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Hosea 2:6 (#4)

וְגָדַרְתִּי אֶת־גְּדֵרָהּ

“and I will wall up a wall against her”

The speaker is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [and I will obstruct her path with a wall]

See: Poetry

Hosea 2:7 (#1)

וְרִדְפָה אֶת־מְאַהֲבֶיהָ

“And she will pursue her lovers”

The speaker is speaking of both Gomer’s pursuit of sexual partners and Israel’s devotion to false gods as **pursuing her lovers**. Continue translating in a way that works for both meanings. Alternate translation: [And she will continue going after the ones she is devoted to]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 2:8 (#1)

וְהִיא לֹא יָדְעָה

“And she, she did not know”

The speaker is stating the pronoun **she** separately, even though the verb translated as **she did not know** already includes this meaning. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [And she herself did not know]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 2:8 (#2)

כִּי אֲנֹכִי נָתַתִּי

“that I, I gave”

The speaker is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I gave** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that he is the one who gave her all those things. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [that I myself gave]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 2:8 (#3)

עָשׂוּ לַבָּעַל

“which} they made for the Baal”

The pronoun **they** refers to the people of Israel. From here on it is clear that Yahweh is talking about the unfaithfulness of the people of Israel. Alternate translation: [which the Israelites made for the Baal]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 2:9 (#1)

אֶת־עֶרְוָתָהּ

“her nakedness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **nakedness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [her exposed body]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 2:9 (#2)

וְהִצַּלְתִּי֙ צַמְרִ֣י וּפִשְׁתִּ֔י לְכַסּ֖וֹת אֶת־עֶרְוָתָֽהּ

“and I will snatch away my wool and my linen {meant} to cover her nakedness”

The speaker is speaking as if reclaiming the resources Yahweh provided to Israel were **snatching away** his **wool** and **linen** that covered **her nakedness**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I will take back the wool and linen I provided to clothe her]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 2:10 (#1)

אֲגַלֶּ֛ה אֶת־נַבְלֻתָּ֖הּ

“I will uncover her lewdness”

Yahweh is speaking as if publicly exposing Israel’s unfaithfulness were **uncovering her lewdness**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will publicly expose her shameful acts]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 2:10 (#2)

אֶת־נַבְלֻתָּ֖הּ

“her lewdness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **lewdness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [her shameful acts]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 2:10 (#3)

מִיָּדִֽי

“from my hand”

Here, **my hand** represents a person’s power and authority. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [from my power]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 2:10 (#4)

לְעֵינֵ֖י מְאַהֲבֶ֑יהָ

“to the eyes of her lovers”

Yahweh is using **to the eyes of her lovers** as a common expression of the culture to mean “in the sight of her lovers.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in the sight of her lovers]

See: Idiom

Hosea 2:11 (#1)

מְשׂוֹשָׂ֔הּ

“her joy”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **joy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [her being joyful] or [the times she is joyful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 2:12 (#1)

אֶתְנָ֗ה הֵ֚הָמָּה לִ֣י אֲשֶׁ֣ר נָתְנ֣וּ־לִ֔י מְאַהֲבָ֑י

“A payment they {are} to me, which my lovers gave to me”

Israel is presented as speaking as if the produce of Israel’s land were **a payment** given by **her lovers**, like wages paid to a prostitute. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The gods gave these to me as wages for my services to them]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 2:12 (#2)

וְשַׂמְתִּ֖ים לְיַ֣עַר

“And I will make them a forest”

The speaker is speaking as if turning Israel’s cultivated vineyards and fig trees into untended overgrowth were making them **a forest**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your

translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And I will cause them to become uncultivated and unproductive]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 2:12 (#3)

אָמְרָ֔ה אֶתְנָ֖ה הֵ֣מָּה לִ֑י אֲשֶׁ֤ר נָתְנ֙וּ־לִ֣י מְאַהֲבָ֔י

“she said, “A payment they {are} to me, which my lovers gave to me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as a direct quotation. Alternate translation: [she said that they were a payment to her, which her lovers had given to her]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Hosea 2:13 (#1)

וּפָקַדְתִּ֤י עָלֶ֙יהָ֙ אֶת־יְמֵ֣י הַבְּעָלִ֔ים

“And I will visit on her the days of the Baals”

The speaker is using **I will visit on her** as a common expression of the culture to mean “I will punish her for.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And I will punish her for the times she worshipped the Baals]

See: Idiom

Hosea 2:13 (#2)

אֶת־יְמֵ֣י הַבְּעָלִ֔ים

“the days of the Baals”

The speaker is using the term **days** to refer to the time periods when Israel worshiped the Baals. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the times when she worshiped the Baals]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 2:13 (#3)

נְאֻם־יְהוָ֖ה

“the declaration of Yahweh”

Although this speech began in verse 2 as Hosea’s complaint about Gomer’s unfaithfulness, he shows us here that Yahweh has also been describing Israel’s unfaithfulness to him, and now continues to do so. The rest of the chapter is about Yahweh and Israel.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 2:14 (#1)

הִנֵּ֥ה

“behold”

The speaker is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [look]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Hosea 2:14 (#2)

אָנֹכִ֣י מְפַתֶּ֔תְיָהּ

“I am alluring her”

The speaker is speaking as if winning back Israel’s loyalty were **alluring her** like a lover. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am trying to win back her loyalty]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 2:14 (#3)

וְדִבַּרְתִּ֖י עַל לִבָּ֑הּ

“and I will speak on her heart”

The speaker is using **speak on her heart** as a common expression of the culture to mean that he will speak lovingly or compassionately to her. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I will speak lovingly to her]

See: Idiom

Hosea 2:14 (#4)

וְהֹלַכְתִּ֥יהָ הַמִּדְבָּ֖ר

“and I will lead her {into} the wilderness”

Here, **the wilderness** represents the experience that Israel had when Yahweh led their ancestors through the wilderness after bringing them out of Egypt. That is where the people of Israel first pledged their loyalty to Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state some of this plainly. Alternate translation: [and I will remind her of when we were in the wilderness and she first vowed her loyalty to me]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 2:15 (#1)

עֵמֶק עָכוֹר

“the Valley of Achor”

The word **Achor** is the name of a valley. This word means “trouble.” It received this name because of the events recorded in Joshua 7:24–26. If it is helpful in your language, you may want to put some of this information in a footnote.

See: How to Translate Names

Hosea 2:15 (#2)

עֵמֶק עָכוֹר לְפֶתַח תִּקְוָה

“the Valley of Achor as a door of hope”

The point of this comparison is that just as a **door** provides access to what lies beyond, so the Valley of Achor will become an entrance to **hope** for Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [the Valley of Achor as a place where she can begin to hope again]

See: Simile

Hosea 2:15 (#3)

תִּקְוָה

“hope”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **hope**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [being able to hope again]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 2:16 (#1)

תִּקְרְאִי אִישִׁי וְלֹא־תִקְרְאִי־לִי עוֹד בַּעְלִי

“you will call {me} “My Husband,” and you will no longer call me “My Baal”

In this verse, Yahweh addresses Israel directly in the second person (**you will call**), whereas in the surrounding context he has been speaking about her in the third person. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use third person throughout. Alternate translation: [she will call me “My Husband,” and she will no longer call me “My Baal]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Hosea 2:16 (#2)

תִּקְרְאִי אִישִׁי

“you will call {me} “My Husband”

Yahweh is continuing to speak of his relationship to Israel as though they were a husband and a wife. Israel calling Yahweh **My Husband** represents their renewed covenant loyalty to him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly.

See: Metaphor

Hosea 2:16 (#3)

תִּקְרְאִי אִישִׁי וְלֹא־תִקְרְאִי־לִי עוֹד בַּעְלִי

“you will call {me} “My Husband,” and you will no longer call me “My Baal”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [you will me your husband and you will no longer call me your Baal]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Hosea 2:16 (#4)

נְאֻם־יְהוָה

“the declaration of Yahweh”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:13.

See: Information Structure

Hosea 2:16 (#5)

וְלֹא־תִקְרְאִי־לִי עוֹד בַּעְלִי

“and you will no longer call me “My Baal”

The word **Baal** means “master” or “lord” in the original language, but it is also the name of a Canaanite deity that Israelites were worshiping. Yahweh declares that Israel will no longer use this title for him because of its association with the false gods. If your readers would not be familiar with this term, you could explain its significance in a footnote.

See: Translate Unknowns

Hosea 2:17 (#1)

מִפִּֽיהָ

“from her mouth”

Here, **her mouth** represents her speech. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent

expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [from her speech]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 2:17 (#2)

וְלֹא־יִזָּכְרוּ עוֹד בִּשְׁמָם

“and they will no longer be remembered by their name”

The expression **they will no longer be remembered** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and no one will ever mention their name again]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 2:18 (#1)

וְכָרַתִּי & בְּרִית

“And I will cut a covenant”

Yahweh is using **cut a covenant** as a common expression of the culture to mean “establish a covenant.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will make a covenant]

See: Idiom

Hosea 2:18 (#2)

וְהַשְׁכַּבְתִּים

“and I will make them lie down”

By **make them lie down**, Yahweh means that he will create the situation of safety in which they can lie down. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and I will make it possible for them to lie down]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 2:18 (#3)

לָבֶטַח

“in safety”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **safety**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in a safe place]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 2:19 (#1)

וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי לְעוֹלָם

“And I will betroth you to me forever”

Yahweh continues speaking as if renewing his covenant with Israel were **betrothing** her to himself. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And you will be pledged to me forever]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 2:19 (#2)

וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי בְּצֶדֶק וּבְמִשְׁפָּט וּבְחֶסֶד וּבְרַחֲמִים

“and I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, and in covenant faithfulness and in compassion”

Here Yahweh defines the characteristics of his renewed relationship with Israel. If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **righteousness**, **justice**, **covenant faithfulness**, and **compassion**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [and in our marriage relationship I promise to do the right and just thing, to love you faithfully, and to be compassionate toward you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 2:20 (#1)

וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי בֶּאֱמוּנָה

“And I will betroth you to me in faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [And in our marriage I promise to be faithful to you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 2:20 (#2)

וְיָדַעַתְּ אֶת־יְהוָה

“and you will know Yahweh”

To **know Yahweh** is an important concept in the book of Hosea. It means to be in an intimate covenant relationship with Yahweh. Those who know Yahweh both love and obey him. You could indicate this explicitly in your translation if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and you will be in an intimate covenant relationship with Yahweh]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 2:20 (#3)

וְאֵרַשְׂתִּתִיךְ לִ֣י בֶּאֱמוּנָ֑ה

“And I will betroth you to me in faithfulness”

Yahweh is speaking as if renewing his covenant with Israel were **betrothing** her to himself **in faithfulness**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And I will commit myself to you in faithfulness]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 2:21 (#1)

אֶֽעֱנֶ֣ה אֶת־הַשָּׁמַ֗יִם וְהֵ֛ם יַֽעֲנ֥וּ אֶת־הָאָֽרֶץ

“I will answer the heavens, and they, they will answer the earth”

Yahweh is speaking of **the heavens** and **the earth** as if they were living things that could make requests and give answers. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will command the heavens and they will give the earth what it needs]

See: Personification

Hosea 2:21 (#2)

וְהֵ֛ם יַֽעֲנ֥וּ

“and they, they will answer”

The speaker is stating the pronoun **they** separately for emphasis, even though the verb translated as **they will answer** already includes this meaning. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [and they themselves will answer]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 2:21 (#3)

נְאֻם־יְהוָ֑ה

“the declaration of Yahweh”

See how you translated the similar expression in 2:13.

See: Information Structure

Hosea 2:22 (#1)

וְהָאָ֖רֶץ תַּֽעֲנֶ֥ה אֶת־הַדָּגָ֛ן

“And the earth will answer the grain”

Yahweh continues speaking of **the earth** as if it were a living thing that could **answer** by producing grain, new wine, and oil. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And the earth will do its part by producing grain]

See: Personification

Hosea 2:22 (#2)

וְהֵ֣ם יַֽעֲנ֔וּ אֶת־יִזְרְעֶֽאל׃

“and they will answer Jezreel”

The speaker is speaking of the grain, new wine, and oil as if they were living things that could **answer** Jezreel by providing for the people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they, in turn, will provide for Jezreel]

See: Personification

Hosea 2:22 (#3)

אֶת־יִזְרְעֶֽאל׃

“Jezreel”

The word **Jezreel** is the name of a city and a valley. It means “God sows.” You could include this information in a footnote if that would be helpful to your readers.

See: How to Translate Names

Hosea 2:23 (#1)

וּזְרַעְתִּ֥יהָ לִ֖י בָּאָֽרֶץ

“And I will sow her for myself on the earth”

Yahweh is speaking as if establishing his people in the land were **sowing** them like seed **on the earth**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And I will settle her for myself in the land]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 2:23 (#2)

אֶת־לֹ֣א רֻחָמָ֑ה

“Lo Ruhamah”

The word **Lo Ruhamah** is a name that means “not pitied.” You may want to include this information in a footnote.

See: How to Translate Names

Hosea 2:23 (#3)

וְאָמַרְתִּי֙ לְלֹ֣א־עַמִּ֔י עַמִּי־אַ֖תָּה וְה֣וּא יֹאמַ֑ר אֱלֹהָֽי

“and I will say to Lo Ammi, “You {are} my people,” and he, he will say, “My God”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could express this as an indirect quotation. Alternate translation: [and I will tell Lo Ammi that he is my people and he will call me his God]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Hosea 2:23 (#4)

לְלֹ֣א־עַמִּ֔י

“to Lo Ammi”

The word **Lo Ammi** is a name that means “not my people.” You may want to include this information in a footnote.

See: How to Translate Names

Hosea 2:23 (#5)

וְה֣וּא יֹאמַ֑ר

“and he, he will say”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **he** separately, even though the verb translated as **he will say** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize the complete reconciliation because Lo Ammi is the one saying it. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [and he himself will say]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea - Chapter 3 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

1. Hosea redeems and restores his wife (1–3)
2. Israel will experience discipline before restoration (4–5)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Ancient measurements

The purchase price in verse 2 includes 15 shekels of silver, a homer of barley, and a lethek of barley. These are ancient units of currency and dry measure that translators may need to handle with footnotes or culturally appropriate equivalents.

Legitimate and illegitimate practices

The list in verse 4 includes both legitimate Israelite institutions such as “sacrifice” and “ephod” as well as items associated with idolatry such as “pillar” and “teraphim.” Israel will lose access to both proper worship and false worship during the period of deprivation.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

“David their king”

In verse 5, “David their king” uses David’s name as a metonymy for a future Davidic ruler, not David himself.

Hosea 3:1 (#1)

וַיֹּ֤אמֶר יְהוָה֙ אֵלַ֔י

“And Yahweh said to me”

Hosea is using the word translated as **And** to introduce a new event in the story. Use a word, phrase, or other method in your language that is natural for introducing a new event.

See: Introduction of a New Event

Hosea 3:1 (#2)

אֲהֻבַ֥ת רֵ֖עַ

“loved by a friend”

The expression **loved by a friend** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [whom a friend loves]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 3:1 (#3)

כְּאַהֲבַ֣ת יְהוָה֮ אֶת־בְּנֵ֣י יִשְׂרָאֵל֒

“like the love of Yahweh for the sons of Israel”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the love of Yahweh for the sons of Israel** is faithful despite their unfaithfulness, so is the love that Hosea is to show for this adulterous woman. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [just as Yahweh loves the sons of Israel faithfully]

See: Simile

Hosea 3:1 (#4)

בְּנֵ֣י יִשְׂרָאֵל֒

“the sons of Israel”

Here Yahweh is speaking as if the Israelite people were actually the **sons** of the patriarch Jacob who was also known as **Israel**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the Israelite people]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 3:1 (#5)

וְהֵהֵם פֹּנִיםאֶל־אֱלֹהִים אֲחֵרִים

“and they turning to other gods”

Here Yahweh is speaking as if the Israelites were physically **turning** to walk toward other gods. He means that they are changing their allegiance and worshiping other gods. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they give their allegiance to other gods]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 3:2 (#1)

בַּחֲמִשָּׁעָה עָשָׂר כָּסֶף

“for 15 of silver”

Hosea is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [for 15 shekels of silver]

See: Ellipsis

Hosea 3:2 (#2)

וְחֹמֶר שְׂעֹרִים וְלֶתֶךְ שְׂעֹרִים

“and a homer of barley, and a lethek of barley”

A **homer** was equivalent to about 220 liters, and a **lethek** was equivalent to about 115 liters. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could express these in terms of modern measurements, either in the text or in a footnote.

See: Biblical Volume

Hosea 3:3 (#1)

וְלֹא תִהְיִי לְאִישׁ

“and you will not be to a man”

Hosea is referring to having sexual relations in a polite way by using the phrase **you will not be to a man**. Depending on what is helpful for your readers, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [and you will not have sexual relations with any man]

See: Euphemism

Hosea 3:4 (#1)

אֵין מֶלֶךְ וְאֵין שָׂשָׂר וְאֵין זֶבַח וְאֵין מַצֵּבָה וְאֵין אֵפוֹד וּתְרָפִים

“without a king, and without a prince, and without a sacrifice, and without a pillar, and without an ephod, and teraphim”

The speaker uses a repetitive series of clauses to communicate that what he is saying should be understood as comprehensive and overwhelming. Use a form in your language that someone would use to describe a situation that is comprehensive and overwhelming.

See: Litany

Hosea 3:4 (#2)

וּתְרָפִים

“and teraphim”

The word **teraphim** refers to a kind of household idol. If your readers would not be familiar with what teraphim are, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [and without an idol]

See: Translate Unknowns

Hosea 3:5 (#1)

אַחַר

“Afterward”

The word **Afterward** indicates that this will not happen immediately after the period described in the preceding verses. Your language may have a connecting phrase that you can use to show this. Alternate translation: [After a while]

See: Connect — Sequential Time Relationship

Hosea 3:5 (#2)

בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל

“the sons of Israel”

See how you translated the same expression in verse 1. Alternate translation: [the Israelite people]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 3:5 (#3)

אֶת־יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵיהֶם

“Yahweh their God”

Hosea is using the possessive form **their God** not to indicate that the Israelites possess or control Yahweh, but to indicate that Yahweh is the God whom they worship. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Yahweh, the God they worship]

See: Possession

Hosea 3:5 (#4)

וְאֶת דָּוִד מַלְכָּם

“and David their king”

The expression **David their king** represents a future king who will be a descendant of King David. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and their king, David’s descendant]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 3:5 (#5)

וּפָחֲדוּ אֶל־יְהוָה וְאֶל־טוּבוֹ בְּאַחֲרִית הַיָּמִים

“and they will tremble toward Yahweh and toward his goodness in the latter days”

The speaker is using **tremble toward Yahweh and toward his goodness** as a common expression of the culture to mean “approach Yahweh with reverent awe, drawn by his goodness.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they will come to Yahweh with reverent awe, drawn by his goodness]

See: Idiom

Hosea 3:5 (#6)

טוּבוֹ

“his goodness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **goodness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [all the good things he does]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 3:5 (#7)

בְּאַחֲרִית הַיָּמִים

“in the latter days”

The speaker is using **in the latter days** as a common expression of the culture to mean “in the distant future.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in the distant future]

See: Idiom

Hosea - Chapter 4 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

1. Yahweh brings charges against the people (1–5)
2. The priests are condemned for rejecting knowledge (6–10)
3. Israel’s idolatry leads to moral corruption (11–19)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Idolatry as prostitution
Hosea uses prostitute language as a sustained metaphor for Israel’s idol worship, connecting physical unfaithfulness at pagan shrines (13–14) with spiritual unfaithfulness to Yahweh.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Shifting addressees
The speaker addresses different groups without explicit transitions: Israel collectively (1–3), a priest in second person singular (4–6), and then Israel in second person plural (13–15).

Hosea 4:1 (#1)

דְּבַר־יְהוָה

“the word of Yahweh”

Here, **word** represents “message.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the message from Yahweh]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 4:1 (#2)

בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל

“sons of Israel”

Here the speaker is speaking as if the Israelites were literal **sons** of the patriarch Jacob who was also called **Israel**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [people of Israel]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 4:1 (#3)

רִ֤יב לַיהוָה֙ עִם־יוֹשְׁבֵ֣י הָאָ֔רֶץ

“Yahweh has a dispute with the dwellers of the land”

Here the speaker is speaking as if Yahweh’s judgment against Israel were a legal **dispute** in a court of law. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is bringing charges against the dwellers of the land]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 4:1 (#4)

אֵין־אֱמֶ֥ת וְאֵין־חֶ֖סֶד וְאֵין־דַּ֣עַת אֱלֹהִ֑ים בָּאָֽרֶץ

“there is no truth and there is no covenant faithfulness, and there is no knowledge of God in the land”

These three clauses mean basically the same thing. Each one emphasizes the meaning by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them. Alternate translation: [there is no truth, covenant faithfulness, or knowledge of God in the land.]

See: Parallelism

Hosea 4:1 (#5)

אֱמֶ֥ת

“truth”

If your language does not use abstract noun for the idea of **truth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [telling the truth]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 4:1 (#6)

חֶ֖סֶד

“covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [keeping covenant promises]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 4:1 (#7)

דַּ֣עַת

“knowledge of”

If your language does not use abstract noun for the idea of **knowledge**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [understanding of]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 4:2 (#1)

וְדָמִ֖ים בְּדָמִ֥ים נָגָֽעוּ

“and bloodshed touches bloodshed”

The speaker is using **bloodshed touches bloodshed** as a common expression of the culture to mean “one act of violence follows right after another.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and one act of violence follows right after another]

See: Idiom

Hosea 4:3 (#1)

תֶּאֱבַ֤ל הָאָ֙רֶץ֙

“the land mourns”

The speaker is speaking of how desolate **the land** is as if it were person that has emotions and **mourns**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the land becomes dry and unproductive]

See: Personification

Hosea 4:3 (#2)

יֵאָסֵֽפוּ

“are gathered away”

The expression **are gathered away** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [disappear]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 4:4 (#1)

אִ֣ישׁ

“man”

Here the masculine term **man** here and in the next line has a generic sense that includes both men and women. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use language in your translation that is clearly inclusive of both men and women. Alternate translation: [person]

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Hosea 4:4 (#2)

וְעַמְּךָ כְּמְרִיבֵי כֹהֵן

“but your people {are} like those disputing with a priest”

The point of this comparison is that just as **those disputing with a priest** stubbornly reject correction, so **your people** stubbornly reject Yahweh’s correction. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [but your people are like those who dispute with a priest, stubbornly rejecting his correction]

See: Simile

Hosea 4:4 (#3)

וְעַמְּךָ

“but your people”

The pronoun **your** refers to the people of Israel whom the speaker is addressing. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [but you people of Israel]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 4:5 (#1)

וְכָשַׁלְתָּ֣ הַיּ֔וֹם וְכָשַׁל גַּם־נָבִ֖יא עִמָּ֑ךְ לָ֖יְלָה

“And you will stumble by day, and also the prophet will stumble with you by night”

Here the speaker is speaking of the people experiencing disaster as if they as well as their prophet would physically **stumble** when walking. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And you will continually experience disaster along with the prophet]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 4:5 (#2)

וְדָמַ֥יְתִי אִמֵּֽךְ

“and I will destroy your mother”

Here the speaker is speaking as if the nation of Israel were the people’s **mother**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I will destroy your nation]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 4:6 (#1)

נִדְמ֥וּ

“are destroyed”

The expression **are destroyed** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [perish]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 4:6 (#2)

הַדָּ֑עַת

“the knowledge”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **the knowledge**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [knowing God]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 4:6 (#3)

אַתָּ֣ה & מָאַ֔סְתָּ

“you, you have rejected”

The speaker is stating the pronoun **you** separately, even though the verb translated as **you have rejected** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it was that it was their choice to reject Yahweh. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [you have completely rejected]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 4:6 (#4)

עַמִּ֖י

“My people”

Even though the speaker has been and will continue to address the people directly, here he speaks of them in the third person as **My people** to remind them of

their relationship to him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this consistently in the second person. Alternate translation: [You, who are my people,]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Hosea 4:6 (#5)

אֱלֹהֶ֖יךָ

“your God”

The speaker is using the possessive form to describe **God** as the one who is in a covenant relationship with the people of Israel. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the God who made a covenant with you]

See: Possession

Hosea 4:6 (#6)

אֶשְׁכַּ֥ח בָּנֶ֖יךָ גַּם־אָֽנִי

“I, I also will forget your sons”

The speaker is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I will forget** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that he will also reject their sons. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [I myself will forget your sons]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 4:6 (#7)

אֶשְׁכַּ֥ח בָּנֶ֖יךָ גַּם־אָֽנִי

“I, I also will forget your sons”

The speaker is speaking as if the people that descended from the Israelites were actually their **sons**. Alternate translation: [I will also reject your descendants]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 4:7 (#1)

כְּבוֹדָ֖ם בְּקָלְל֥וֹן

“their glory for dishonor”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **glory** and **dishonor**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [what is honored about them for what is disgraceful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 4:8 (#1)

חַטַּ֣את עַמִּ֔י יֹאכֵ֑לוּ

“They eat the sin of my people”

Here, **They** could refer to: (1) the priests, as in the UST, or (2) the people. Alternate translation: [The sin of my people, they eat] or [My people eat their sin]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 4:8 (#2)

חַטַּ֣את

“the sin of”

The word translated as **the sin of** can also be translated as “the sin offering of” as in the UST.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 4:8 (#3)

וְאֶל־עֲוֹנָ֖ם יִשְּׂאוּ֙ נַפְשָׁ֔וֹ

“and to their iniquity they lift up his soul”

The speaker is using **lift up his soul** as a common expression of the culture to mean “eagerly desires.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [each priest eagerly desires the people’s iniquity]

See: Idiom

Hosea 4:8 (#4)

עֲוֹנָ֖ם

“their iniquity”

If your language does not use abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the wrong things the people do]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 4:9 (#1)

וְהָיָ֥ה כָעָ֖ם כַּכֹּהֵ֑ן

“And it will be like people, like priest”

The speaker is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language.

Alternate translation: [What happens to the people will also happen to the priest]

See: Ellipsis

Hosea 4:9 (#2)

כַּכֹּהֵן

“like priest”

In this verse, the word **priest** is singular in form, but it refers to all priests as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form here and for the rest of the pronouns referring to them in this verse. Alternate translation: [like all the priests]

See: Collective Nouns

Hosea 4:9 (#3)

וּפָקַדְתִּי עָלָיו דְּרָכָיו

“And I will visit upon him his ways”

The speaker is using **I will visit upon him his ways** as a common expression of the culture to mean “I will punish him for his behavior.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And I will punish him for his behavior]

See: Idiom

Hosea 4:9 (#4)

וּמַעֲלָלָיו אָשִׁיב לוֹ

“and I will return his deeds to him”

The speaker is using **return his deeds to him** as a common expression of the culture to mean “pay him back for what he has done.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I will pay him back for what he has done]

See: Idiom

Hosea 4:10 (#1)

כִּי־אֶת־יְהוָה עָזְבוּ לִשְׁמֹר

“for they have forsaken to heed Yahweh”

The phrase **for they have forsaken to heed Yahweh** is a translation of the Hebrew text as it is in verse 10. Some translations, however, include the first word of verse 11 in this sentence. You may want to do the same in your translation if this is what the major translation in your area does. Alternate translation: [for they have forsaken Yahweh to keep prostitution]

See: Alternative Readings

Hosea 4:11 (#1)

זְנוּנוֹת

“Prostitution”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **Prostitution**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Prostituting themselves]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 4:11 (#2)

יִקַּח־לֵב

“take heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s understanding exists and **take** means to remove. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [remove a person’s understanding]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 4:12 (#1)

עַמִּי בְּעֵצָו יִשְׁאָל

“My people inquires of his wood”

In this verse, the pronoun **his** is singular in form, but it refers to all the people of Israel as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form here and throughout the verse where other singular pronouns are used. Alternate translation: [My people all inquire of their wood]

See: Collective Nouns

Hosea 4:12 (#2)

בְּעֵצָו

“of his wood”

Here, **wood** represents “wooden idol.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [of the wooden idol he worships]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 4:12 (#3)

וּמַקְלוֹ יַגִּיד לוֹ

“and his staff declares to him”

The speaker is speaking of the **staff** as if it were a living thing that could declare things. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he looks to his staff for guidance]

See: Personification

Hosea 4:12 (#4)

רְוּחַ זְנוּנִים֙ הִתְעָ֔ה

“a spirit of prostitutions has led astray”

The phrase **a spirit of prostitutions** could mean: (1) the prevailing attitude in Israel was in favor of prostitution. Alternate translation: [a desire for unfaithfulness has led them astray] or (2) an evil spirit is causing the people to participate in prostitution. Alternate translation: [an evil spirit promoting prostitution has led them astray]

See: Possession

Hosea 4:12 (#5)

רְוּחַ זְנוּנִים֙ הִתְעָ֔ה

“a spirit of prostitutions has led astray”

Here the speaker is speaking of persuading people to do wrong as if it were someone who **led** people **astray**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [their desire has persuaded them to do wrong]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 4:12 (#6)

זְנוּנִים֙

“prostitutions”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **prostitutions**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [being unfaithful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 4:12 (#7)

מִתַּ֥חַת אֱלֹהֵיהֶ֖ם

“from under their God”

Here the speaker is speaking of God directing the people as though they are “under” him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [out of God’s control]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 4:12 (#8)

אֱלֹהֵיהֶ֖ם

“their God”

The speaker is not using this possessive form **their God** to indicate that the Israelites possess or control Yahweh but rather to emphasize that Yahweh is the God that the Israelites worship. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the God whom they worship]

See: Possession

Hosea 4:13 (#1)

תִּזְנֶ֜ינָה בְּנֹתֵיכֶ֗ם וְכַלּוֹתֵיכֶ֛ם תְּנָאַפְנָֽה

“your daughters prostitute {themselves}, and your daughters-in-law commit adultery”

The pronoun **your** still refers to the people of Israel whom the speaker has been addressing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could continue to translate these in the third person here and in the next verse. Alternate translation: [their daughters prostitute themselves and their daughters-in-law commit adultery]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 4:14 (#1)

לֹ֣א־אֶפְקֹ֗ד עַל־בְּנוֹתֵיכֶם֙

“I will not visit upon your daughters”

The speaker is using **I will not visit upon** as a common expression of the culture to mean “I will not punish.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will not bring punishment upon your daughters]

See: Idiom

Hosea 4:14 (#2)

הַקְּדֵשׁ֔וֹת

“the temple prostitutes”

The **temple prostitutes** were women who served at idol shrines and participated in religious rituals involving sexual acts. If your readers would not be

familiar with what **temple prostitutes** are, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term.

See: Translate Unknowns

Hosea 4:14 (#3)

יִלָּבֵט

“will be thrown down”

The expression **will be thrown down** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Yahweh will ruin]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 4:15 (#1)

אִם־זֹנָה אַתָּה֙ יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל

“If you are prostituting {yourself}, Israel”

The speaker is speaking as if this were a hypothetical possibility, but he means that it is actually true. If your language does not state something as a condition if it is certain or true, then you could translate this as a confident statement. Alternate translation: [Although you are prostituting yourself, Israel]

See: Connect — Factual Conditions

Hosea 4:15 (#2)

בֵּ֣בְית אָ֑וֶן

“to} Beth Aven”

The speaker is calling the city of Bethel **Beth Aven** as a derogatory wordplay because of all the idol worship there. “Bethel” means “house of God” and “Beth Aven” means “house of evil.”

See: How to Translate Names

Hosea 4:15 (#3)

חַי־יְהוָ֖ה

“By} the life of Yahweh”

Following the custom of his culture, the speaker is using a common phrase that would be used in swearing an oath and guaranteeing it by something that he holds sacred. Alternate translation: [As Yahweh is my witness, I promise]

See: Oath Formulas

Hosea 4:16 (#1)

כְּפָרָ֣ה סֹרֵ֔רָה סָרַ֖ר יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“Israel is stubborn like a stubborn cow”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a stubborn cow** refuses to be led, so **Israel** refuses to obey Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Israel refuses to obey Yahweh just as a stubborn cow refuses to be led]

See: Simile

Hosea 4:16 (#2)

עַתָּ֣ה יִרְעֵ֔ם יְהוָ֖ה כְּכֶ֣בֶשׂ בַּמֶּרְחָֽב

“Now will Yahweh pasture them like a lamb in a wide place”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a lamb in a wide place** would have the freedom to roam, so the people would have freedom if they had obeyed God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [Now will Yahweh allow them freedom to roam like a lamb looking for pasture]

See: Simile

Hosea 4:16 (#3)

עַתָּ֣ה יִרְעֵ֔ם יְהוָ֖ה כְּכֶ֣בֶשׂ בַּמֶּרְחָֽב

“Now will Yahweh pasture them like a lamb in a wide place”

The speaker is using the question form to emphasize that Yahweh will certainly not act in this way. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Surely Yahweh will not pasture them like a lamb in a wide place!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Hosea 4:17 (#1)

חֲבֻ֥ר עֲצַבִּ֖ים אֶפְרָ֑יִם

“Ephraim {is} joined to idols”

Here the speaker is speaking of Ephraim committing himself to worshiping idols as if he and the idols were **joined** together. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Ephraim has committed himself to worshiping idols]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 4:17 (#2)

חֻבָּר עֲצַבִּים אֶפְרָיִם

“Ephraim {is} joined to idols”

The speaker is using the tribe of **Ephraim**, to represent the people of the northern kingdom of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [The people of the northern kingdom of Israel are joined to idols]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 4:17 (#3)

הֶנַּח־לוֹ

“Leave him alone”

The pronoun **him** refers to Ephraim, that is, the northern kingdom of Israel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [The people of the northern kingdom]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 4:18 (#1)

הַזְנֵנָה הִזְנּוּ

“Prostituting, they have prostituted {themselves”

The speaker is repeating forms of the verb **prostituted** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [They have completely prostituted themselves]

See: Reduplication

Hosea 4:18 (#2)

מָגִנֶּיהָ

“Her shields”

The pronoun **Her** still refers to the people of the northern kingdom of Israel, called “Ephraim”, whom the speaker has been describing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could continue to translate these in the third person here and in the next verse. [Their shields]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 4:18 (#3)

מָגִנֶּיהָ

“Her shields”

Here, **shields** represents “rulers” or “leaders” who are supposed to be protecting the people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Her rulers]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 4:18 (#4)

אָהֲבִ֥ו הֵבֵֽבוּ

“have loved, loved”

The speaker is repeating forms of the verb **loved** in order to intensify his expression of the idea that it conveys. If your language can repeat words for intensification, it would be appropriate to do that here in your translation. If not, your language may have another way of expressing the intensification. Alternate translation: [have passionately loved]

See: Reduplication

Hosea 4:18 (#5)

קָלֹֽנּוֹן

“dishonor”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **dishonor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [disgraceful things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 4:19 (#1)

צָרַ֤ר רוּחַ֙ אוֹתָ֣הּ בִּכְנָפֶ֔יהָ

“A wind has wrapped her in its wings”

The speaker is speaking of the people being taken into exile by enemies as if the enemies were a **wind** that had wings that had blown them away. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [An enemy has suddenly taken them away]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 4:19 (#2)

וְיֵבֹ֖שׁוּ

“and they will have shame”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **shame**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and they will be disgraced]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea - Chapter 5 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

1. Yahweh calls Israel's leaders to account (1–7)
2. Judgment comes upon Israel and Judah (8–14)
3. Yahweh withdraws until his people seek him (15)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Idolatry as prostitution
Hosea describes Israel's worship of other gods as sexual unfaithfulness. The "spirit of prostitutions" (verse 4) portrays idolatry as a deep compulsion which is preventing their return to Yahweh.

Hosea 5:1 (#1)

בֵּ֣ית יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

"house of Israel"

Here, **house** means all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So the **house of Israel** figuratively means all the people descended from the patriarch Jacob, who was also known as Israel. Alternate translation: [you people of Israel]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 5:1 (#2)

הַאֲזִ֖ינוּ

"and give ear"

The speaker is using the phrase **give ear** to mean "listen to me." If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly as in the UST.

See: Metonymy

Hosea 5:1 (#3)

וּבֵ֥ית הַמֶּ֖לֶךְ

"house of the king"

Here, **house of the king** means all the people who were considered a part of the king's court as if they were one household living together. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [all you who serve in the king's court]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 5:1 (#4)

לָכֶ֣ם הַמִּשְׁפָּ֔ט

"the judgment {is} for you"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgment**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you will be judged]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 5:1 (#5)

פַּ֖חַ

"a snare"

The speaker is speaking of the leaders trying to get the people to sin as if they were setting a trap or a **snare** to catch animals. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a cause of sin]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 5:1 (#6)

וְרֶ֥שֶׁת פְּרוּשָׂ֖ה עַל־תָּבֽוֹר

"and a net spread over Tabor"

The speaker is speaking as if the leaders were a trap or **a net spread** to catch prey. He means that they have trapped the people in sin. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and you have schemed to make the people sin at Tabor]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 5:2 (#1)

וְשַׁחֲטָ֥ה שָׂטִ֖ים הֶעְמִֽיקוּ

"And the revolters have made the slaughter deep"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **slaughter**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [And the revolters have slaughtered many people]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 5:2 (#2)

וַאֲנִי מוּסָר לְכֻלָּם

“but I {will} be a reproof to all of them”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **reproof**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [but I will rebuke all of them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 5:3 (#1)

יָדַעְתִּי אֶפְרַיִם

“I know Ephraim”

The speaker is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I know** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that he is the one who knows all about them. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [indeed know Ephraim]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 5:3 (#2)

אֶפְרַיִם

“Ephraim”

The speaker is using the tribe of **Ephraim**, to represent the people of the northern kingdom of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [you people of the northern kingdom of Israel]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 5:3 (#3)

וְיִשְׂרָאֵל לֹא־נִכְחַד מִמֶּנִּי

“and Israel is not hidden from me”

The expression **is not hidden** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and I see Israel clearly]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 5:3 (#4)

וְיִשְׂרָאֵל לֹא־נִכְחַד מִמֶּנִּי

“and Israel is not hidden from me”

The speaker is emphasizing a positive meaning by using a negative word, **not**, together with a mild expression that is the opposite of the intended meaning. If it would be helpful in your language, you could emphasize the positive meaning in a strong way. Alternate translation: [and everything about Israel is fully revealed to me]

See: Litotes

Hosea 5:3 (#5)

נִטְמָא יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Israel is defiled”

The expression **is defiled** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Israel has defiled itself]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 5:4 (#1)

לֹא יִתְּנוּ֙ מַעַלְלֵיהֶ֔ם

“Their deeds will not allow {them”

The speaker is speaking of their **deeds** as if they were a living thing that could prevent people from doing something. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Because of what they have done, they are not able]

See: Personification

Hosea 5:4 (#2)

לָשׁוּב אֶל־אֱלֹהֵיהֶם

“to return to their God”

The speaker is speaking as if repenting and worshiping God again were to physically change directions and **return** to him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [to repent and worship their God again]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 5:4 (#3)

רוּחַ זְנוּנִים֙

“a spirit of prostitutions”

The phrase **a spirit of prostitutions** could mean: (1) the prevailing attitude in Israel was in favor of prosti-

tution. Alternate translation: [an attitude of unfaithfulness] or (2) an evil spirit is causing the people to participate in prostitution. Alternate translation: [an evil spirit promoting prostitution]

See: Possession

Hosea 5:5 (#1)

וְעָנְתָה גְאוֹן־יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּפָנָיו

“And the pride of Israel testifies against his face”

The speaker is speaking of **pride** as if it were a living thing that could **testify** against someone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And Israel’s pride makes his guilt evident]

See: Personification

Hosea 5:5 (#2)

גְאוֹן

“the pride of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **pride**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the proud behavior of]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 5:5 (#3)

בְּפָנָיו

“against his face”

Here, **his face** represents his presence or himself. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [against him]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 5:5 (#4)

יִכָּשְׁלוּ בַעֲוֹנָם

“will stumble in their sin”

The speaker is speaking of the people’s moral failure as if they actually **stumble** as they walk. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly as modeled in the UST.

See: Metaphor

Hosea 5:5 (#5)

בַּעֲוֹנָם

“in their sin”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **sin**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from their sinful actions]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 5:6 (#1)

לְבַקֵּשׁ אֶת־יְהוָה וְלֹא יִמְצָאוּ

“to seek Yahweh, but they will not find {him”

The speaker is speaking of the people trying to appease Yahweh as if they went to **seek** but could not **find** him. He means that the people will pray and make sacrifices to Yahweh but he will not accept it because of their sin. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly as modeled in the UST.

Hosea 5:6 (#2)

חָלַץ מֵהֶם

“He has withdrawn from them”

Yahweh is speaking as if his refusal to accept the people’s worship were his having physically **withdrawn** from them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He refuses to respond to them]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 5:7 (#1)

בָּנִים זָרִים יָלָדוּ

“they have borne strange children”

The speaker is speaking of the people’s failure to keep their covenant with Yahweh as if it had resulted in their having **borne strange children**, that is, producing a generation that does not belong to him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [their descendants do not belong to Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 5:7 (#2)

יֹאכְלֵם

“he will devour them”

The speaker is speaking as if Yahweh would **devour** the people like a predator consuming its prey. Your

language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he will destroy them]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 5:7 (#3)

אֶת־חֶלְקֵיהֶם

“with their portions”

The phrase **their portions** could refer to: (1) the people’s portion of the sacrifice that they offer as modeled in the UST, or (2) it could refer to the portion of the land that Yahweh had allotted to them. Alternate translation: [with their portions of the land]

Hosea 5:8 (#1)

שׁוֹפָר

“a shofar”

A **shofar** is a kind of musical instrument made from a ram’s horn. If your readers would not be familiar with what a **shofar** is, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [a ram’s horn]

See: Translate Unknowns

Hosea 5:8 (#2)

בְּבֵית אָוֶן

“at Beth Aven”

The speaker is calling the city of Bethel **Beth Aven** as a derogatory wordplay because of all the idol worship there. “Bethel” means “house of God” and “Beth Aven” means “house of evil.”

See: How to Translate Names

Hosea 5:8 (#3)

אַחֲרֶיךָ בִּנְיָמִין

“After you, Benjamin”

The speaker is using **After you** as a common expression of the culture to mean “lead the way.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Lead the way, Benjamin]

See: Idiom

Hosea 5:8 (#4)

בִּנְיָמִין

“Benjamin”

The speaker is using **Benjamin**, to represent the advance warriors of the southern kingdom. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [warriors of Benjamin]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 5:9 (#1)

לְשַׁמָּה

“a desolation”

If your language does not use abstract noun for the idea of **desolation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [a wasteland]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 5:9 (#2)

תּוֹכֵחָה

“rebuke”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **rebuke**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [being rebuked]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 5:10 (#1)

כְּמַסִּיגֵי גְּבוּל

“like the movers of a boundary”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the movers of a boundary** dishonestly steal land that belongs to others by changing the boundaries, so the leaders or **princes of Judah** have violated what rightfully belongs to others. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like those who dishonestly steal land that belongs to others]

See: Simile

Hosea 5:10 (#2)

עֲלֵיהֶם אֶשְׁפֹּךְ כַּמַּיִם עֶבְרָתִי

“I will pour out my wrath on them like water”

The speaker is speaking of punishing them as if his anger were a liquid that he could **pour out** like water. Your language may have a comparable expression that

you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will punish them in my anger]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 5:10 (#3)

עֶבְרָתִי

“my wrath”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wrath**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [my great anger]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 5:11 (#1)

עָשׁוּק אֶפְרַיִם

“Ephraim is oppressed”

The expression **is oppressed, crushed** use passive verbal forms. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I will oppress and crush Ephraim]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 5:11 (#2)

עָשׁוּק & רְצוּץ

“is oppressed, crushed”

The terms **oppressed** and **crushed** mean similar things. The speaker is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [severely oppressed]

See: Doublet

Hosea 5:11 (#3)

מִשְׁפָּט

“in} judgment”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgment**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in the judging of him]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 5:11 (#4)

הָלַךְ אַחֲרֵי־צָו

“he walked after nonsense”

The speaker is speaking as if Ephraim’s devotion to worthless idols were physically having **walked after** them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he devoted himself to what is worthless]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 5:12 (#1)

כָּעָשׁ לְאֶפְרָיִם

“like a moth to Ephraim”

The point of this comparison is that just as a **moth** slowly destroys clothing by eating through it, so Yahweh will slowly destroy Ephraim. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [the one who destroys Ephraim just as a moth destroys clothing]

See: Simile

Hosea 5:12 (#2)

וְכָרָקָב לְבֵית יְהוּדָה

“and like rot to the house of Judah”

The point of this comparison is that just as **rot** slowly destroys wood by decaying it, so Yahweh will slowly destroy the **house of Judah**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and I will slowly destroy the house of Judah just as rot destroys wood]

See: Simile

Hosea 5:12 (#3)

לְבֵית יְהוּדָה

“to the house of Judah”

Here, **house** means all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **the house of Judah** figuratively means all the people descended from the patriarch Judah, who was also known as Israel. Alternate translation: [to the tribe of Judah]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 5:13 (#1)

אֶת־חֳלְיוֹ

“his sickness”

The speaker is speaking as if Ephraim’s national weakness were a physical **sickness**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your

translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [how weak his nation was]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 5:13 (#2)

אֶת־מְזֹרֹו

“his wound”

The speaker is speaking as if Judah’s national suffering were a physical **wound**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [how distressed his people were]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 5:13 (#3)

וַיֵּ֤לֶךְ אֶפְרַיִם֙ אֶל־אַשּׁ֔וּר וַיִּשְׁלַ֖ח אֶל־מֶ֥לֶךְ יָרֵֽב

“then Ephraim went to Assyria and sent to the king of Yareb”

These two clauses mean basically the same thing since **Yareb** was another name for **Assyria**. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them into a single phrase as in the UST. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word other than “and” that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [then Ephraim went to Assyria, indeed, he sent to the king of Yareb]

See: Parallelism

Hosea 5:13 (#4)

וְה֣וּא לֹֽא יוּכַ֔לל לִרְפֹּ֥א לָכֶ֖ם

“But he, he is not able to heal you”

The speaker is stating the pronoun **he** separately, even though the verb translated as **he is not able** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that the king of Assyria is definitely not the one who can help them. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [But the king of Assyria is certainly not able to heal you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 5:13 (#5)

מֶ֥לֶךְ יָרֵֽב

“the king of Yareb”

The word **Yareb** represents the written Hebrew text both here and in 10:6. It may be an alternative name for the country of Assyria that is otherwise unknown. Scholars have proposed, however, that a word that shares most of these letters that means “great” would make better sense and may have been original. You may want to follow the major translation in your area. Alternate translation: [the great king]

See: Alternative Readings

Hosea 5:14 (#1)

כַּשַּׁ֣חַל לְאֶפְרַ֗יִם וְכַכְּפִ֛יר לְבֵ֥ית

“like a lion to Ephraim, and like a young lion to the house of”

The point of this comparison is that just as a **lion** is powerful and tears apart its prey, so Yahweh will powerfully destroy the people of Ephraim and Judah. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like a lion that will tear apart both Ephraim and]

See: Simile

Hosea 5:14 (#2)

אֲנִ֥י אֲנִ֛י אֶטְרֹ֖ף וְאֵלֵֽךְ

“I, I, I will tear and go away”

The speaker is repeating the pronoun **I** separately two times, even though the verb translated as **I will tear** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Yahweh himself is the one doing this. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [I, Yahweh, myself will tear and go away]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 5:14 (#3)

אֶטְרֹ֖ף וְאֵלֵֽךְ

“I will tear and go away”

The speaker is speaking of their enemies attacking them as if Yahweh had allowed a predatory animal to **tear** apart its prey and then **go away** and leave them to themselves. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will allow their enemies to attack them and will leave them undefended]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 5:14 (#4)

אֶשָּׂא

“I will carry off”

The speaker is speaking of Yahweh causing their enemies to take them into exile as if they were a predatory animal able to **carry off** its prey. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will allow them to be taken into exile in another land]

Hosea 5:15 (#1)

אָשׁוּבָה אֶל־מְקוֹמִי

“I shall return to my place”

The speaker is speaking as if Yahweh had a physical **place** to which he would **return**, meaning that he will withdraw his presence from the people. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I shall withdraw my presence from them]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 5:15 (#2)

יֶאְשְׁמוּ

“they acknowledge their guilt”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **guilt**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [they acknowledge that they have sinned]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 5:15 (#3)

וּבְקַשְׁנִי פָּנָי

“and seek my face”

Here the speaker is speaking of Yahweh as if he were a person located in a specific place that someone would need to **seek**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and want to be reconciled to me again]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 5:15 (#4)

בַּצַּר לָהֶם

“In their distress”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **distress**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [When they are suffering]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 5:15 (#5)

פָּנָי

“my face”

Here, **my face** represents Yahweh’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [my presence]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 5:15 (#6)

יֶאְשְׁמוּ

“they acknowledge their guilt”

The verb translated as **acknowledge their guilt** could also mean, “bear their guilt.” Alternate translation: [they bear their guilt] or [they have been punished for their guilt]

See: Alternative Readings

Hosea - Chapter 6 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

1. A call to return to Yahweh (1–3)
2. Yahweh rebukes Israel’s shallow repentance (4–6)
3. Israel’s persistent sin and covenant unfaithfulness (7–11)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Covenant faithfulness versus sacrifice
Yahweh declares he desires covenant faithfulness and knowledge of God rather than sacrifices and burnt offerings (v. 6), prioritizing ongoing relational loyalty over ritual acts.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Unattributed speaker transitions
The chapter shifts speakers without quotation margins: the people speak in verses 1–3, then Yahweh responds beginning in verse 4. Translators may need to clarify who is speaking.

Hosea 6:1 (#1)

לְכוּ֙ וְנָשׁ֣וּבָה אֶל־יְהוָ֔ה כִּֽי־הֽוּא֙ טָרָ֣ף וְיִרְפָּאֵ֔נוּ יַ֥ךְ וְיַחְבְּשֵׁ֖נוּ

“Come, and let us return to Yahweh, for he, he has torn, and he will heal us; he struck, and he will bind us up”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [He, he has torn, and he will heal us; he struck, and he will bind us up. Therefore, come, and let us return to Yahweh]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Hosea 6:1 (#2)

לְכוּ֙ וְנָשׁ֣וּבָה אֶל־יְהוָ֔ה

“Come, and let us return to Yahweh”

This is the beginning of what the people said. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote of the people as modeled in the UST.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Hosea 6:1 (#3)

לְכוּ֙ וְנָשׁ֣וּבָה אֶל־יְהוָ֔ה

“Come, and let us return to Yahweh”

The word translated as **Come** is an imperative, but it communicates an exhortation to mutual action rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate an exhortation for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates an exhortation. Alternate translation: [Let us come and return to Yahweh]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Hosea 6:1 (#4)

וְנָשׁ֣וּבָה אֶל־יְהוָ֔ה

“and let us return to Yahweh”

The people are speaking of renewing their loyalty to Yahweh as if they were going to physically **return** to him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and let us renew our loyalty to Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 6:1 (#5)

כִּֽי־הֽוּא֙ טָרָ֣ף וְיִרְפָּאֵ֔נוּ יַ֥ךְ וְיַחְבְּשֵׁ֖נוּ

“for he, he has torn, and he will heal us; he struck, and he will bind us up”

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [for even though he has wounded us, he will certainly heal us]

See: Parallelism

Hosea 6:1 (#6)

כִּֽי־הֽוּא֙ טָרָ֣ף

“for he, he has torn”

The people are stating the pronoun **he** separately, even though the verb translated as **he has torn** already includes this meaning. They are doing that to emphasize that Yahweh is the one who is doing this. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [for Yahweh himself has torn]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 6:1 (#7)

טָרָ֣ף וְיִרְפָּאֵ֔נוּ

“he has torn, and he will heal us”

The people are speaking of Yahweh’s discipline as if he were a predator that had **torn** them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he has injured us, and he will heal us]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 6:2 (#1)

יְחַיֵּ֣ינוּ

“He will revive us”

The people are speaking of their national restoration as if Yahweh would bring them back from death by **reviving** them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He will restore our nation]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 6:2 (#2)

מִיֹּמָיִם בַּיּוֹם֙ הַשְּׁלִישִׁ֔י

“after two days; on the third day”

The people are using **after two days** and **on the third day** as a common expression of the culture to mean “in a very short time.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in a very short time; soon]

See: Idiom

Hosea 6:2 (#3)

יְקִמֵּ֑נוּ

“he will raise us up”

The people are speaking of their national restoration as if Yahweh would lift them up from the ground and physically **raise** them up. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he will make us well again]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 6:2 (#4)

וְנִחְיֶ֖ה לְפָנָֽיו

“and we will live to his face”

Here, **his face** represents Yahweh’s presence. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and we will live in his presence]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 6:3 (#1)

וְיָבֹ֤וא כַגֶּ֙שֶׁם֙ לָ֔נוּ

“and he will come like the rain to us”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the rain** refreshes and nourishes the land, so Yahweh will refresh and restore his people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and he will come and refresh and restore us]

See: Simile

Hosea 6:3 (#2)

כְּמַלְקֹ֖וש יוֹרֶ֥ה אָֽרֶץ

“like the latter rain {that} waters the land”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the latter rain** gives life to the land by watering it, so Yahweh will give life and blessing to his people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [to give us life, just as the latter rain waters the land]

See: Simile

Hosea 6:3 (#3)

כְּשַׁ֤חַר נָכֹ֙ון מֹוצָאֹ֔ו

“Like the dawn, {his} going forth is established”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the dawn** will certainly come each day, so Yahweh’s **going forth** will certainly happen. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [He is as certain to go forth as the dawn is to come]

See: Simile

Hosea 6:3 (#4)

נָכֹ֙ון מֹוצָאֹ֔ו

“his} going forth is established”

The expression **is established** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [he will certainly go forth]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 6:4 (#1)

מָֽה־אֶֽעֱשֶׂה־לְּךָ֥ אֶפְרַ֖יִם

“What shall I do for you, Ephraim”

This is the beginning of what Yahweh said. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote of Yahweh as modeled in the UST.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Hosea 6:4 (#2)

מָֽה־אֶֽעֱשֶׂה־לְּךָ֥ אֶפְרַ֖יִם

“What shall I do for you, Ephraim”

Yahweh is using the question form to express his exasperation with Ephraim. If a speaker of your language

would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [There is nothing more I can do for you, Ephraim!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Hosea 6:4 (#3)

מָֽה אֶֽעֱשֶׂה־לְּךָ֣ יְהוּדָ֑ה

“What shall I do for you, Judah”

Yahweh is using the question form to express his exasperation with Judah. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I have exhausted what I can do for you, Judah!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Hosea 6:4 (#4)

וְחַסְדְּכֶ֖ם כֶּֽעָנָ֣ן־בֹּ֑קֶר

“And your covenant faithfulness {is} like a cloud of the morning”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a cloud of the morning** quickly disappears, so the people’s **covenant faithfulness** quickly fades. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [And your covenant faithfulness is like a cloud of the morning that quickly disappears]

See: Simile

Hosea 6:4 (#5)

וְחַסְדְּכֶ֖ם

“And your covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [And the way you faithfully keep your covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 6:4 (#6)

וְכַטַּ֥ל מַשְׁכִּ֖ים הֹלֵֽךְ

“and like the dew rising early {and} going {away”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the dew** disappears early in the morning, so the people’s **covenant faithfulness** quickly vanishes. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and like the dew that vanishes early in the morning]

See: Simile

Hosea 6:5 (#1)

חָצַ֙בְתִּי֙ בַּנְּבִיאִ֔ים

“I have hewn {them} by the prophets”

Yahweh is speaking of his discipline of the people through the prophets as if he had **hewn** them like a stonecutter chiseling rock. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have corrected them through the prophets]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 6:5 (#2)

חָצַ֙בְתִּי֙ בַּנְּבִיאִ֔ים

“I have hewn {them} by the prophets”

The pronoun **them** refers to the people of Israel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [I have hewn the people of Israel by the prophets]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 6:5 (#3)

הָרַ֣גְתִּ֔ים בְּאִמְרֵי־פִ֑י

“I have killed them by the words of my mouth”

Yahweh is speaking of the destructive power of his prophetic messages as if his words had **killed** the people. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have brought destruction on them through the words of my mouth]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 6:5 (#4)

בְּאִמְרֵי־פִ֑י

“by the words of my mouth”

Here, **my mouth** represents Yahweh’s speech. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [by what I said]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 6:5 (#5)

וּמִשְׁפָּטֶיךָ

“and your judgments”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgments**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and my rulings against you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 6:5 (#6)

וּמִשְׁפָּטֶיךָ אוֹר יֵצֵא

“and your judgments {are as} light {that} goes forth”

The point of this comparison is that just as **light** goes forth with certainty, so **your judgments** go forth with certainty. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and your judgments will certainly go forth]

See: Simile

Hosea 6:5 (#7)

וּמִשְׁפָּטֶיךָ אוֹר יֵצֵא

“and your judgments {are as} light {that} goes forth”

The phrase **and your judgments are as light that goes forth** is an attempt to translate the written Hebrew text. This reading, however, does not seem to make sense. You may want to follow an alternative reading from some ancient Greek and Aramaic translations. The Hebrew would also say this by moving one letter from the end of one word to the beginning of the next word. The UST follows that reading. Alternate translation: [and my judgment goes forth as light]

See: Alternative Readings

Hosea 6:6 (#1)

וְדַעַת אֱלֹהִים

“and the knowledge of God”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **knowledge**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and knowing God]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 6:6 (#2)

חֶסֶד

“covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that you faithfully keep your covenant promises]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 6:7 (#1)

וְהֵמָּה כְּאָדָם עָבְרוּ בְרִית

“But they, like Adam, they transgressed {the} covenant”

The point of this comparison is that just as **Adam** disobeyed God’s command, so the people of Israel have **transgressed** God’s covenant. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [But just as Adam disobeyed God, they transgressed the covenant]

See: Simile

Hosea 6:7 (#2)

וְהֵמָּה כְּאָדָם עָבְרוּ

“But they, like Adam, they transgressed”

The speaker is stating the pronoun **they** separately, even though the verb translated as **they transgressed** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it was the people of Israel who did the transgressing. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [But it was the people themselves who, like Adam, transgressed]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 6:8 (#1)

פֹּעֲלֵי אָוֶן

“workers of evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [people doing bad things]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 6:8 (#2)

עֲקֻבָּה מִדָּם

“tracked with blood”

Here the speaker is speaking how prevalent murder is in this city as if the streets were **tracked with blood** of those who have been murdered. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [full of violence and murder]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 6:9 (#1)

וּכְחַכֵּי֙ אִ֣ישׁ גְּדוּדִ֔ים

“And, as lying in wait for a man, {are} bands”

The point of this comparison is that just as **bands** of robbers lie in wait to ambush a traveler, so a **company of priests** lies in wait to attack people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [And just as bands of robbers lie in wait to ambush a man, so also]

See: Simile

Hosea 6:9 (#2)

זִמָּ֖ה

“villainy”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **villainy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [wicked deeds]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 6:10 (#1)

זְנוּנֹ֥ות

“prostitution”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **prostitution**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [acting as a prostitute]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 6:10 (#2)

בְּבֵ֣יתְ יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל

“In the house of Israel”

Here, **house** means all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **the house of Israel** figuratively means all the people descended from the patriarch Jacob, who was also known as Israel. Alternate translation: [Among the Israelites]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 6:10 (#3)

שערירה

“the horrible”

The speaker is using the adjective **horrible** as a noun to refer to a certain kind of thing. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [many horrible things]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Hosea 6:10 (#4)

נִטְמָ֖א יִשְׂרָאֵֽל

“Israel is defiled”

The expression **is defiled** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Israel defiled itself]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 6:11 (#1)

שָׁ֥שָׂת קָצִ֖יר לָֽךְ

“he has appointed a harvest for you”

Yahweh is speaking of the coming judgment as if it were a **harvest** that he has appointed. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a time of judgment has been appointed for you]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 6:11 (#2)

בְּשׁוּבִ֥י שְׁבִ֖ות עַמִּֽי

“When I restore the fortunes of my people”

Yahweh is using **restore the fortunes** as a common expression of the culture to mean “bring about national renewal and prosperity.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [When I bring about renewal and prosperity for my people]

See: Idiom

Hosea 6:11 (#3)

שָׁ֥שָׂת קָצִ֖יר לָֽךְ

“he has appointed a harvest for you”

Yahweh is speaking of himself in the third person as **he**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person as modeled in the UST.

See: First, Second or Third Person

Hosea - Chapter 7 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter continues using poetic forms to speak of Yahweh’s anger over the sin of the people. Yahweh exposes Israel’s sin and misplaced trust.

1. Israel’s wickedness is fully revealed (1–7)
2. Israel is weakened by compromise and spiritual decline (8–10)
3. Israel seeks help everywhere but Yahweh (11–16)

Translation Issues in This Chapter

“oven” as an extended metaphor

In verses 4–7, conspirators are compared to a baker’s oven burning through the night, portraying their ambition as all-consuming.

Ephraim

“Ephraim” and “Israel” are used interchangeably to represents the northern kingdom throughout this chapter.

Hosea 7:1 (#1)

כְּרָפְאִ֣י לְיִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“when I would heal Israel”

Yahweh is using the clause **when I would heal Israel** to describe something that was ongoing. This indicates that it is a continuing thought from the previous verse in the last chapter. Connect this clause in a way that makes it clear in your language that this clause is continuing a previous statement. Alternate translation: [or whenever I try to heal Israel]

See: Connect — Background Information

Hosea 7:1 (#2)

כְּרָפְאִ֣י לְיִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“when I would heal Israel”

Here Yahweh is speaking of desiring the spiritual restoration of Israel as if he were wanting to **heal** a sick person. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when I would make Israel well spiritually]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 7:1 (#3)

וְנִגְלָ֣ה עֲוֹ֤ן אֶפְרַיִם֙

“then the iniquity of Ephraim is uncovered”

Here Yahweh is speaking of seeing their sin as if their **iniquity** were an object that had been hidden but is now **uncovered**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [then the iniquity of Ephraim can be clear seen]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 7:1 (#4)

אֶפְרַיִם֙

“Ephraim”

Here and throughout the chapter, **Ephraim** refers to the people or leaders of Ephraim which represents the northern kingdom of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the people of the northern kingdom]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 7:1 (#5)

וְנִגְלָ֣ה עֲוֹ֤ן אֶפְרַיִם֙

“then the iniquity of Ephraim is uncovered”

The expression **is uncovered** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh. Alternate translation: [then I uncover the iniquity of Ephraim]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 7:1 (#6)

שֹׁ֔מְרוֹן

“falsehood”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **falsehood**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what is false]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 7:1 (#7)

וְרָעִ֖ות שֹׁמְרֽוֹן

“and the evils of Samaria”

Yahweh is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. The verb “is uncovered” from the previous clause is implied here as well. Alternate translation: [and the evils of Samaria are uncovered]

See: Ellipsis

Hosea 7:1 (#8)

וְרָעֹ֥ות שֹׁמְרֹ֑ון

“and the evils of Samaria”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evils**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and all the bad things the Samaritans do]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 7:1 (#9)

עֲוֹ֣ן

“the iniquity of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the sinful behavior of]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 7:2 (#1)

רָעָתָ֖ם

“their evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the evil things they have done]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 7:2 (#2)

סְבָבֻ֥ום מַעַלֵ֖יהֶם

“their deeds surround them”

Yahweh is speaking of **their deeds** as if they were living things that could **surround** the people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they cannot escape what they have done]

See: Personification

Hosea 7:2 (#3)

וּבַל־יֹ֥אמְרוּ֙ לִלְבָבָ֔ם

“And they do not say to their heart”

Yahweh is using **say to their heart** as a common expression of the culture to mean “consider” or “reflect on something inwardly.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And they do not consider]

See: Idiom

Hosea 7:2 (#4)

נֶגְדָּ֥ פָּנַ֖י הָיֽוּ

“they are before my face”

Here, **before my face** represents Yahweh’s sight or awareness. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [they are always in my sight]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 7:3 (#1)

בְּרָעָתָ֖ם

“By their evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [By their wicked actions]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 7:3 (#2)

וּבְכַחֲשֵׁיהֶ֖ם שָׂרִֽים

“and by their lies, {the} princes”

Yahweh is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and by their lies, they make the princes glad]

See: Ellipsis

Hosea 7:4 (#1)

כֻּלָּ֣ם מְנָאֲפִ֔ים כְּמֹ֥ו תַנּ֖וּר בֹּעֵ֣רָה מֵאֹפֶ֑ה יִשְׁבְּתֹ֥ות מֵעִֽיר

“All of them {are} adulterers, like an oven burning from a baker; he ceases from awakening {it”

These phrases represent the written Hebrew text. Scholars have proposed, however, that scribes divided the words incorrectly, making the sentence awkward and ungrammatical. They have proposed the following reading as original. You may want to follow the major translation in your area. Alternate translation: [All of them are adulterers; like a burning oven are they; a baker ceases from awakening it]

See: Alternative Readings

Hosea 7:4 (#2)

יִשְׁבַּבְּוֹת מֵעִֽיר

“he ceases from awakening {it”

The pronoun **he** refers to the baker. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the baker ceases from awakening {it}]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 7:4 (#3)

כְּמֹ֣ו תַנּ֗וּר בֹּעֵרָ֛ה מֵאֹפֶ֖ה

“like an oven burning from a baker”

The point of this comparison is that just as **an oven burning from a baker** is intensely hot, so the people’s passion for evil is intense and consuming. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [their passion for evil is like an oven that a baker has heated until it is intensely hot and consuming]

See: Simile

Hosea 7:5 (#1)

יֹ֣ום מַלְכֵּ֔נוּ

“On} the day of our king”

Yahweh is using **the day of our king** as a common expression of the culture to mean the occasion when the king’s festival is celebrated. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [On the royal holiday]

See: Idiom

Hosea 7:5 (#2)

מַלְכֵּ֔נוּ

“our king”

The pronoun **our** refers to the people of Israel. Here Yahweh is quoting their perspective as they speak of their king. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the king of Israel]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 7:5 (#3)

מָשַׁ֥ךְ יָדֹ֖ו אֶת־לֹצְצִֽים

“He extended his hand with the mockers”

Yahweh is using **extended his hand with** as a common expression of the culture to mean “made an agreement with” or “allied himself with.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He conspires with the mockers]

See: Idiom

Hosea 7:6 (#1)

לִבָּ֑ם

“their heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s desires and intentions exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [their desires]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 7:6 (#2)

כַּתַּנּ֖וּר

“like an oven”

The point of this comparison is that just as **an oven** is intensely hot inside, so the hearts of the conspirators burn with murderous desire as they lie in ambush. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [their murderous desire is as intensely hot as an oven]

See: Simile

Hosea 7:6 (#3)

כָּל־הַלַּ֣יְלָה יָשֵׁ֔ן אֹפֵ֖הֶם בֹּ֣קֶר הוּא֙ בֹּעֵ֣ר כְּאֵ֔שׁ לֶֽהָבָֽה

“All the night their baker {is} asleep; {in} the morning it is burning like a fire of flame”

Here Yahweh is speaking as if the princes’ anger were a **fire** smoldering **all the night** as the **baker is asleep** that then intensifies in the morning. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Their anger smolders

all night, but in the morning it flares up] or [All night long, they remain angry; they become more angry in the morning]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 7:6 (#4)

הַהוּא בֹּעֵר כְּאֵשׁ לֶהָבָה

“it is burning like a fire of flame”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a fire of flame** blazes up intensely, so the conspirators’ anger suddenly erupts in the morning when they carry out their plot. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [their anger blazes up as intensely as a flame] or [their anger intensifies]

See: Simile

Hosea 7:7 (#1)

כֻּלָּם יֵחַמּוּ כַּתַּנּוּר

“All of them are hot like an oven”

The point of this comparison is that just as **an oven** is intensely hot, so the princes are intensely passionate in their desire to seize power. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [All of them burn with intense passion to seize power]

See: Simile

Hosea 7:7 (#2)

וְאָכְלוּ אֶת־שֹׁפְטֵיהֶם

“and they devour their judges”

Here Yahweh is speaking as if the conspirators literally **devour** their judges the way a person eats food. He means that they destroy their rulers. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and they destroy their leaders]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 7:7 (#3)

כָּל־מַלְכֵיהֶם נָפָלוּ

“All of their kings have fallen”

Here, **fallen** represents dying violently. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [All of their kings have died violent deaths]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 7:8 (#1)

אֶפְרַיִם הָיָה עֻגָּה בְּלִלָּי הֻפּוּכָה

“Ephraim is a bread cake & turned over”

Here Yahweh is speaking as if Ephraim were **a bread cake not turned over**, which is burned on one side and raw on the other. He means that Ephraim is ruined and useless because of being only partially committed. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Ephraim is ruined and useless because he is only partially committed]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 7:8 (#2)

בָּעַמִּים הוּא יִתְבּוֹלָלָל

“he mixes himself”

Here Yahweh is speaking of Ephraim, or the leaders of northern kingdom of Israel, forming alliances with foreign nations as if **Ephraim** were a substance that **mixes** into other substances. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [forms alliances with other nations]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 7:8 (#3)

בְּלִלָּי הֻפּוּכָה

“turned over”

The expression **not turned over** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [that no one has turned over]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 7:9 (#1)

אָכְלוּ זָרִים כֹּחוֹ

“Strangers have devoured his strength”

Here Yahweh is speaking of the Ephraim’s weakness as if the other nations had literally **devoured** his **strength** the way a person eats food. He means that foreign nations have used up and depleted their resources, leaving them weak and defenseless. Your

language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Foreign nations have left him weak and defenseless]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 7:9 (#2)

כֹּחוֹ

“his strength”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **strength**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [what his strenuous labor produced]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 7:9 (#3)

שֵׂיבָהּ זָרְקָה בּוֹ וְהוּא לֹא יָדָע

“gray hair is sprinkled on him, and he does not know {it”

Here Yahweh is speaking as if Ephraim were an aging person on whom **gray hair is sprinkled** without him knowing it. He means that the nation is declining but is unaware of it. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his power is fading away, and he is unaware of it]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 7:9 (#4)

שֵׂיבָהּ זָרְקָה בּוֹ

“gray hair is sprinkled on him”

The expression **is sprinkled** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [he has more and more gray hair]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 7:10 (#1)

וְעָנְתָה גְאוֹן־יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּפָנָיו

“And the pride of Israel testifies against his face”

Yahweh is speaking of **the pride of Israel** as if it were a living thing that **testifies** as a witness in court. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And the pride of Israel clearly reveals his guilt]

See: Personification

Hosea 7:10 (#2)

גְאוֹן־יִשְׂרָאֵל

“the pride of Israel”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **pride**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the proud way Israel acts]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 7:10 (#3)

בְּפָנָיו

“against his face”

Here, **his face** represents Israel, who is representing the people of the northern kingdom of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [against him]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 7:10 (#4)

יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵיהֶם

“Yahweh their God”

Yahweh is speaking of himself in the third person as **Yahweh, their God**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [me, their God]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Hosea 7:10 (#5)

אֱלֹהֵיהֶם

“their God”

Yahweh is not using this possessive form **their God** to indicate that the Israelites possess or control Yahweh but rather to emphasize that he is the God that the Israelites should worship. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the God who chose them]

See: Possession

Hosea 7:11 (#1)

וַיְהִי אֶפְרַיִם כְּיוֹנָה פוֹתָה אֵין לֵב

“And Ephraim has been like a dove, being silly, without heart”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a dove** can be easily deceived and lacks good judgment, so Ephraim foolishly goes back and forth seeking help from foreign nations. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [And Ephraim has been easily deceived and foolish, without good judgment]

See: Simile

Hosea 7:11 (#2)

אֵ֥ין לֵֽב

“without heart”

Here the **heart** represents where a person’s thoughts and understanding exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [without understanding]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 7:12 (#1)

אֶפְרֹ֣שׂ עֲלֵיהֶ֔ם רִשְׁתִּ֖י

“I will spread my net over them”

Here Yahweh is speaking as if he were a hunter who catches birds by spreading a **net** over them. He means that he will capture and restrain the people of Israel when they try to seek help from foreign nations. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will capture and restrain them]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 7:12 (#2)

כְּע֣וֹף הַשָּׁמַ֔יִם אוֹרִידֵ֑ם

“like birds of the heavens I will bring them down”

The point of this comparison is that just as **birds of the heavens** can be caught and brought down by a hunter’s net, so Yahweh will catch and bring down the people of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like a hunter who catches birds from the sky, I will bring them down]

See: Simile

Hosea 7:12 (#3)

כְּשֶׁשְׁמַ֖ע

“according to the report”

The phrase **according to the report** could refer to: (1) a report that a prophet delivered to the congregation about the people’s sin, or (2) a report that would come in the future, such as from the delegation to Egypt, that would cause Israel to rebel against Assyria and bring about the exile. Alternate translation: [when the report comes]

Hosea 7:13 (#1)

א֣וֹי לָהֶ֔ם

“Woe to them”

Yahweh is using the phrase **Woe to them** that expresses a strong feeling of grief and warning of coming judgment. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [How horrible it will be for them]

See: Exclamations

Hosea 7:13 (#2)

א֣וֹי לָהֶ֔ם כִּֽי־נָדְד֖וּ מִמֶּ֑נִּי

“Woe to them, for they have wandered from me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since they wandered from me, they will be punished]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Hosea 7:13 (#3)

נָדְד֖וּ מִמֶּ֑נִּי

“they have wandered from me”

Yahweh is speaking as if the Israelites had been walking with him but then **wandered** away to walk in a different direction from him. He means that they stopped living in the manner in which God wants people to live. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they no longer live as I want them to]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 7:13 (#4)

שֹׁ֣שַׁד לָהֶ֔ם כִּֽי־פָשְׁע֖וּ בִּ֑י

“Destruction to them, for they have revolted against me”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second

phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since they have revolted against me, destruction to them]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Hosea 7:13 (#5)

שֹׁ֥שַׁד לָהֶ֖ם

“Destruction to them”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **Destruction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [They will be destroyed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 7:13 (#6)

וְאָנֹכִ֖י אֶפְדֵּ֑ם

“And I, I would redeem them”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I would redeem** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that he is the only one who can redeem them. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [And I myself would redeem them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 7:13 (#7)

וְהֵ֥מָּה דִּבְּר֖וּ

“but they, they have spoken”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **they** separately, even though the verb translated as **they have spoken** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize what he had done in contrast to how they responded. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [but instead, they have spoken]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 7:14 (#1)

וְלֹא־זָעֲק֥וּ אֵלַ֖י בְּלִבָּֽם

“And they have not cried out to me in their heart”

Yahweh is using **in their heart** as a common expression of the culture to mean “sincerely” or “with genuine devotion.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And they have not cried out to me with genuine devotion]

See: Idiom

Hosea 7:14 (#2)

יִתְגּוֹרָ֑רוּ

“they sojourn”

The word translated as **they sojourn** represents the written Hebrew Masoretic text. But most modern translations follow an alternative reading from some other ancient Hebrew manuscripts and the ancient Greek translation, since it represents the pagan practice of shedding blood to encourage the fertility of the soil. The UST follows that reading. You may want to follow the major translation in your area. Alternate translation: [they cut themselves]

See: Textual Variants

Hosea 7:15 (#1)

וְאָנֹכִ֖י יִסַּ֣רְתִּי

“And I, I trained”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I trained** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize what he has done for them in contrast to how they respond. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that meaning here. Alternate translation: [Even though it was I who trained them]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 7:15 (#2)

וְאָנֹכִ֖י יִסַּ֣רְתִּי

“And I, I trained”

Yahweh is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context of the following phrase if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [And I, I trained them for battle]

See: Ellipsis

Hosea 7:15 (#3)

חִזַּקְתִּי זְרֹעֹתָם

“I strengthened their arms”

Here, **their arms** represents the military strength and capability of the people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [I strengthened them for battle]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 7:16 (#1)

יָשֻׁבוּ ׀ לֹא עָל

“They turn, {but} not upward”

Here Yahweh is speaking as if they were walking down a path and then change direction and **turn** but they were not turning **upward** toward him but away from him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They turn, but not toward me]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 7:16 (#2)

יִפְּלוּ בַחֶרֶב

“will fall by the sword”

Hosea is using **will fall by the sword** as a common expression of the culture to mean “will die in battle.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will be killed in battle] or [will die by the sword]

See: Idiom

Hosea 7:16 (#3)

מִזַּעַם

“from the indignation of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **indignation**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from my anger at]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 7:16 (#4)

הָיוּ כְּקֶשֶׁת רְמִיָּה

“they are like a deceitful bow”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a deceitful bow** is unreliable and does not shoot where the archer aims, so the people of Israel are unreliable and do not do what they should. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [they are unreliable, like a bow that sends its arrows off course]

See: Simile

Hosea 7:16 (#5)

לְשׁוֹנָם

“their tongue”

Here, **their tongue** represents what the people have said. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [their words]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 7:16 (#6)

לַעְגָּם

“is} their scorn”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **scorn**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [is how they will be scorned]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea - Chapter 8 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Yahweh accuses Israel of breaking the covenant, making idols, and seeking foreign alliances.

1. Israel has broken Yahweh’s covenant (1–6)
2. Israel reaps the consequences of its sin (7–10)
3. Israel’s worship and alliances bring judgment (11–14)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

“the calf of Samaria”

This chapter contains some references to the “calf of Samaria.” This most likely refers to an image that was set up by an earlier king of Israel. He did this in order to discourage his people from going to Jerusalem, which was part of the southern kingdom of Judah.

Hosea 8:1 (#1)

אֶל־חִכְּךָ שֹׁפָר

“To your palate, a shofar”

This is the beginning of a direct quotation by Yahweh to Hosea. In your translation, use a natural way of introducing direct quotations in your language as modeled in the UST.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Hosea 8:1 (#2)

אֶל־חִכְּךָ שֹׁפָר

“To your palate, a shofar”

Yahweh is using one part of the body, **palate**, to represent the whole mouth in the act of blowing a horn. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Put a shofar to your mouth]

See: Synecdoche

Hosea 8:1 (#3)

כַּנֶּשֶׁר עַל־בֵּית יְהוָה יַעַן עָבְרוּ בְרִיתִי וְעַל־תּוֹרָתִי פָּשָׁעוּ

“Like a vulture over the house of Yahweh, because they have transgressed my covenant and against my law they have rebelled”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases as modeled in the UST, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes.

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Hosea 8:1 (#4)

כַּנֶּשֶׁר עַל־בֵּית יְהוָה

“Like a vulture over the house of Yahweh”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a vulture** hovers over its prey waiting to devour it, so an enemy is ready and waiting to attack and defeat the people of Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [An enemy is waiting to devour the house of Yahweh]

See: Simile

Hosea 8:1 (#5)

בֵּית יְהוָה

“the house of Yahweh”

Here, **house** means all the people related to a particular person as if they were one household living together. So **the house of Yahweh** figuratively means all the people of Israel who Yahweh has chosen as his people. Alternate translation: [the people of Israel]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 8:1 (#6)

עָבְרוּ

“they have transgressed”

The pronoun **they** refers to the people of Israel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Israel has transgressed]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 8:1 (#7)

בְּרִיתִי

“my covenant”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **my covenant**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the agreement that I made with them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 8:2 (#1)

אֱלֹהַי יְדָעְנוּךָ יִשְׂרָאֵל

“My God, we, Israel, know you”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [and claim that they know me]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Hosea 8:2 (#2)

אֱלֹהַי

“My God”

The Israelites are using the possessive form **My God** to express their relationship with Yahweh as the God whom they worship, not to mean that they possess or control Yahweh. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Oh God whom we serve]

See: Possession

Hosea 8:3 (#1)

טֹוב

“the good”

Yahweh is using the adjective **good** as a noun to mean good things or what is right. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [what is morally good]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Hosea 8:4 (#1)

הֵ֣מָּה הִמְלִ֔יכוּ

“They, they have made kings”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **They** separately, even though the verb translated as **have made kings** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Israel acted on their own, without his approval. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [They themselves have made kings]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 8:4 (#2)

וְלֹ֣א יָדָ֑עְתִּי

“but I did not know”

Yahweh is using **I did not know** as a common expression of the culture to mean “I did not approve.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [without my approval]

See: Idiom

Hosea 8:4 (#3)

לְמַ֤עַן יִכָּרֵת֙

“so that he will be cut off”

The phrase **so that** indicates that what it describes, being **cut off**, is a result of what came before, the Israelites appointing their own kings and making their own idols. Use a connector in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [therefore he will be cut off]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Hosea 8:4 (#4)

יִכָּרֵת֙

“he will be cut off”

The pronoun in **he might be cut off** refers to Israel in verse 3. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Israel might be cut off] or [they will be cut off]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 8:4 (#5)

יִכָּרֵת֙

“he will be cut off”

Yahweh is speaking of Israel’s destruction as if it were something being **cut off**, like a branch severed from a tree. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he might be destroyed]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 8:4 (#6)

יִכָּרֵת֙

“he will be cut off”

The expression **he might be cut off** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I will destroy him]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 8:5 (#1)

זָנַ֤ח עֶגְלֵךְ֙

“He has rejected your calf”

Yahweh is speaking of himself in the third person as **He**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [I have rejected your calf]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Hosea 8:5 (#2)

שֹׁמְר֔וֹן

“Samaria”

Here, **Samaria** represents the people who live in the city of Samaria. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language as modeled in the UST.

See: Metonymy

Hosea 8:5 (#3)

חָרָ֥ה אַפִּ֖י בָּ֑ם

“My nose burns against them”

Yahweh is using **My nose burns against them** as a common expression of the culture to mean “I am very angry with them.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My anger burns against them]

See: Idiom

Hosea 8:5 (#4)

עַד־מָתַ֥י לֹ֖א יוּכְלֽוּ נִקָּיֹֽן

“Until when will they not attain innocence”

Yahweh is using the question form for the purpose of rebuking the people of Israel for their continued guilt. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [They will never attain innocence!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Hosea 8:5 (#5)

לֹ֖א יוּכְלֽוּ נִקָּיֹֽן

“will they not attain innocence”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **innocence**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [will they not become pure]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 8:6 (#1)

כִּֽי־מִיִּשְׂרָאֵ֣ל וְה֗וּא חָרָ֤שׁ עָשָׂ֙הוּ֙

“For from Israel {is} even this: a craftsman made it”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [After all, it was a craftsman from Israel that made it]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Hosea 8:7 (#1)

רֽוּחַ֙ יִזְרָ֔עוּ

“they sow wind”

Yahweh is speaking of the actions of the Israelites being completely futile as if they were farmers trying **sow wind**, or plant and grow more wind. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they do completely useless things]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 8:7 (#2)

וְסוּפָ֖תָה יִקְצֹֽרוּ

“and they will reap a whirlwind”

Yahweh is speaking of the outcome of the Israelites’ actions being devastating as if the harvest they are able to **reap** from sowing the wind, turns out to be **a whirlwind**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and all they will get is destruction]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 8:7 (#3)

קָמָ֣ה אֵין־לֹ֔ו צֶ֖מַח בְּלִ֣לִי יַעֲשֶׂה־קֶּ֑מַח

“standing grain on which there is no head. It will not yield flour”

Yahweh is speaking of Israel’s futile efforts with only destruction as an outcome as if the farmer ended up with nothing but barren stalks or **standing grain on which there is no head**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they will produce nothing useful with all their efforts]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 8:7 (#4)

זָרִ֖ים יִבְלָעֻֽהוּ

“strangers will swallow it up”

This line introduces the consequence of the possible condition proposed in the previous line. Yahweh is presenting the consequence of a possible condition that even if the stalks turn out to yield something,

then strangers will come and take it all, leaving them with nothing. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a condition that could happen. Alternate translation: [then strangers will swallow it up]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Hosea 8:7 (#5)

זָרִים יִבְלָעֻהוּ

“strangers will swallow it up”

Yahweh is speaking of foreigners taking advantage of everything Israel has worked for as if they were **strangers** who would come into a field and steal the produce and **swallow it up** or eat it all. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [other nations will just come and take it all]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 8:8 (#1)

נִבְלַע יִשְׂרָאֵל

“is swallowed up”

The expression **Israel is swallowed up** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [The strangers swallowed up Israel]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 8:8 (#2)

נִבְלַע יִשְׂרָאֵל

“is swallowed up”

Yahweh is speaking of Israel being absorbed by the nations as if it were being **swallowed up**, like food consumed by a person. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Israel has been completely assimilated]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 8:8 (#3)

כִּכְלִי אֵין־חֵפֶץ בּוֹ

“in which there is no delight”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a vessel in which there is no delight** is no longer special or distinctive, so Israel has become just like the other nations and is no longer distinct or special in any way. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [without distinction like a vessel that is no longer special]

See: Simile

Hosea 8:9 (#1)

כִּי־הֵהָמָּה

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: כִּי־הֵהָמָּה”

Here the word **For** introduces not a reason but an explanation. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [In fact, they]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Hosea 8:9 (#2)

הֵהָמָּה עָלְלוּ

“have gone up”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **they** separately, even though the verb translated as **they have gone** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that they are the ones acting like this. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [they themselves have gone up]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 8:9 (#3)

פֶּרֶא בּוֹדֵד לוֹ

“alone by itself”

Yahweh is speaking of the Israelites seeking help from Assyria as if they were **a wild donkey** who is **alone** and is looking for a mate. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly as modeled in the UST.

See: Metaphor

Hosea 8:9 (#4)

אֶפְרַיִם

“Ephraim”

Here, **Ephraim** represents the people of the northern kingdom of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or

plain language. Alternate translation: [The northern kingdom]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 8:9 (#5)

אֶפְרַיִם הִתְנַנּוּ אֲהָבִים

“Ephraim has hired lovers”

Yahweh is speaking of the foreign alliances the northern kingdom of Israel is seeking as if they were hiring **lovers**, as a prostitute seeks paying clients. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Ephraim has paid for other nations to support them]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 8:10 (#1)

אֲקַבְּצֵם

“I will gather them”

Yahweh is speaking of punishing Israel as if he were **gathering** them for punishment. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will gather them for judgement]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 8:10 (#2)

וַיָּחֵלּוּ מְעָט

“And they will begin {in} a little”

Yahweh is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [And they will begin to be gathered in a little while]

See: Ellipsis

Hosea 8:10 (#3)

מִמַּשָּׂא

“from the burden of”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **burden**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [from the oppression of]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 8:10 (#4)

מֶמֶלֶךְ שָׂרִים

“the king of princes”

Yahweh is using the possessive form to describe a **king** who rules over **princes** which refers to the king of Assyria (see Isaiah 10:8). If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the king over princes]

See: Possession

Hosea 8:12 (#1)

רבו תּוֹרָתִי

“myriads of my law”

Yahweh says **myriads of my law** as an extreme statement for emphasis. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [a huge number of copies of my law]

See: Hyperbole

Hosea 8:12 (#2)

כְּמוֹ־זָר נֶחְשָׁבוּ

“they would be regarded as something strange”

The expression **be regarded** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [he would still consider my law as something strange]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 8:13 (#1)

זִבְחֵי הַבְהָבַי יִזְבְּחוּ בָשָׂר וַיֹּאכֵלוּ

“The sacrifices of my gifts they sacrifice flesh and they eat”

Yahweh is using a construction in which a verb **sacrifice** and its object **sacrifices**, come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [They eat the flesh from the sacrifices they offer me as gifts]

See: Poetry

Hosea 8:13 (#2)

זִבְחֵי הַבְהָבַי

“The sacrifices of my gifts”

Yahweh is using the possessive form to describe **sacrifices** that consist of **gifts** offered to him. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [The offerings given as gifts to me]

See: Possession

Hosea 8:13 (#3)

יְהוָה לֹא רָצָם עַתָּה יִזְכֹּר

“Yahweh does not accept them. Now he will remember”

Yahweh is speaking of himself in the third person as **Yahweh** and**he**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [I do not accept them. Now I will remember]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Hosea 8:13 (#4)

עֲוֹנָם

“their iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the evil they have done]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 8:13 (#5)

חַטֹּאותָם

“their sins”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **sins**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the wrong things they did]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 8:13 (#6)

הֵמָּה מִצְרַיִם יָשׁוּבוּ

“They, they will return to Egypt”

Yahweh is speaking of Israel once again experiencing bondage under a foreign power as their ancestors did as if they **return to Egypt**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They will be enslaved by a foreign nation again]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 8:13 (#7)

הֵמָּה מִצְרַיִם יָשׁוּבוּ

“They, they will return to Egypt”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **They** separately, even though the verb translated as **they will return** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that Israel is choosing to return to bondage by their own actions. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [They themselves will return to Egypt]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 8:14 (#1)

וַיִּשְׁכַּח יִשְׂרָאֵל

“And Israel forgot”

Here Yahweh is speaking of Israel’s deliberate rejection of Yahweh as if they **forgot** him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And Israel rejected] or [And Israel abandoned]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 8:14 (#2)

וְשִׁלַּחְתִּי־אֵשׁ בְּעָרָיו וְאָכְלָה אַרְמְנֹתֶיהָ

“but I will send fire on his cities, and it will devour her citadels”

Yahweh is speaking of **fire** as if it were an animal that will **devour** its prey. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [it will burn down her citadels]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 8:14 (#3)

בְּעָרָיו וְאָכְלָה אַרְמְנֹתֶיהָ

“on his cities, and it will devour her citadels”

The pronoun **his** and the pronoun **her** both refer to Judah, who represents the people of the southern kingdom of Israel. It may be helpful to clarify this for

your readers. Alternate translation: [on Judah's cities and it will devour Judah's citadels]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea - Chapter 9 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Hosea 9 is prophetic judgment poetry in which Yahweh forbids Israel from celebrating and announces exile to Egypt and Assyria for idolatry.

1. Israel's joy will turn to exile and loss (1–6)
2. Israel rejects Yahweh's prophets and remains corrupt (7–9)
3. Yahweh removes blessing because of Israel's sin (10–17)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Fertility and barrenness as divine judgment

Yahweh reverses Israel's fruitfulness through miscarrying wombs, dry breasts, and dried roots. Agricultural metaphors (threshing floors, grapes, figs) tie barrenness directly to the people's unfaithfulness.

Hosea 9:1 (#1)

גִּילַל

"joy"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **joy**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [celebrate]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 9:1 (#2)

זָנִֽיתָ מֵעַ֣ל אֱלֹהֶ֔יךָ

"you have prostituted {yourself} from upon your God"

The speaker is speaking of Israel's unfaithfulness to Yahweh as if it were **prostitution**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have worshiped other gods instead of your God]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 9:1 (#3)

מֵעַ֣ל

"from upon"

The speaker is speaking of Israel's faithfulness to God as if it were a physical position, with Israel resting **upon** God, but now in their unfaithfulness, they have moved away **from upon** him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have prostituted yourself away from your God]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 9:1 (#4)

אֱלֹהֶ֔יךָ

"your God"

The speaker is not using this possessive form **your God** to indicate that the Israelites possess or control Yahweh. Rather he is using these words to emphasize the distinction between the gods of the nations and Israel's God. Alternate translation: [the God who has chosen you]

See: Possession

Hosea 9:1 (#5)

אָהַ֣בְתָּ אֶתְנָ֔ן

"You have loved prostitute-wages"

The speaker is speaking of the grain that Israel perceived as being a reward from the idols for their worship as if they were **prostitute-wages**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You have loved the rewards you perceived as being from your idols]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 9:2 (#1)

לֹ֥א יִרְעֵ֖ם

"will not feed them"

In verse 1, the speaker addresses Israel directly in the second person, but here he shifts to speaking about them in the third person as **them**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could continue addressing them in the second person. Alternate translation: [will not feed you]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Hosea 9:2 (#2)

יְכַחֲשׁ בָּהּ

"will fail"

The pronoun **her** refers to the nation of Israel who he was addressing directly in the previous verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers or continue to use the second person for consistency. Alternate translation: [will fail Israel] or [will fail you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 9:3 (#1)

בְּאֶ֣רֶץ יְהוָ֔ה

“in the land of Yahweh”

The speaker is using this possessive form to mean that the **land** belongs to **Yahweh**. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [in Yahweh’s land that he has given to them]

See: Possession

Hosea 9:4 (#1)

יִטַּמָּאוּ

“will be defiled”

The expression **will be defiled** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [will defile themselves]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 9:4 (#2)

כְּלַחְמָ֥ם אוֹנִ֖ים

“like bread of mourning”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **mourning**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [like bread eaten by those who grieve]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 9:4 (#3)

כְּלַחְמָ֥ם אוֹנִ֖ים

“like bread of mourning”

The point of this comparison is that just as **bread of mourning** is ritually unclean (see Deuteronomy 26:12–15) and makes anyone who eats it unacceptable to God, so **their sacrifices** will make them unacceptable to God. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like food that makes a person ritually unclean]

See: Simile

Hosea 9:4 (#4)

לַחְמָ֑ם

“their bread”

Hosea is using one kind of food, **their bread**, to mean food in general. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [their food]

See: Synecdoche

Hosea 9:4 (#5)

לֹ֥א יָבֹ֖וא בֵּ֥ית יְהוָֽה

“it will not enter the house of Yahweh”

The speaker is speaking of the temple of Yahweh as if it were a **house** in which he lived. Alternate translation: [it will not enter the temple of Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 9:5 (#1)

מַה־תַּעֲשׂ֥וּ לְי֖וֹם מוֹעֵ֑ד וּלְי֥וֹם חַג־יְהוָֽה

“What will you do for the day of meeting, and for the day of the festival of Yahweh”

The speaker is using the question form to emphasize that the people will not be able to do anything for these religious festivals and feasts because they will not be in their land and far from the temple. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [You will be able to do nothing for the day of meeting or for the day of the festival of Yahweh.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Hosea 9:5 (#2)

לְי֖וֹם מוֹעֵ֑ד

“for the day of meeting”

The speaker is using the possessive form to describe a **day** that is characterized by **meeting**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [for the day when you meet together]

See: Possession

Hosea 9:5 (#3)

וּלְי֥וֹם חַג־יְהוָֽה

“and for the day of the festival of Yahweh”

The speaker is using the possessive form to describe a **festival** that is about **Yahweh**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and for the day of the festival dedicated to Yahweh]

See: Possession

Hosea 9:6 (#1)

כִּי־הִנֵּה

“For behold”

The word translated as **For** indicates that the fact that follows about them being taken into captivity is a reason for what came before which was their inability to celebrate the holy occasions any more. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [This is because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Hosea 9:6 (#2)

הִנֵּה

“behold”

The speaker is using the term **behold** to focus his listeners’ attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [For indeed,]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 9:6 (#3)

מִצְרַיִם תְּקַבְּצֵם מֹף תְּקַבְּרֵם

“Egypt will gather them; Memphis will bury them”

The words **Egypt** and **Memphis** represent the people of those places. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [The people of Egypt will gather them; the people of Memphis will bury them]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 9:6 (#4)

מַחְמַד לְכַסְפָּם קִמּוֹשׁ יִירָשֵׁשֵׁם

“Nettles will possess the precious things of their silver”

The speaker is speaking of **Nettles** as if they were living things that could **possess** property. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The precious things of their silver will be covered with nettles]

See: Personification

Hosea 9:6 (#5)

קִמּוֹשׁ

“Nettles”

Nettles are a kind of prickly weed that grows in neglected places. If your readers would not be familiar with the name of these weeds, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [Prickly weeds]

See: Translate Unknowns

Hosea 9:6 (#6)

מַחְמַד לְכַסְפָּם

“the precious things of their silver”

The speaker is using this possessive form to mean the **precious things** that are made of **silver**. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [their precious things made of silver]

See: Possession

Hosea 9:7 (#1)

בָּבְאוּ ׀ יְמֵי הַפְּקֻדָּה בָּבְאוּ יְמֵי הַשִּׁלֻּם יֵדְעִעוּ יִשְׂרָאֵל אֱוִיל הַנָּבִיא מְשֻׁגָּעַע אִישׁ הָרוּחַ עַל רֹב עֲוֹנְךָ וְרַבָּה מַשְׂטֵמָה

“The days of punishment have come; the days of retribution have come. Israel will know {it}! The prophet {is} a fool; the man of the Spirit is insane, because of the abundance of your iniquity and great hostility”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because of the abundance of your iniquity and great hostility, the days of punishment have come; the days of retribution have come. Israel will know it! The prophet {is} a fool; the man of the Spirit is insane]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Hosea 9:7 (#2)

הַפְּקֻדָּה

“punishment”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **punishment**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [punishing you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 9:7 (#3)

בָּ֣אוּ ׀ יְמֵ֣י הַפְּקֻדָּ֗ה בָּ֚אוּ יְמֵ֣י הַשִּׁלֻּ֔ם

“The days of punishment have come; the days of retribution have come”

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in poetry, and follow that approach here and throughout this chapter. Alternate translation: [The days of getting the punishment they deserve have certainly come]

See: Parallelism

Hosea 9:7 (#4)

הַשִּׁלֻּ֔ם

“retribution”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **retribution**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [getting what they deserve]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 9:7 (#5)

אֱוִ֤יל הַנָּבִיא֙ מְשֻׁגָּ֣עַ אִ֔ישׁ הָרֽוּחַ

“The prophet {is} a fool; the man of the Spirit is insane”

Here the speaker is saying what the people said about the prophet. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote of the people. Alternate translation: [They said, “The prophet is a fool; the man of the Spirit is insane.” They say this]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Hosea 9:7 (#6)

אֱוִ֤יל הַנָּבִיא֙ מְשֻׁגָּ֣עַ אִ֔ישׁ הָרֽוּחַ

“The prophet {is} a fool; the man of the Spirit is insane”

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in poetry, and follow that approach here and throughout this chapter. Alternate translation: [The prophet is a fool; indeed, the man of the Spirit is insane]

See: Parallelism

Hosea 9:7 (#7)

מַשְׂטֵמָ֑ה

“hostility”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **hostility**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [hatred toward God]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 9:7 (#8)

אִ֖ישׁ הָרֽוּחַ

“the man of the Spirit”

The speaker is using the possessive form to describe the prophet as being a **man** that is characterized by being associated with **the Spirit**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the man who has the Spirit]

See: Possession

Hosea 9:7 (#9)

רֹ֥ב עֲוֹנְךָ֖

“the abundance of your iniquity”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **abundance** and **iniquity**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [the many evil things you have done]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 9:7 (#10)

עֲוֹנְךָ֖

“your iniquity”

The speaker has been speaking about Israel in the third person, but here he shifts to addressing them

directly in the second person with **your iniquity**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could continue in the third person for consistency. Alternate translation: [their iniquity]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Hosea 9:8 (#1)

אֱלֹהָיו

“my God”

The speaker is not using this possessive form **my God** to indicate that he possesses or controls Yahweh. Rather he is using these words to indicate that Yahweh is the God whom he worships. Alternate translation: [the God I worship]

See: Possession

Hosea 9:8 (#2)

צֹפֶה אֶפְרַיִם עִם־אֱלֹהָי

“The watcher of Ephraim {is} with my God”

Here the speaker is speaking of the prophet as if he were a **watcher** over the people along **with** their God. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The prophet is a watchman for God over Ephraim]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 9:8 (#3)

פַּח יָקוּשׁ עַל־כָּל־דְּרָכָיו

“a snare of a fowler {is} on all his ways”

The speaker is speaking of the dangers the prophet faces as if they were **a snare of a fowler** set to trap his prey. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a trap is set for him wherever he goes]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 9:8 (#4)

יָקוּשׁ

“a fowler”

A **fowler** is a person who catches birds. If your readers would not be familiar with what a **fowler** is, you could use the name of a similar thing that your readers would recognize, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [a bird catcher]

See: Translate Unknowns

Hosea 9:8 (#5)

מַשְׂטֵמָה

“hostility {is”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **hostility**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [those who hate him are]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 9:8 (#6)

בְּבֵית אֱלֹהָיו

“in the house of his God”

The speaker is using the possessive form to describe the **house** that belongs to **his God** as the temple. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in the temple where his God is worshiped]

See: Possession

Hosea 9:9 (#1)

הֶעְמִיקוּ־שִׁחֵתוּ

“They have made deep, they have corrupted {themselves”

The speaker is using **They have made deep, they have corrupted themselves** as a common expression to mean “they have become thoroughly corrupt.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They have corrupted themselves completely]

See: Idiom

Hosea 9:9 (#2)

כִּימֵי הַגִּבְעָה

“as {in} the days of Gibeah”

The point of this comparison is that just as the people in **the days of Gibeah** were extremely corrupt (refers to the story of the people of Gibeah’s sin again the Levite’s concubine in Judges 19), so the people of Israel are equally corrupt now. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [just as corrupt as the people of Gibeah were]

See: Simile

Hosea 9:9 (#3)

עֲוֹנָ֖ם יִפְקֹ֑ד חַטֹּאותָֽם

“their iniquity; he will punish their sins”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **iniquity** and **sin**, you could express the same ideas in other ways. Alternate translation: [the evil things they have done; he will punish their sinful ways]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 9:10 (#1)

כַּעֲנָבִ֣ים בַּמִּדְבָּ֔ר מָצָ֖אתִי יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“Like grapes in the wilderness, I found Israel”

This seems to be the beginning of what Yahweh said. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote of Yahweh that continues through the end of the chapter except for a few verses that are probably the prophet speaking as modeled in the UST.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Hosea 9:10 (#2)

כַּעֲנָבִ֣ים בַּמִּדְבָּ֔ר מָצָ֖אתִי יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“Like grapes in the wilderness, I found Israel”

The point of this comparison is that just as **grapes in the wilderness** would be a delightful and unexpected discovery for a weary traveler, so **Israel** was a delight to Yahweh when he first chose them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [When I found and chose Israel, it was as pleasing to me as finding grapes in the wilderness]

See: Simile

Hosea 9:10 (#3)

אֲבוֹתֵיכֶ֗ם

“your fathers”

Yahweh is using the term **fathers** to mean “ancestors.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your forefathers]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 9:10 (#4)

וַיִּהְיוּ֙ שִׁקּוּצִ֔ים כְּאָהֳבָֽם

“and they became abominations like {what} they loved”

The point of this comparison is that just as the idol **they loved** was detestable to God, so the people who worshiped it **became abominations** themselves. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and they became as abominable as the idols they loved]

See: Simile

Hosea 9:10 (#5)

כְּבִכּוּרָ֣ה בִתְאֵנָ֔ה בְּרֵאשִׁיתָ֖הּ רָאִ֣יתִי אֲבוֹתֵיכֶ֑ם

“Like the first fruit on the fig tree in its beginning, I saw your fathers”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the first fruit on the fig tree in its beginning** is especially valued and eagerly anticipated, so Yahweh valued the early **fathers** when he first chose them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [I chose your fathers and greatly valued them]

See: Simile

Hosea 9:10 (#6)

וַיִּנָּזְרוּ֙ לַבֹּ֔שֶׁת

“and they devoted themselves to the shame”

Here, **the shame** represents the idol Baal, which Yahweh considers shameful. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and they devoted themselves to that shameful idol]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 9:10 (#7)

הֵ֖מָּה בָּ֥אוּ

“They, they came to”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **They** separately, even though the verb translated **they came** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize the contrast between the delight he took in their ancestors and his sadness at their subsequent unfaithfulness. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing

the emphasis here. Alternate translation: [They themselves came to]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 9:10 (#8)

בָּבָאוּ בַעַל־פְּעֹר

“they came to Baal Peor”

The phrase **they came to Baal Peor** refers to the events of Numbers 25:1–18. The speaker is pointing out the turning point when the people that Yahweh had chosen turned away from worshiping him to worshiping false gods. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information in a footnote.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 9:11 (#1)

כָּעוֹף יִתְעוֹפֵף כְּבוֹדָם

“like a bird their glory will fly away”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a bird** quickly flies away and is gone, so Ephraim’s **glory will fly away** and vanish. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like a bird flies away and is gone, so will their glory fly away]

See: Simile

Hosea 9:11 (#2)

כָּעוֹף יִתְעוֹפֵף כְּבוֹדָם

“like a bird their glory will fly away”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **glory**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [soon the children that they glory in will be gone]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 9:12 (#1)

וְשִׁכַּלְתִּים מֵאָדָם

“I will bereave them from a man”

Yahweh is using **from a man** as a common expression of the culture to mean “every one.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will bereave them of every last child] or [not a single child will be left]

See: Idiom

Hosea 9:12 (#2)

אַף אוֹי לָהֶם

“woe to them”

Yahweh is using the phrase **woe to them** that expresses a strong feeling of coming judgment and disaster. There may be an equivalent word or phrase in your language that you can use in your translation to convey this feeling. Alternate translation: [great disaster will come upon them]

See: Exclamations

Hosea 9:12 (#3)

בְּשׁוּרְרִי מֵהֶם

“when I turn away from them”

Yahweh is speaking as if he had been walking toward the people of Israel but now would physically **turn away from** them. He means that he will stop protecting them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [when I stop protecting them]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 9:13 (#1)

כַּאֲשֶׁר־רָאִיתִי לְצֹר שְׁתוּלָה בִנְוֶה וְאֶפְרַיִם

“just as I have seen for Tyre, planted in a meadow, so Ephraim”

The point of this comparison is that just as **Tyre** was once prosperous and beautifully **planted in a meadow** but its judgment had been predicted, so **Ephraim** was once prosperous but will also be judged. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [just as Tyre was once prosperous, so also Ephraim who was once prosperous]

See: Simile

Hosea 9:14 (#1)

תֵּן־לָהֶם יְהוָה

“Give to them, Yahweh”

This is an imperative, but it communicates a polite request that Hosea is making to Yahweh rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please give to them, Yahweh]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Hosea 9:14 (#2)

מַה־תִּתֵּן

“what will you give”

The speaker is using the question form to express his anguish about what to ask God to give the people. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I do not know what to ask!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Hosea 9:14 (#3)

רֶ֣חֶם מַשְׁכִּ֔יל וְשָׁדַ֖יִם צֹמְקִֽים

“a miscarrying womb and dry breasts”

Hosea is using **a miscarrying womb and dry breasts** to represent the complete inability to have and raise children which would be a mercy since they were destined to be slain as mentioned in the previous verse. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the complete inability to have and raise children]

See: Synecdoche

Hosea 9:15 (#1)

כָּל־רָעָתָ֖ם בַּגִּלְגָּ֑ל

“their evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [All their wicked deeds began in Gilgal]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 9:15 (#2)

כִּי־שָׁ֖ם

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: כִּי־שָׁ֖ם”

Here the word **for** introduces not a reason but an explanation. You may want to use a different connecting word to show how this statement relates to what comes before it. Alternate translation: [and it was because of what they did there that]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Hosea 9:15 (#3)

מִבֵּיתִ֣י אֲגָרְשֵׁ֔ם

“QUOTE_NOT_FOUND: מִבֵּיתִ֣י אֲגָרְשֵׁ֔ם”

Yahweh is speaking of his land as if it were his **house**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will expel them from my land]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 9:16 (#1)

מַחֲמַדֵּ֥י בִטְנָֽם

“the precious ones of their womb”

Yahweh is using this possessive form to mean the **precious ones** who came from **their womb**, that is, their beloved children. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the precious children born from their womb]

See: Possession

Hosea 9:16 (#2)

שֹׁרְשָׁ֖ם יָבֵ֑שׁ פְּרִ֥י בלי־יַעֲשׂ֖וּן

“their root has dried up; they will not produce fruit”

Yahweh is speaking of the people of Ephraim as if they were a plant whose **root has dried up** and that will not **produce fruit**. He means they will have no children or prosperity. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [they will no longer have children or prosperity]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 9:16 (#3)

הֻכָּ֥ה אֶפְרַ֖יִם

“Ephraim is struck”

The expression **Ephraim is struck** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is God. Alternate translation: [I will strike Ephraim]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 9:16 (#4)

מַחֲמַדֵּ֥י בִטְנָֽם

“the precious ones of their womb”

Here, **womb** represents the act of giving birth to children. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the precious children to whom they give birth]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 9:17 (#1)

אֱלֹהַי

“My God”

See how you translated the similar expression in 9:8. Alternate translation: [The God I worship]

See: Possession

Hosea - Chapter 10 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter is poetic prophecy of judgment against Israel for its idolatry.

1. Israel rejects Yahweh and turns to idolatry (1–4)
2. Yahweh brings judgment on Israel’s false security (5–10)
3. Israel reaps the consequences of sin (11–13)
4. Yahweh executes justice on the nation (14–15)

Idolatry and the high places

Prosperity led Israel to multiply altars and worship the calf idol at Beth Aven, which Yahweh will destroy. Yahweh’s relationship to his people was not based on his people’s actions. Even though they rebelled, Yahweh still desired to rescue them.

Sowing and reaping

Verses 12–13 use recurring farming imagery: people reap what they sow, whether righteousness or wickedness.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Jacob

The repeated use of different names for the two kingdoms can be confusing. In verse 11, “Ephraim” refers to the northern kingdom of Israel, and “Judah” refers to the southern kingdom of Judah. However, Jacob is also mentioned. This use of “Jacob” makes us think of the earlier unified nation and may also refer to a future unified nation.

Hosea 10:1 (#1)

גֶּפֶן בּוֹקֵקָה יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Israel {is} an emptying vine”

The speaker is speaking as if Israel were **an emptying vine**, a productive plant that spreads out and bears fruit. He means that the nation had grown and become prosperous. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Israel had grown and become prosperous]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 10:1 (#2)

פֹּרֵרִי יְשַׁוֶּה־לֹּוֹ

“he places fruit for himself”

The speaker continues to speak as if Israel were a vine that **places fruit for himself**. He means that the people used their growing prosperity for their own benefit. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he uses his prosperity for himself]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 10:1 (#3)

כְּרֹ֣ב לְפִרְיֹ֔ו

“According to the abundance of his fruit”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **abundance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [According to the abundant fruit it produced]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 10:1 (#4)

הֵיטִ֥יבוּ מַצֵּבֹ֖ות

“they made good pillars”

The pronoun **they** refers to the nation of Israel which is a shift from earlier in this verse where he refers to the nation as the person with the pronouns**he** and **his**. Throughout this chapter, the pronouns referring to Israel vary between singular and plural. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the singular here and in the next verses or use the plural throughout as modeled in the UST. Alternate translation: [he made good pillars] or [Israel made good pillars]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 10:1 (#5)

כְּטֹובַ֖ לְאַרְצֹ֑ו

“According to the goodness of his land”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **goodness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [According to how good his land was]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 10:2 (#1)

חָלַ֥ק לִבָּ֖ם

“Their heart is slippery”

Here the **heart** represents where the people’s motives and intentions exist. By describing it as if it were **slippery**, the speaker shows that their motives and intensions were insincere and deceitful, as they were divided in their devotion to Yahweh. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Their motives are insincere and deceitful]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 10:2 (#2)

יֶאְשָׁ֣מוּ

“they will bear guilt”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **guilt**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [they will be punished for their wrongdoing]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 10:2 (#3)

הֽוּא יַעֲרֹ֥ף

“He, he will break the neck of”

The speaker is stating the pronoun **He** separately, even though the verb translated as **he will break** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it is Yahweh who will perform this action. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing that meaning here. Alternate translation: [Yahweh himself will break the neck of]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 10:2 (#4)

יַעֲרֹ֥ף מִזְבְּחוֹתָ֖ם

“he will break the neck of their altars”

The speaker is using the expression **break the neck of** as a common expression of the culture to mean “completely destroy.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [he will completely destroy their altars]

See: Idiom

Hosea 10:3 (#1)

אֵ֣ין מֶ֤לֶךְ לָ֙נוּ֙ כִּֽי לֹ֣א יָרֵ֔אנוּ אֶת־יְהוָ֖ה

“There is no king for us, for we did not fear Yahweh”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since we did not fear Yahweh, there is no king for us]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Hosea 10:3 (#2)

וְהַמֶּ֖לֶךְ מַה־יַּֽעֲשֶׂה־לָּֽנוּ

“and the king—what could he do for us”

The people are using the question form to emphasize that a king could do nothing at all to help them. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [and even with a king, he could do nothing for us!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Hosea 10:4 (#1)

דִּבְּר֣וּ דְבָרִ֔ים

“They have spoken words”

The speaker is using the expression **They have spoken words** as a common expression of the culture to mean “they speak empty words.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They have made insincere promises]

See: Idiom

Hosea 10:4 (#2)

שָׁ֣וְא

“of worthlessness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **worthlessness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that are worthless]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 10:4 (#3)

וּפָרַח כָּרֹאשׁ מִשְׁפָּט

“so judgment sprouts like a poisonous weed”

The point of this comparison is that just as a **poisonous weed** grows quickly and spreads harm everywhere, so does the **judgment** that the people produce. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [so judgment spreads harm like a fast-growing poisonous weed]

See: Simile

Hosea 10:4 (#4)

כָּרֹת בְּרִית

“cutting a covenant”

The speaker is using **cutting a covenant** as a common expression of his culture to mean they are making or establishing a covenant. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [establishing a covenant]

See: Idiom

Hosea 10:4 (#5)

מִשְׁפָּט

“judgment”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **judgment**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [false accusations]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 10:5 (#1)

שְׁכֵנֵן

“The inhabitant of”

The speaker is not referring to a specific **inhabitant**. He means inhabitants in general. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could use an expression that would be more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [All the inhabitants of]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Hosea 10:5 (#2)

בֵּית אָוֶן

“Beth Aven”

The speaker is calling the city of Bethel **Beth Aven** as a derogatory wordplay because of all the idol worship there. “Bethel” means “house of God” and “Beth Aven” means “house of evil.” See how you translated this in Hosea 4:15.

See: How to Translate Names

Hosea 10:5 (#3)

כִּי־אָבַל עָלָיו עַמּוֹ

“for its people will mourn over it”

The pronoun **its** refers to the Beth Aven and **it** refers to the calf idol. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [for the people of Beth Aven will mourn over the calf idol]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 10:5 (#4)

וּכְמָרָיו & יָגִילוּ

“and its idolatrous priests will shout”

The word translated as **will shout** normally refers to a shout of joy. But here, the shout is not one of joy but one of fear.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 10:5 (#5)

עַל־כְּבוֹדוֹ

“over its glory”

Here, **its glory** represents how glorious the people considered the calf idol to be. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [over how glorious the calf idol was]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 10:5 (#6)

כִּי־גָלָה מִמֶּנּוּ

“for it has departed from it”

There are two possible interpretations of the pronouns in this phrase. (1) The first **it** could refer to the **glory** of the idol and the second **it** would then refer to the idol itself. See the UST. (2) The first **it** could refer to the calf idol, although the speaker uses a plural form for it earlier in the verse, but that may be a sarcastic use of the "plural of majesty," since the people around him considered it to be a god that had **glory**. The second **it** would then refer to either the **inhabitant** who feared for it (in which case, you would translate "it" as "him"), or its place, **Beth Aven**. Alternate translation: [for the calf idol has departed from Beth Aven]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 10:6 (#1)

גַּם־אוֹתוֹ & יוּבָל

"Even it will be carried"

The speaker is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context of the previous verse if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Even the calf itself will be carried]

See: Ellipsis

Hosea 10:6 (#2)

אוֹתוֹ לְאַשּׁוּר יוּבָל

"it will be carried to Assyria"

The expression **will be carried** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [the enemy will carry it to Assyria]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 10:6 (#3)

לְמֶלֶךְ יָרֵב

"to the king of Yareb"

The word **Yareb** represents the written Hebrew text both here and in 5:13. See what you decided to do there. Alternate translation: [to the great king] or [to the king of Assyria]

See: Alternative Readings

Hosea 10:6 (#4)

בָּשְׁנָה אֶפְרַיִם יִקָּח

"Ephraim will receive shame"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **shame**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Ephraim will feel ashamed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 10:6 (#5)

וְיֵבֹשׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל מֵעֲצָתוֹ

"and Israel will be ashamed of his counsel"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **counsel**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and Israel will be ashamed of what their leaders had led them to believe]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 10:7 (#1)

נִדְמָמָה & מַלְכָּהּ

"its king will be ended"

The expression **will be ended** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [its king will perish]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 10:7 (#2)

כְּקֶצֶף עַל־פְּנֵי־מָיִם

"like a splinter on the face of the waters"

The point of this comparison is that just as a **splinter on the face of the waters** is small and helplessly carried away by the force of the water, so the king of Samaria will be swept away and come to nothing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [he will disappear like a small splinter that is carried away on the surface of the water]

See: Simile

Hosea 10:7 (#3)

עַל־פְּנֵי־מָיִם

"on the face of the waters"

Here, **the face of the waters** represents the surface of the water. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [on top of the water]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 10:8 (#1)

וְנִשְׁמְדוּ֙ בָּמ֣וֹת אָ֔וֶן

“And the high places of Aven will be destroyed”

The expression **will be destroyed** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [And Yahweh will destroy the high places of Aven]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 10:8 (#2)

אָ֔וֶן

“Aven”

The word **Aven** is a shortened version of “Beth Aven” (which means “house of evil”) mentioned in verse 5 and refers to the city of Bethel. See how you translated it there.

See: How to Translate Names

Hosea 10:8 (#3)

חַטַּאת֙ יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל

“the sin of Israel”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **sin**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [where Israel sinned]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 10:8 (#4)

קִמּ֥וֹשׂ וְדַרְדַּ֖ר

“Thorn and thistle”

The terms **Thorn and thistle** mean similar things. The speaker is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [All kinds of weeds]

See: Doublet

Hosea 10:8 (#5)

וְאָמְר֣וּ לָהָרִ֔ים כַּסּ֖וּנוּ וְלַגְּבָעוֹת֙ נִפְלוּ־לָ֔נוּ עָלֵֽינוּ׃

“and they will say to the mountains, “Cover us!” and to the hills, “Fall on us”

The people are speaking to the **mountains** and the **hills**, which they know cannot hear them. They are doing this to express that they feel very strongly about their desire to escape Yahweh’s judgment. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if they were speaking directly to the people about the mountains and the hills. Alternate translation: [and they will cry out to one another, “Let the mountains cover us!” and “Let the hills fall on us]

See: Apostrophe

Hosea 10:9 (#1)

שָׁ֚שָׁם עָמָ֣דוּ

“There they have stood”

The speaker is speaking of Israel persisting in their sin as if the Israelites had **stood** still in the place where their sin began. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [There they have remained in their sin]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 10:9 (#2)

לֹֽא־תַשִּׂ֥יגָם בַּגִּבְעָ֖ה מִלְחָמָ֑ה עַל־בְּנֵ֥י עַוְלָֽה

“Will not war overtake them in Gibeah, against the sons of injustice”

The speaker is using the question form to emphasize that war will certainly be the consequence of their sinfulness. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [War will certainly overtake them in Gibeah against the sons of injustice!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Hosea 10:9 (#3)

בְּנֵ֥י עַוְלָֽה

“the sons of injustice”

The speaker is using **son of** as a common expression of the culture to indicate people who have a certain characteristic. In this case, the people of Gibeah are characterized by doing what is unjust. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those who have acted unjustly]

See: Idiom

Hosea 10:10 (#1)

בְּאַוָּתִ֖י

“When it is my desire”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **desire**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [When I want to]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 10:10 (#2)

בְּאַוָּתִ֖י

“When it is my desire”

This seems to be the beginning of what Yahweh said. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote of Yahweh that continues beyond the end of the chapter as modeled in the UST.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Hosea 10:10 (#3)

וְאֵסְפ֤וּ עֲלֵיהֶם֙ עַמִּ֔ים

“and peoples will be gathered against them”

The expression **will be gathered** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who does the action, the context indicates that it is Yahweh who is speaking from this point forward in the chapter. Alternate translation: [and I will gather peoples against them]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 10:10 (#4)

בְּאָסְרָ֖ם

“when they are bound”

The expression **are bound** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [when I bind them]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 10:10 (#5)

לִשְׁתֵּ֥י עינתם

“to their two eyes”

The phrase ** to their two eyes** is a translation of the written Hebrew text. Later Hebrew scribes, however, have recommended in the margin of the text what they considered to be a correction, by changing one letter. The UST follows this reading, and you may want to do the same or follow the reading of the major translation in your area. Alternate translation: [because of their two sins]

See: Alternative Readings

Hosea 10:11 (#1)

וְאֶפְרַ֗יִם עֶגְלָ֤ה מְלֻמָּדָה֙

“And Ephraim {is} a trained heifer”

Yahweh is speaking as if Ephraim were **a trained heifer**, a young cow that had been taught to work. He means that the people of Ephraim had become accustomed to easy, pleasant labor. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And the people of Ephraim were like a teachable calf]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 10:11 (#2)

עָבַ֙רְתִּי֙ עַל־טּ֣וּב צַוָּארָ֔הּ

“I have passed over upon the goodness of her neck”

Yahweh is speaking as if he would lay a yoke on a work animal when he says that he **passed over upon the goodness of her neck**. He means that he will subject the people of Ephraim to hard labor and suffering. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have subjected her to hard labor and suffering]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 10:11 (#3)

אַרְכִּ֤יב אֶפְרַ֙יִם֙ יַחֲרֹ֣ושׁ יְהוּדָ֔ה יְשַׁדֵּ֥ד־לֹ֖ו יַעֲקֹֽב

“I will harness Ephraim; Judah will plow; Jacob will harrow by himself”

Yahweh is speaking as if the people were work animals that he would **harness** to **plow** and **harrow** the fields. He means that he will subject Ephraim, Judah, and Jacob to hard toil. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will put Ephraim to hard work; Judah will labor; Jacob will toil alone]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 10:11 (#4)

טֹ֖וב צַוָּארָֽהּ

“the goodness of her neck”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **goodness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [her untouched neck]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 10:12 (#1)

זִרְע֨וּ לָכֶ֤ם לִצְדָקָה֙ קִצְר֣וּ לְפִי־חֶ֔סֶד

“Sow for yourselves for righteousness; reap to the mouth of covenant faithfulness”

Yahweh is speaking as if righteousness were a crop that the people should **Sow** and then **reap**. He means that they should do what is right and so receive Yahweh’s covenant faithfulness in return. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Do what is right, and you will receive covenant faithfulness]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 10:12 (#2)

זִרְע֨וּ לָכֶ֤ם לִצְדָקָה֙

“Sow for yourselves for righteousness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [If you do the right thing, then]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 10:12 (#3)

קִצְר֔וּ לְפִי־חֶ֖סֶד

“reap to the mouth of covenant faithfulness”

Yahweh is using **to the mouth of** as a common expression of the culture to mean “according to.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [then you will reap according to Yahweh’s covenant faithfulness to you]

See: Idiom

Hosea 10:12 (#4)

חֶ֖סֶד

“covenant faithfulness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **covenant faithfulness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [faithfully keeping the covenant]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 10:12 (#5)

נִ֣ירוּ לָכֶ֔ם נִ֖יר

“Till for yourselves tillage”

Yahweh is using a construction in which a verb and its object come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of saying this. Alternate translation: [Break up your unplowed ground]

See: Poetry

Hosea 10:12 (#6)

וְיֹרֶ֥ה צֶ֖דֶק לָכֶֽם

“and rains righteousness on you”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **righteousness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and rains his righteous deeds on you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 10:12 (#7)

נִ֣ירוּ לָכֶ֔ם נִ֖יר

“Till for yourselves tillage”

Yahweh is speaking as if the people needed to **Till for yourselves tillage**, breaking up new ground. He means that they should make a thorough change in the way they live. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Begin to break your bad habits] or [Make a thorough change in the way you live]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 10:12 (#8)

אֶת־יְהוָ֔ה עַד־יָבֹ֥וא

“Yahweh, until he comes”

Yahweh is speaking of himself in the third person as **Yahweh** and **he**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person as modeled in the UST.

See: First, Second or Third Person

Hosea 10:12 (#9)

וְיֹרֶה צֶדֶק לָכֶם

“and rains righteousness on you”

Yahweh is speaking of Yahweh’s abundant blessing as if he **rains** it down on the people like water from the sky. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and abundantly gives righteousness to you]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 10:13 (#1)

חֲרַשְׁתֶּם־רֶשַׁע

“You have plowed wickedness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wickedness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [You have plowed what is wicked]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 10:13 (#2)

חֲרַשְׁתֶּם־רֶשַׁע עַוְלָתָה קְצַרְתֶּם

“You have plowed wickedness; you have reaped injustice”

Hosea is speaking as if wickedness and injustice were crops that the people had **plowed** and **reaped**. He means that the people did evil and then experienced its harmful consequences. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You have committed wickedness; you have received injustice]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 10:13 (#3)

עַוְלָתָה קְצַרְתֶּם

“you have reaped injustice”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **injustice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [you have reaped what is unjust]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 10:13 (#4)

כָּזָב

“deception”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **deception**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [deceiving others]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 10:13 (#5)

אֲכַלְתֶּם פְּרִי־כָזָב

“You have eaten the fruit of deception”

Yahweh is speaking as if the people’s deception were **fruit** that they had **eaten**. He means that the people have experienced the harmful consequences of their lies and deceit. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You have experienced the harmful consequences of your own deception]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 10:13 (#6)

בְּרֹ֣ב גְּבוֹרֶ֔יךָ

“in the multitude of your warriors”

Yahweh is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and you trusted in the multitude of your warriors]

See: Ellipsis

Hosea 10:13 (#7)

בְּרֹ֣ב גְּבוֹרֶ֔יךָ

“in the multitude of your warriors”

Yahweh is using the possessive form to describe a **multitude** made up of **warriors**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [in how many warriors you have]

See: Possession

Hosea 10:14 (#1)

וְכָל־מִבְצָרֶיךָ יוּשַׁד

“and all your fortresses will be destroyed”

The expression **will be destroyed** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and your enemies will destroy all your fortresses]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 10:14 (#2)

אֵֽם & רֻטָּשָׁה

“a mother was dashed to pieces”

The expression **was dashed to pieces** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [when his soldiers dashed a mother to pieces]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 10:15 (#1)

כָּכָה עָשָׂה לָכֶם

“Thus he will do to you”

The pronoun **he** refers to Yahweh. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Thus I, Yahweh will do to you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 10:15 (#2)

בֵּית־אֵל

“Bethel”

Here, **Bethel** represents the people who live in Bethel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [who live in Bethel]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 10:15 (#3)

מִפְּנֵי רָעַ֥ת רָעַתְכֶ֖ם

“from the face of the evil of your evil”

Yahweh is using the expression **from the face of** as a common expression of the culture to mean “because of.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because of your great evil]

See: Idiom

Hosea 10:15 (#4)

רָעַ֥ת רָעַתְכֶ֖ם

“the evil of your evil”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **evil**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the extremely evil things you have done]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 10:15 (#5)

נִדְמֹ֥ה נִדְמָ֖ה מֶ֣לֶךְ יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“the king of Israel being destroyed, will be destroyed”

The expressions **being destroyed** and **will be destroyed** are passive verbal forms. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [your enemies will attack and surely destroy the king of Israel]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea - Chapter 11 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter is a poetic divine speech: Yahweh recalls his fatherly love for Israel, laments their unfaithfulness, and finally turns from judgment to compassion.

1. Yahweh recalls his love and care for Israel (1–4)
2. Israel faces judgment for refusing to return to Yahweh (5–7)
3. Yahweh’s compassion restrains his anger (8–11)
4. Israel’s unfaithfulness is exposed (12)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Israel as God’s son

Yahweh portrays himself as a parent who taught the child Israel to walk and called his “son” out of Egypt.

Hosea 11:1 (#1)

נַ֣עַר יִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל

“Israel was a child”

Yahweh is speaking of the nation of Israel as if it were a young **child** here and in the next few verses. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Israel was a young nation]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 11:1 (#2)

לִבְנִי

“my son”

Yahweh is speaking of the nation of Israel as if it were his **son**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my people]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 11:2 (#1)

קָרְאוּ לָהֶם

“They called to them”

The phrase **They called to them** is a translation of the written Hebrew text. It is unclear who **They** would refer to. The ancient Greek and Syriac translations reflect a reading that has Yahweh calling to the Israelites directly and that includes an initial term that means “the more” or “as much as.” The UST follows this reading. If you prefer to translate according to the Hebrew, there are two possibilities: (1) “They” could refer to the prophets, through whom Yahweh called to the Israelites to repent and obey him. Alternate translation: [The prophets called to them] or [I called to them through the prophets] or (2) it could refer to worshippers of Baal, who called the Israelites away from Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Worshippers of Baal called to them]

See: Alternative Readings

Hosea 11:2 (#2)

הָלְכוּ מִפְּנֵיהֶם

“they went from their faces”

The pronoun **they** in this phrase refers to the people of Israel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the Israelites went from their faces]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 11:2 (#3)

מִפְּנֵיהֶם

“from their faces”

Here the phrase **from their faces** could: (1) represent “from their presence,” referring to the prophets of Yahweh. Or if you chose to divide the words differently as did the ancient Greek and Syriac translators, it would represent “from my presence.” Alternate translation: [from before them] or [from before me] or (2) be a common expression of the culture that means “because of them.” In this case, it could refer to the worshippers of Baal, if that is how you chose to interpret who **They** is in **They called to them** at the beginning of the verse. Alternate translation: [because of them]

See: Idiom

Hosea 11:2 (#4)

מִפְּנֵיהֶם

“from their faces”

The phrase **from their faces** is a translation of the written Hebrew text. This reading, however, does not seem to make sense. You may want to follow an alternative reading from the ancient Greek and Syriac translations, which divided the words differently, reading the pronoun with the verb “they kept sacrificing” (“they” has the same letters as “their”). The UST follows that reading. Alternate translation: [from my face] or [from me]

See: Alternative Readings

Hosea 11:3 (#1)

וְאָנֹכִי תִרְגַּלְתִּי לְאֶפְרַיִם

“Yet I, I taught Ephraim to walk”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I taught** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it was he himself who cared for the people of Ephraim. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [Yet I myself taught Ephraim to walk]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 11:3 (#2)

תִרְגַּלְתִּי לְאֶפְרַיִם

“I taught Ephraim to walk”

Yahweh is speaking of his early care for the people of Ephraim as if he as a parent had been teaching a small child and **taught Ephraim to walk**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly.

Alternate translation: [I cared for Ephraim like a parent teaching a small child to walk]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 11:3 (#3)

קָחָם עַל־זְרוֹעֹתָיו

“He took them upon his arms”

The phrase **He took them upon his arms** could be translated to mean: (1) that Yahweh picked up Ephraim, pictured as a small child, and carried him in his arms. The UST follows this interpretation. It may be that Hosea is speaking about Yahweh here, or it may be that the original reading continued Yahweh’s speech in the first person, as the ancient Greek and Syriac translations have it. Alternate translation: [I took him up in my arms] or (2) that Yahweh took Ephraim, pictured as a small child, and held onto Ephraim’s arms as Yahweh taught Ephraim to walk. Alternate translation: [He took him by his arms] or [I took him by his arms]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 11:3 (#4)

קָחָם עַל־זְרוֹעֹתָיו וְלֹא יָדְעוּ כִּכִּי רְפָאתִים

“He took them upon his arms, but they did not know that I healed them”

The plural pronouns **them** and **they** refer to Ephraim as the nation of Israel which is a shift from earlier in this verse where he refers to the nation as the person, **Ephraim**. Throughout this chapter, the pronouns referring to Israel and Ephraim vary between singular and plural. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the singular here and in the next verses or use the plural throughout as modeled in the UST. Alternate translation: [He took him upon his arms, but he did not know that I healed him]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 11:3 (#5)

רְפָאתִים

“I healed them”

Yahweh is speaking of caring for the people of Israel as if he **healed them** from sickness. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I cared for them]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 11:4 (#1)

בְּחַבְלֵי אָדָם אֶמְשְׁכֵם בַּעֲבֹתֹות אַהֲבָה

“I led them with cords of humanity, with bands of love”

Yahweh is speaking of the kind and gentle ways he led the people of Israel as if they were **cords of humanity** and **bands of love** by which he drew them along. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I led them with gentle kindness and love]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 11:4 (#2)

אַהֲבָה

“love”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **love**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how I loved them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 11:4 (#3)

וָאֱהִי לָהֶם כְּמֵרִימֵי עֹל עַל לְחֵיהֶם

“And I was to them like the lifters of a yoke on their jaws”

The phrase **And I was to them like the lifters of a yoke on their jaws** is a translation of the written Hebrew text. This reading, however, does not seem to make sense. A yoke is never placed on an animal’s jaws, but on the animal’s neck. Further, if this were an image of release from slavery, it would describe lifting the yoke from the animal, not lifting it on the animal. It seems that the word translated as **yoke** should be pronounced with a different vowel, which would then be the word for “infant.” The word translated as **jaws** also means “cheek.” Therefore, this could mean: (1) Yahweh is continuing the picture of Ephraim as a small child and describing his tender care for them. The UST follows that reading. Alternate translation: [And I was to them like those who lift an infant onto their cheeks] or (2) Yahweh is describing Ephraim as a working animal on which he is lifting a yoke, perhaps as a picture of releasing them from slavery. Alternate translation: [And I was to them like those who lift a yoke on their jaws]

See: Alternative Readings

Hosea 11:4 (#4)

וְאַאֲט אֵלֶיו אוֹכִיל

“and I bent down to him; I fed {him”

Yahweh is speaking of his care for the people of Israel as if he were a parent who **bent down** and **fed** a small child. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and I gently cared for him and fed him]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 11:5 (#1)

לֹ֣א יָשׁוּב֮ אֶל־אֶ֣רֶץ מִצְרַיִם֒ וְאַשּׁ֣וּר הֽוּא־מַלְכּ֔וֹ כִּֽי־מֵאֲנ֖וּ לָשֽׁוּב

“He will not return to the land of Egypt, but Assyria —he {will be} his king, because they refused to return”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the last phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrases describe. Alternate translation: [Since they refused to return to worship Yahweh, he will not return them to the land of Egypt, but instead, Assyria will be his king]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Hosea 11:5 (#2)

הֽוּא־מַלְכּ֔וֹ

“he {will be} his king”

The pronoun **he** refers to the king of Assyria, while the pronoun **his** refers to Ephraim. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the king of Assyria will be Ephraim‘s king]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 11:5 (#3)

מֵאֲנ֖וּ לָשֽׁוּב

“they refused to return”

The implication is that they refused to return to worshiping Yahweh. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [they no longer worship me]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 11:6 (#1)

וְכִלְתָ֥ה בַדָּ֖יו

“and will destroy his bars”

Yahweh assumes that readers will know the **bars** being referred to are part of the city gates. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and will destroy the bars of his gates]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 11:6 (#2)

וְאָכְלָ֖ה מֵֽעֲצֹתֵיהֶֽם

“and will devour because of their plans”

Yahweh is speaking of the destruction that the sword will cause as if the sword would **devour** its victims like an animal eating its prey. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and will destroy them because of their plans]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 11:6 (#3)

וְאָכְלָ֖ה מֵֽעֲצֹתֵיהֶֽם

“and will devour because of their plans”

Yahweh is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and will devour them because of their plans]

See: Ellipsis

Hosea 11:6 (#4)

מֵֽעֲצֹתֵיהֶֽם

“because of their plans”

The pronoun **their** refers to the Ephraim or the nation of Israel which is a shift from earlier in this verse where he refers to the nation as the person with the pronoun **his**. Throughout this chapter, the pronouns referring to Ephraim and Israel vary between singular and plural. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the singular here and in the next verses or use the plural throughout as modeled in the UST. Alternate translation: [because of his plans]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 11:7 (#1)

תְּלוּאִ֖ים לִמְשׁוּבָתִ֑י

“are bent on turning away from me”

Yahweh is speaking of his people abandoning their loyalty to him as if they were physically **turning away from** him to walk in a different direction. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [are determined to abandon me]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 11:7 (#2)

וְאֶל־עַל֙ יִקְרָאֻ֣הוּ יַחַ֔ד לֹ֥א יְרוֹמֵֽם

“Though they call to him on high, he will not raise {them} up at all”

Yahweh is speaking of himself in the third person as **him** and **he**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [Though they call to me on high, I will not raise them up at all]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Hosea 11:8 (#1)

אֵ֚יךְ אֶתְּנְךָ֣ אֶפְרַ֔יִם אֲמַגֶּנְךָ֖ יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל

“How can I give you up, Ephraim, surrender you, Israel”

Yahweh is using the question form to express the anguish and reluctance he feels at the thought of giving up his people. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I will not give you up, Ephraim or surrender you, Israel!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Hosea 11:8 (#2)

אֵ֚יךְ אֶתְּנְךָ֣ כְאַדְמָ֔ה אֲשִׂימְךָ֖ כִּצְבֹאִ֑ים

“How can I make you like Admah, set you like Zeboiim”

Yahweh is using the question form to express how unwilling he is to destroy his people as he destroyed Admah. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [I will not make you like Admah or set you like Zeboiim!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Hosea 11:8 (#3)

אֶתְּנְךָ֣ כְאַדְמָ֔ה אֲשִׂימְךָ֖ כִּצְבֹאִ֑ים

“can I make you like Admah, set you like Zeboiim”

The point of this comparison is that while the cities of **Admah** and **Zeboiim** were completely destroyed (see Deuteronomy 29:23), this is something that Yahweh does not want to do to the people of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [How can I completely destroy you like Admah and Zebeoiim]

See: Simile

Hosea 11:8 (#4)

נֶהְפַּ֤ךְ עָלַי֙ לִבִּ֔י

“My heart is turned over within me”

Yahweh is speaking of the turmoil of his strong feelings of anguish as if his **heart** were physically **turned over within** him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My heart is overwhelmed within me]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 11:8 (#5)

נֶהְפַּ֤ךְ עָלַי֙ לִבִּ֔י

“My heart is turned over within me”

The expression **is turned over** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [This situation makes my heart turn over within me]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 11:8 (#6)

לִבִּ֔י

“My heart”

Here Yahweh speaks of his **heart** as it represents where his feelings and desires exist. You may have a comparable expression in your language, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My inner being]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 11:8 (#7)

נִכְמְרוּ֙

“my compassions”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **compassions**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [my feelings of compassion for you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 11:8 (#8)

נִכְמְרוּ

“are aroused”

The expression **are aroused** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [rise up]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 11:9 (#1)

חֲרוֹן אַפִּי

“the burning of my nose”

Yahweh is using **the burning of my nose** as a common expression of the culture to mean “my fierce anger.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my fierce anger]

See: Idiom

Hosea 11:9 (#2)

בָּעִיר

“in wrath”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wrath**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [angrily]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 11:10 (#1)

אַחֲרֵי יְהוָה יֵלֵכוּ

“They will come after Yahweh”

This could be: (1) Hosea speaking about Yahweh as in the UST or (2) Yahweh speaking of himself in the third person. Alternate translation: [They will come after me, Yahweh]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Hosea 11:10 (#2)

כְּאַרְיֵה יִשְׁאָג

“he will roar like a lion”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a lion** roars loudly and powerfully, so Yahweh will summon his people with a loud, powerful voice. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [he will roar powerfully to summon his people]

See: Simile

Hosea 11:10 (#3)

כִּי־הוּא יִשְׁאַג

“When he, he roars”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **he** separately, even though the verb translated as **he roars** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that it is he himself who roars. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [When he himself roars]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 11:10 (#4)

בָּנִים

“sons”

Yahweh is speaking of the people of Israel as if they were his **sons** returning to their father. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the people who belong to him]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 11:11 (#1)

יֶחֶרְדוּ כְצִפּוֹר מִמִּצְרַיִם

“They will come trembling like a bird from Egypt”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a bird** would be timid, fearful, and trembling in response to a lion’s roar, so the people of Israel will hurry back from exile with respectful fear when Yahweh summons them to return. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [They will return with fear and trembling from Egypt]

See: Simile

Hosea 11:11 (#2)

וּכְיוֹנָה מֵאֶרֶץ אַשּׁוּר

“and like a dove from the land of Assyria”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a dove** is gentle and docile, so the people of Israel will come back without objections from the land of Assyria, ready to obey Yahweh. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and other returns from Assyria like a dove that docilely returns home]

See: Simile

Hosea 11:11 (#3)

נְאֻם־יְהוָה

“the declaration of Yahweh”

Yahweh is speaking of himself in the third person in the phrase **the declaration of Yahweh**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate this in the first person. Alternate translation: [it is I, Yahweh, who is declaring this]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Hosea 11:12 (#1)

סְבָבֻנִי בְכַחַשׁ

“has surrounded me with lies”

Yahweh is speaking of the constant lying of the people of Ephraim as if they had **surrounded me with lies** on every side. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [has completely deceived me with lies]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 11:12 (#2)

וּבְמִרְמָה בֵּית יִשְׂרָאֵל

“and the house of Israel with deceit”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **deceit**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and the house of Israel is constantly trying to deceive me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 11:12 (#3)

רָדַד עִם־אֵל

“roams with God”

Yahweh is using **roams with God** as a common expression of the culture to mean “remains loyal to God.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [remains loyal to God]

See: Idiom

Hosea 11:12 (#4)

בֵּית יִשְׂרָאֵל

“the house of Israel”

Here, **house** means all the people descended from a particular person. It envisions them as if they were one household living together. So **the house of Israel** figuratively means all the people descended from the patriarch Jacob, who was also known as Israel. Alternate translation: [the Israelites]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 11:12 (#5)

וְיהוּדָה עֹדֶנּוּ רָדַד עִם־אֵל וְעִם־קְדוֹשִׁים נֶאֱמָן

“But Judah still roams with God, and is established with the Holy {One”

The sentence **But Judah still roams with God, and is established with the Holy One** could mean: (1) that although Israel is far from God, Judah is still following him. The ULT and UST follow that reading, or (2) that the word translated as “God” refers to the false god Baal, and the word translated as “the Holy One” refers to the lesser gods who serve Baal. This could be possible because the word is plural, but words for God are often plural to indicate his majesty. Alternate translation: [But Judah still roams with a god, and is established with the holy ones]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 11:12 (#6)

וְעִם־קְדוֹשִׁים נֶאֱמָן

“and is established with the Holy {One”

The expression **is established** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and the Holy One establishes them]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea - Chapter 12 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter is prophetic poetry indicting Ephraim (Israel) for futile foreign alliances and deceit, framed as a covenant lawsuit and recalling the patriarch Jacob.

1. Israel turns from Yahweh to idols (1–3)
2. Yahweh recalls his care and Israel's rebellion (4–8)
3. Israel's sin brings judgment and death (9–16)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

The Jacob narrative

Verses 3–4 and 12 allude to Genesis events (grasping Esau's heel, wrestling at Peniel, Bethel, fleeing to Aram) and assume readers know these stories.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Shifting pronouns

The subject shifts often—he/they for Ephraim, and ambiguous he/him for Jacob, God, and the angel in verses 3–4. It may be helpful to clarify who each pronoun refers to in your translation.

Hosea 12:1 (#1)

אֶפְרַ֤יִם רֹעֶה֙ רוּחַ֔ וְרֹדֵ֖ף קָדִ֣ים כָּל־הַיּ֑וֹם

"Ephraim is feeding on wind and pursuing the east-wind all the day"

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional as modeled in the UST. Alternate translation: [Ephraim is uselessly pursuing the wind all the day]

See: Parallelism

Hosea 12:1 (#2)

אֶפְרַ֤יִם רֹעֶה֙ רוּחַ֔ וְרֹדֵ֖ף קָדִ֣ים

"Ephraim is feeding on wind and pursuing the east-wind"

The speaker is speaking of Ephraim's useless pursuit foreign alliances as if it were **feeding on wind** and **pursuing the east-wind**, an activity that gains nothing real. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [By pursuing foreign alliances, Ephraim is chasing after nothing]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 12:1 (#3)

כָּל־הַיּ֑וֹם

"all the day"

The speaker says **all the day** as a generalization for emphasis. If it would be clearer in your language, you could express the emphasis in a different way. Alternate translation: [constantly] or [all the time]

See: Hyperbole

Hosea 12:1 (#4)

כָּזָ֣ב וְשֹׁ֔שֶׁד

"lies and destruction"

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **lies** and **destruction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [false words and destructive activity]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 12:1 (#5)

וּבְרִ֥ית יִכְרֹ֖תוּ

"And they cut a covenant"

The pronoun **they** refers to the people of Ephraim or the northern kingdom of Israel, which is a shift from earlier in this verse where he refers to the nation as the person with his name and the pronoun**He**. Throughout this chapter, the pronouns referring to the nation vary between singular and plural. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the singular here and in the next verses or use the plural throughout as modeled in the UST. The pronoun **they** refers to the people of Ephraim, the same people referred to as **He** earlier in the verse. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [And Ephraim cut a covenant] or [And he cut a covenant]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 12:1 (#6)

וּבְרִ֥ית יִכְרֹ֖תוּ

"And they cut a covenant"

The speaker is using **cut a covenant** as a common expression of his culture which means "to make" or "establish" a covenant. See how you translated the phrase "cut a covenant" in 2:18. Here it refers to

agreements that Israel made when they forsook the help that their God offered to pursue help from enemy nations. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [will establish a covenant]

See: Idiom

Hosea 12:1 (#7)

וְשֶׁשֶׁמֶן לְמִצְרַיִם יוּבָל

“and oil is carried to Egypt”

The expression **is carried** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and they carry oil to Egypt] or [and they give olive oil to negotiate with Egypt]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 12:2 (#1)

וְרִיב לַיהוָה עִם־יְהוּדָה

“And a dispute {is} to Yahweh with Judah”

The implication is that **dispute** here refers to a formal legal complaint, as when one party brings a lawsuit against another. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [And Yahweh has a formal legal complaint against Judah]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 12:2 (#2)

וְרִיב

“And a dispute”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **dispute**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [And Yahweh disputes with Judah]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 12:2 (#3)

כִּדְרָכָיו

“according to his ways”

The speaker is speaking of how Jacob has lived as if it were the paths or ** ways** that he usually walks along. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [based on his behavior]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 12:3 (#1)

עָקַב אֶת־אָחִיו

“he took his brother by the heel”

The pronoun **he** refers to Jacob, the ancestor of the people of Israel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Jacob took his brother by the heel]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 12:3 (#2)

בַּבֶּטֶן עָקַב אֶת־אָחִיו

“In the womb he took his brother by the heel”

This refers to the account of Jacob’s birth described in Genesis 25:26, when he came out of the womb grasping the heel of his twin brother Esau. You could include this information in a footnote if that would be helpful to your readers.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 12:3 (#3)

וּבְאוֹנָנוֹ

“and in his manhood”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **manhood**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and in his adult life]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 12:3 (#4)

שָׂרָה אֶת־אֱלֹהִים

“he struggled with God”

This and the first line of the next verse refer to the account described in Genesis 32:22–32, when Jacob wrestled with an angel who turned out to be God. You could include this information in a footnote if that would be helpful to your readers.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 12:4 (#1)

בָּכָה וַיִּתְחַנֶּן־לוֹ

“He wept and begged favor of him”

The pronoun **He** refers to Jacob, while the pronoun **him** refers to the angel. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Jacob wept and begged favor of the angel]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 12:4 (#2)

בֵּית־אֵל֙ יִמְצָאֶ֔נּוּ

“At Bethel he found him”

This refers to the event described in Genesis 32:28–30 when God revealed himself to Jacob at **Bethel** and spoke with him. You could include this information in a footnote if that would be helpful to your readers.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 12:4 (#3)

יִמְצָאֶ֔נּוּ

“he found him”

The pronoun **he** refers to God, while the pronoun **him** refers to Jacob. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [God found Jacob]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 12:4 (#4)

עִמָּנוּ

“with us”

The phrase **with us** is a translation of the written Hebrew text. This reading, however, does not seem to make sense, since God spoke to Jacob at Bethel, not to his descendants. You may want to follow an alternative reading from the ancient Greek and Syriac translations, which translated the phrase as “with him,” which has the same consonants as “with us.” The UST follows that reading.

See: Alternative Readings

Hosea 12:5 (#1)

אֱלֹהֵ֥י הַצְּבָאֽוֹת

“the God of Armies”

The speaker is using the possessive form **God of Armies** to mean the one who commands the armies of heaven. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the God who commands the armies of heaven]

See: Possession

Hosea 12:5 (#2)

יְהוָ֖ה זִכְרֽוֹ

“Yahweh {is} his memorial name”

The speaker is using the expression **his memorial name** as a common expression of the culture to mean “the name by which Yahweh is to be remembered and worshiped for all generations.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Yahweh is the name by which he is to be remembered and worshiped for all generations]

See: Idiom

Hosea 12:6 (#1)

וְאַתָּ֖ה בֵּאלֹהֶ֣יךָ תָּשׁ֑וּב

“And you, by your God you must return”

The speaker is speaking of repenting and turning back to God as if the people had been walking one direction and must instead **return** to him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [And you must restore yourself to your God]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 12:6 (#2)

בֵּאלֹהֶ֣יךָ

“by your God”

The phrase **by your God** could mean: (1) that the Israelites should return to God by following his ways, as described in the rest of the verse. Alternate translation: [by following the ways of your God] or (2) that the Israelites should rely on God’s help to empower them to return. Alternate translation: [by the help of your God]

Hosea 12:6 (#3)

חֶ֚סֶד וּמִשְׁפָּ֔ט

“covenant faithfulness and justice”

If your language does not use abstract nouns for the ideas of **covenant faithfulness** and **justice**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [being faithful to the covenant and doing what is just]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 12:7 (#1)

כְּנַעַן

“A merchant”

The implication is that the **merchant** here stands for the tradesmen of Ephraim, whom the speaker is portraying as dishonest traders. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [The merchants of Ephraim]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 12:7 (#2)

בְּיָדוֹ מֹאזְנֵי מִרְמָה

“in his hand {are} scales of deceit”

Here, **his hand** represents his possession and control of the scales. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [he possesses scales of deceit]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 12:7 (#3)

מֹאזְנֵי מִרְמָה

“are} scales of deceit”

Here, **scales** describes an instrument for determining the weight of an object. It consists of a central post with a crossbar from which two pans are hung. An object may be placed in one pan and known weights placed in the other pan until the crossbar remains level, indicating that both pans contain an equal weight. By using incorrect weights these merchants were deceiving those with whom they traded in order to increase their wealth. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of weighing instrument, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [are dishonest weighing instruments]

See: Translate Unknowns

Hosea 12:7 (#4)

מֹאזְנֵי מִרְמָה

“are} scales of deceit”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **deceit**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [are deceitful scales]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 12:8 (#1)

עָשַׁשְׁתִּי מָצָאתִי אָוֶן לִי

“I have become rich; I have found wealth for myself”

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it is helpful, you could connect the phrases in a way that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [I have become rich; yes, I have found wealth for myself]

See: Parallelism

Hosea 12:8 (#2)

מָצָאתִי אָוֶן לִי

“I have found wealth for myself”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wealth**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [I have made myself very wealthy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 12:8 (#3)

עָוֹן

“iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [anything evil]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 12:8 (#4)

חֵטְא

“would be} sin”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **sin**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [would be considered sinful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 12:9 (#1)

וְאָנֹכִי יְהוָה

“And I {am} Yahweh”

This is the beginning of what Yahweh said. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a

direct quote of Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Yahweh said, "I am Yahweh]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Hosea 12:9 (#2)

עֹ֚וד אוֹשִׁ֣יבְךָ֔ בָּאֳהָלִ֖ים

"I will make you dwell in tents again"

Yahweh is speaking of bringing the people back to humble dependence on him as if it were making them **dwell in tents** again. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will make you live as wanderers again]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 12:9 (#3)

מֵאֶ֣רֶץ מִצְרָ֑יִם

"from the land of Egypt"

Yahweh assumes that readers will know that the exodus is meant when he mentions **the land of Egypt**. You could say that explicitly if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [who saved you from the land of Egypt]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 12:9 (#4)

כִּימֵ֥י

"as in the days of"

Yahweh is using the term **as in the days** to refer to a specific time. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [during the time of]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 12:9 (#5)

מוֹעֵֽד

"the appointed festival"

The implication is that **the appointed festival** refers to the Festival of Shelters, during which the people lived in **tents** as temporary shelters to remember how their ancestors lived in the wilderness after leaving Egypt. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers as modeled in the UST.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 12:10 (#1)

וּבְיַ֥ד הַנְּבִיאִ֖ים אֲדַמֶּֽה

"and by the hand of the prophets I gave parables"

Here, **the hand of the prophets** represents the prophets as the agents through whom Yahweh acted. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [and through the prophets I gave parables]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 12:10 (#2)

וְאָנֹכִ֖י חָזָ֑ון הִרְבֵּ֖יתִי

"and I, I multiplied visions"

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I multiplied** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that he is the one who did this. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [and I, Yahweh, am the one who multiplied visions]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 12:10 (#3)

חָזָֽון

"visions"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **visions**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the things I revealed to them]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 12:11 (#1)

אִם־גִּלְעָ֥ד אָ֛וֶן

"If Gilead {is} iniquity"

Yahweh is speaking as if this were a hypothetical possibility, but he means that it is actually true. If your language does not state something as a condition if it is certain or true, or if your readers might think that what Hosea is saying is uncertain, then you could translate this as a confident statement. Alternate translation: [Gilead is indeed full of iniquity]

See: Connect — Factual Conditions

Hosea 12:11 (#2)

גִּלְעָ֖ד אָ֑וֶן

“Gilead {is} iniquity”

Here, **Gilead** represents the people of Gilead. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [If the people of Gilead are iniquity]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 12:11 (#3)

אָ֑וֶן

“is} iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [is idolatrous]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 12:11 (#4)

אִם־גִּלְעָ֖ד אָ֑וֶן

“If Gilead {is} iniquity”

The implication is that the people of Gilead were well known for their idolatry and violent deeds. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Since Gilead is known for its idolatry and violent deeds]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 12:11 (#5)

שָׁ֚וְא הָיוּ֙

“they have become worthlessness”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **worthlessness**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [they have come to nothing]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 12:11 (#6)

בַּגִּלְגָּ֣ל שְׁוָרִ֔ים זִבְּח֖וּ

“In Gilgal, they sacrifice bulls”

The implication is that Gilgal was a place of pagan worship, so the people’s sacrificing there was offensive to Yahweh rather than pleasing to him. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [In Gilgal, they sacrifice bulls on their pagan altars]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 12:11 (#7)

בַּגִּלְגָּ֣ל

“In Gilgal”

Here, **In Gilgal** represents the people who lived in Gilgal. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Those who live in Gilgal]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 12:11 (#8)

שְׁוָרִ֔ים זִבְּח֖וּ

“they sacrifice bulls”

The pronoun **they** here refers to the people of Israel who worship at Gilgal. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the people of Israel sacrifice bulls]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 12:11 (#9)

מִזְבְּחוֹתָ֖ם כְּגַלִּ֑ים עַ֚ל תַּלְמֵ֣י שָׂדָֽי

“their altars {will be} like heaps on the furrows of the field”

The point of this comparison is that just as **heaps** of stones cleared onto the **furrows** of a plowed field are nothing but useless piles of rubble, so **their altars** will be torn down into ruined heaps of stone. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [their altars will become useless heaps of rubble on the furrows of the field]

See: Simile

Hosea 12:12 (#1)

וַיִּבְרַ֖ח יַעֲקֹ֑ב שְׂדֵ֥ה אֲרָ֖ם

“And Jacob fled {to} the field of Aram”

This refers to the occasion described in Genesis 27:43 when Jacob fled to Aram (in the land of Haran) in order to escape from his brother Esau. You could include this information or add it in a footnote if that would be helpful to your readers.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 12:12 (#2)

וַיַּעֲבֹ֖ד יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל בְּאִשָּׁ֥ה וּבְאִשָּׁ֖ה שָׁמָֽר

“and Israel served for a wife, and for a wife he kept {sheep”

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [and Israel worked hard tending sheep in order to get a wife] or [and Israel served for a wife, indeed for a wife he kept sheep]

See: Parallelism

Hosea 12:12 (#3)

וּבְאִשָּׁ֥ה שָׁמָֽר

“and for a wife he kept {sheep”

Hosea is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and for a wife he worked by keeping sheep]

See: Ellipsis

Hosea 12:13 (#1)

וּבְנָבִ֥יא נִשְׁמָֽר

“and by a prophet he was kept”

The expression **he was kept** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and by a prophet Yahweh kept him]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 12:13 (#2)

וּבְנָבִ֖יא הֶעֱלָ֣ה יְהוָ֣ה אֶת־יִשְׂרָאֵ֑ל מִמִּצְרַ֖יִם וּבְנָבִ֥יא

“And by a prophet Yahweh brought Israel up from Egypt, and by a prophet”

The speaker assumes that readers will know that the **prophet** through whom Yahweh brought Israel up from Egypt was Moses. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [And by the prophet Moses Yahweh brought Israel up from Egypt, and by Moses]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 12:14 (#1)

הִכְעִ֣יס אֶפְרַ֔יִם תַּמְרוּרִ֖ים

“Ephraim has provoked bitternesses”

The speaker is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context of the next line if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Ephraim has provoked his Lord to bitternesses]

See: Ellipsis

Hosea 12:14 (#2)

הִכְעִ֣יס אֶפְרַ֔יִם תַּמְרוּרִ֖ים

“Ephraim has provoked bitternesses”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **bitternesses**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [Ephraim has bitterly angered his Lord]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 12:14 (#3)

וְדָמָיו֙ עָלָ֣יו יִטּ֔וֹשׁ & אֲדֹנָ֖יו

“and his Lord will leave his bloodguilt on him”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **bloodguilt**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and his Lord will hold him guilty for the blood he has shed]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 12:14 (#4)

וְחֶֽרְפָּתֹ֖ו יָשִׁ֥יב לֹֽו

“and will return his reproach to him”

The speaker is speaking of his Lord repaying Ephraim for his shameful conduct as if the **reproach** were an object that the Lord could **return** to him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and will repay him for his shameful conduct]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 12:14 (#5)

וְחֶֽרְפָּתֹ֖ו יָשִׁ֥יב

“and will return his reproach”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **reproach**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and will repay his offenses]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea - Chapter 13 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

This chapter is a poetic oracle of judgment against the northern kingdom of Israel, usually referred to as "Ephraim."

1. Israel turns from Yahweh to idols (1–3)
2. Yahweh recalls his care and Israel's rebellion (4–8)
3. Israel's sin brings judgment and death (9–16)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Idolatry

The worship of Baal and of cast-metal calf idols is the central offense this chapter condemns.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Yahweh portrayed as a predatory animal

In verses 7–8, Yahweh likens his judgment to a lion, leopard, bear, and lioness; translate these similes so they convey fierceness, not that God is an animal.

Hosea 13:1 (#1)

אֶפְרַיִם

"Ephraim"

Here, **Ephraim** represents the people who were leaders of the northern kingdom of Israel, since Ephraim was its largest and most prominent tribe. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [the leaders of the northern kingdom of Israel]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 13:1 (#2)

רִתֵּת

"trembling"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **trembling**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [people trembled in fear]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 13:1 (#3)

נָשָׂא הוּא

"He lifted up himself"

The speaker is speaking of people exalting themselves and being proud or arrogant as if they had physically **lifted up** themselves. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He exalted himself] or [He became proud of himself]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 13:1 (#4)

וַיָּמֹת

"and died"

The implication is that, by worshiping Baal, the people of Ephraim brought about their own destruction as a nation, as if they had **died**. Their disobedience would eventually lead to the end of the nation of Israel. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [and so destroyed himself as a nation]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 13:2 (#1)

יוֹסִפוּ לַחֲטֹא

"they continue to sin"

The pronoun **they** here going forward refers to the people of Ephraim or the northern kingdom of Israel, which is a shift from the previous verse where the nation is referred to as the person with his name and the singular pronoun**he**. Throughout this chapter, the pronouns referring to the nation vary between singular and plural. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the singular here and in the next verses or use the plural throughout as modeled in the UST. Alternate translation: [Ephraim continued to sin]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 13:2 (#2)

מַעֲשֵׂה חָרָשִׁים

"the work of craftsmen"

The speaker is using the possessive form to describe a **work** that is characterized by being made by **craftsmen**. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in

another way. Alternate translation: [is only handmade by craftsmen] or [is made by craftsmen]

See: Possession

Hosea 13:2 (#3)

לָהֶם֙ הֵ֣מָּה אֹמְרִ֔ים זֹבְחֵי־אָדָ֖ם עֲגָלִ֣ים יִשָּׁקוּֽן

“To them they are saying {things}, the sacrificers of humanity, they kiss calves”

The pronoun **them** could refer to: (1) the idols. Then the pronoun **they** would refer to the **sacrificers**, that is, those who offer sacrifices to the idols. Alternate translation: [Those people who sacrifice humans talk to the idols; they kiss the calves] or (2) the **sacrificers**, and then the pronoun **they** would refer to people in general who are talking about the sacrificers. In this case, the word translated as **saying** would introduce a quote of what these people were saying. Alternate translation: [Of the sacrificers people are saying, “Sacrificers of humans, they kiss calves!”]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 13:3 (#1)

כַּעֲנַ֤ן־בֹּ֙קֶר֙ וְכַטַּ֣ל מַשְׁכִּ֔ים הֹלֵ֖ךְ

“like a cloud of the morning and like the dew rising early, going”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a cloud** and **the dew** that appears early in the day disappears as the day goes on, so the people of Ephraim will soon disappear. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like a morning cloud and the early dew that quickly vanishes]

See: Simile

Hosea 13:3 (#2)

כְּמֹ֣ץ יְסֹעֲעֶ֔ר מִגֹּ֖רֶן

“like chaff—it is blown away from the threshing floor”

The point of this comparison is that just as **chaff** is quickly blown away from the threshing floor and is worthless, so the people of Ephraim will be swept away. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like worthless chaff that is quickly blown away from the threshing floor]

See: Simile

Hosea 13:3 (#3)

יְסֹעֲעֶ֔ר מִגֹּ֖רֶן

“it is blown away from the threshing floor”

The expression **is blown away** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language as modeled in the UST.

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 13:3 (#4)

וּכְעָשָׁ֖ן מֵאֲרֻבָּֽה

“and like smoke from a window”

The point of this comparison is that just as **smoke** quickly dissipates as it goes out from a window, so the people of Ephraim will soon disappear. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and like smoke that quickly disappears out the window]

See: Simile

Hosea 13:4 (#1)

וְאָנֹכִ֣י יְהוָ֔ה אֱלֹהֶ֖יךָ מֵאֶ֣רֶץ מִצְרָ֑יִם

“Yet I {am} Yahweh your God from the land of Egypt”

This is the beginning of what Yahweh said. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote of Yahweh as modeled in the UST. See how you translated the similar statement, “And I am Yahweh your God from the land of Egypt.” in 12:9.

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Hosea 13:5 (#1)

יְדַעְתִּ֖יךָ

“I knew you”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verb translated as **I knew** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that he is the one who cared for their ancestors. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [I, Yahweh knew you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 13:6 (#1)

כְּמַרְעִיתָם֙ וַיִּשְׂבָּ֔עוּ

“According to their pasturage, then they became satisfied”

Yahweh is speaking of the provision he gave the people as if it were **pasturage** where they fed like animals and became satisfied. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [According to the food that I provided them, they ate until they were satisfied]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 13:6 (#2)

וַיִּ֥רָם לִבָּ֖ם

“and their heart was lifted up”

Yahweh is speaking of the people becoming proud as if their **heart** were **lifted up**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly as modeled in the UST.

See: Metaphor

Hosea 13:6 (#3)

עַל־כֵּ֣ן

“Therefore”

The term translated as **Therefore** indicates that what follows is a result of what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes this clear. Alternate translation: [As a result,]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Hosea 13:7 (#1)

כְּמוֹ־שָׁ֔חַל

“like a lion”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a lion** attacks its prey fiercely, so Yahweh will act fiercely toward the people in judgment. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like a fierce lion attacking its prey]

See: Simile

Hosea 13:7 (#2)

כְּנָמֵ֖ר עַל־דֶּ֥רֶךְ אָשׁ֖וּר

“like a leopard along the path I will watch”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a leopard** lurks beside the path to ambush its prey, so Yahweh will watch and wait for the right time to bring judgment on them. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [like a leopard that waits beside the path to attack, so I will watch and wait to punish them]

See: Simile

Hosea 13:8 (#1)

כְּדֹ֣ב שַׁכּ֔וּל

“like a bereaved bear”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a bereaved bear** attacks with ferocious rage when someone takes her cubs, so Yahweh will confront the people in his anger. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [with the fierce rage of a bereaved bear]

See: Simile

Hosea 13:8 (#2)

וְאֶקְרַ֥ע סְגֹ֖ר לִבָּ֑ם

“and I will tear open the enclosure of their heart”

Yahweh is speaking of destroying the people as if he were a wild animal that would **tear open the enclosure of their heart**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly as modeled in the UST.

See: Metaphor

Hosea 13:8 (#3)

כְּלָבִ֔יא

“like a lioness”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a lioness** devours its prey, so Yahweh will completely destroy the people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and completely destroy them as a lioness does her prey]

See: Simile

Hosea 13:9 (#1)

שִׁחֶתְךָ֖

“It has destroyed you”

The pronoun **It** refers to Israel’s rebellion against Yahweh, which is described in the rest of the verse. It may

be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Your rebellion has destroyed you]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 13:9 (#2)

יִשְׂרָאֵל

“Israel”

Here, **Israel** represents the people of the northern kingdom of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [Israelites]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 13:9 (#3)

בְּעָזְרֶךָ

“against your help”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **help**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [against the one who helps you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 13:10 (#1)

אֱהִי מַלְכְּךָ אֵפוֹא וְיוֹשִׁיעֲךָ בְּכָל־עָרֶיךָ וְשֹׁפְטֶיךָ אֲשֶׁר אָמַרְתָּ תְּנָה־לִּי מֶלֶךְ וְשָׂרִים

“Where {is} your king now, that he may save you in all of your cities, and your judges of whom you said, ‘Give to me a king and princes”

Yahweh is using the question form to emphasize that the people’s king is unable to save them. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Even though you asked for a king to save you and for judges to rule you, they cannot help you now.]

See: Rhetorical Question

Hosea 13:10 (#2)

וְשֹׁפְטֶיךָ אֲשֶׁר אָמַרְתָּ תְּנָה־לִּי מֶלֶךְ וְשָׂרִים

“and your judges of whom you said, ‘Give to me a king and princes”

If it would be clearer in your language, you could translate this so that there is not a quotation within a quotation. Alternate translation: [and your judges that I gave you because you asked me for a king and princes?]

See: Quotes within Quotes

Hosea 13:11 (#1)

בְּאַפִּי

“in my nose”

Yahweh is using **in my nose** as a common expression of the culture to mean “in my anger.” If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [even though it made me angry]

See: Idiom

Hosea 13:11 (#2)

בְּעֶבְרָתִי

“in my wrath”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **wrath**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because I am angry]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 13:12 (#1)

צָרוּר֙ עֲוֹ֣ן אֶפְרָ֔יִם צְפוּנָ֖ה חַטָּאתֽוֹ

“The iniquity of Ephraim {is} bound up & is} stored up”

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional as modeled in the UST. See how you as a team have decided to translate the parallel phrases in poetry, and follow that approach here and throughout this chapter. Alternate translation: [I have recorded all of the evil things that Ephraim has done]

See: Parallelism

Hosea 13:12 (#2)

צָרוּר֙ עֲוֹ֣ן אֶפְרָ֔יִם צְפוּנָ֖ה חַטָּאתֽוֹ

“The iniquity of Ephraim {is} bound up & is} stored up”

The speaker is speaking of all of Ephraim's sinfulness as if it were a physical object that is **bound up** and **stored up** to be kept for the future. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I have remembered the iniquity of Ephraim; I have kept a record of his sin for future punishment]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 13:12 (#3)

עֲוֹן

"The iniquity of"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [The wrong things done by]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 13:13 (#1)

חֶבְלֵי יוֹלֵדָה יָבֹאוּ לוֹ

"The pains of a woman giving birth will come to him"

The speaker is speaking of the suffering that judgment will bring on the people as if it were **pains of a woman giving birth**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Intense suffering will come to him]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 13:13 (#2)

לֹא־יַעֲמֹד בְּמִשְׁבַּר בָּנִים

"he does not stand at the womb opening of sons"

The speaker is using the possessive form to describe a **womb opening** that is characterized by being the place through which **sons** are born. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [he refused to come out at the opening where babies are born]

See: Possession

Hosea 13:14 (#1)

מִיַּד שְׁאוֹל אֶפְדֵּם מִמָּוֶת אֶגְאָלֵם

"From the hand of Sheol I would ransom them; from death I would redeem them"

These phrases could be: (1) expressions of Yahweh's frustration that he wants to redeem the people of Israel, but their sin and rebellion keep him from doing so, as in the ULT and UST, or (2) promises that Yahweh will redeem the people of Israel. Alternate translation: [From the hand of Sheol I will ransom them; from death I will redeem them] or (3) questions that expect a negative answer. Alternate translation: [From the hand of Sheol should I ransom them? No! From death should I redeem them? No]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Hosea 13:14 (#2)

מִיַּד שְׁאוֹל

"From the hand of Sheol"

Here, **hand** represents the power or grip of Sheol, the place of the dead. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [From the power of death]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 13:14 (#3)

אֱהִי דְבָרַיִךְ מָוֶת אֱהִי קָטָבֵךְ שְׁאוֹל

"Where are your plagues, Death? Where is your destruction, Sheol"

Yahweh is speaking to **Death** and **Sheol**, which he knows cannot hear him. He is doing this to communicate to the people listening to him that he feels very strongly that they deserve death. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if he were speaking directly to the people about Death and Sheol. Alternate translation: [Where are the plague and destruction that bring death]

See: Apostrophe

Hosea 13:14 (#4)

אֱהִי דְבָרַיִךְ מָוֶת אֱהִי קָטָבֵךְ שְׁאוֹל

"Where are your plagues, Death? Where is your destruction, Sheol"

The meaning of these two questions could be: (1) that Yahweh is calling on Death to bring out its plagues and for Sheol to bring out its destructive forces. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements or as exclamations. Alternate translation: [Bring your plagues, Death! Bring your destruction, Sheol!] or (2) that the plagues of Death

and the destruction of Sheol are nowhere to be found. If you decided to translate the first two phrases of this verse as promises that Yahweh will redeem the people of Israel, then you may want to choose this option. Alternate translation: [Your plagues have gone missing, Death! Your destruction is gone, Sheol!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Hosea 13:14 (#5)

קָטָבְדְּךָ

“your destruction”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **your destruction**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [your power to destroy]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 13:14 (#6)

נֹחָם יִסָּתֵר מֵעֵינָי

“Relenting is hidden from my eyes”

Here Yahweh is speaking as if his **Relenting** toward Israel were a thing that could be **hidden from my eyes**, out of his sight so that he could not act on it. He means that he will not change his mind and show mercy to Israel. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will not change my mind about this]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 13:15 (#1)

הֽוּא בֵּבֵן אַחִים יַפְרִֽיא

“he, among brothers, he bears fruit”

The pronoun **he** refers to Ephraim. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [Ephraim, among brothers, he bears fruit]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 13:15 (#2)

בֵּבֵן אַחִים יַפְרִֽיא

“among brothers, he bears fruit”

The speaker is speaking of Ephraim prospering more than the other tribes as if he were a plant that **bears fruit**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [in comparison to his brothers, he prospers]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 13:15 (#3)

יָבוֹא קָדִים֙ רוּחַ יְהוָ֔ה

“an easterly will come, the wind of Yahweh”

The speaker is speaking of the destructive judgment of the enemies from the east that Yahweh will send, **the wind of Yahweh**, as if it were **an easterly**, a scorching wind from the east. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [a destroyer sent by Yahweh will come]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 13:15 (#4)

וְיֵבֹ֣ושׁ מְקוֹר֗וֹ וְיֶחֱרַ֙ב מַעְיָנ֔וֹ

“and his fountain will be ashamed and his spring will dry up”

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them and express the emphasis in another way as in the UST. Another approach would be to connect the phrases with a word that shows that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [and his fountain will dry up, indeed his spring as well]

See: Parallelism

Hosea 13:15 (#5)

וְיֵבֹ֣ושׁ מְקוֹר֗וֹ

“and his fountain will be ashamed”

The word translated as **will be ashamed** is a translation of the written Hebrew text. This reading, however, does not seem to make sense. Scholars suggest that two letters got switched from the original reading, which was the word meaning “will dry up.” The ancient Greek and Syriac translations also translated the word as “will dry up.” Alternate translation: [and his fountain will dry up]

See: Alternative Readings

Hosea 13:15 (#6)

הוּא יִשְׁסֶֽה

“It, it will plunder”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **It** separately, even though the verb translated as **it will plunder** already includes this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize how completely the enemies will plunder them. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [They will completely plunder]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 13:15 (#7)

כְּלִי֙ חֶמְדָּה

“vessel of desire”

The speaker is using the possessive form to describe a **vessel** that is characterized by being desirable and valuable. If a speaker of your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could express this idea in another way. Alternate translation: [every desirable possession]

See: Possession

Hosea 13:16 (#1)

שֹׁמְרוֹן

“Samaria”

Here, **Samaria** represents the people who live in the city of Samaria, the capital of the northern kingdom. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [The people living in Samaria]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 13:16 (#2)

תֶּאְשַׁם שֹׁמְרוֹן כִּֽי־ מָרְתָ֥ה בֵאלֹהֶ֖יהָ

“Samaria will bear guilt, for she has rebelled against her God”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Since Samaria has rebelled against her God, she will bear guilt]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Hosea 13:16 (#3)

מָרְתָ֥ה בֵאלֹהֶ֖יהָ בַּחֶ֣רֶב יִפֹּ֑לוּ עֹלְלֵיהֶ֣ם יְרֻטָּ֔שׁוּ וְהָרִיּוֹתֶ֖יו

“she has rebelled against her God. By the sword they will fall; their young children will be dashed to pieces, and his pregnant women”

The pronouns **she**, **her**, **they**, **their**, and **his** all refer to the people of Samaria. Throughout this verse, the pronouns vary between singular and plural and even gender. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the singular masculine pronouns as is more common for consistency or use the plural throughout as modeled in the UST. Alternate translation: [he has rebelled against his God. By the sword he will fall; his young children will be dashed to pieces, and his pregnant women]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 13:16 (#4)

בַּחֶ֣רֶב יִפֹּ֑לוּ

“By the sword they will fall”

Here, **the sword** represents warfare and violent death in battle. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [They will die in battle]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 13:16 (#5)

יִפֹּ֑לוּ

“they will fall”

The pronoun **they** refers to the people of Samaria. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. Alternate translation: [the people of Samaria will fall]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 13:16 (#6)

עֹלְלֵיהֶ֣ם יְרֻטָּ֔שׁוּ

“their young children will be dashed to pieces”

The expression **will be dashed to pieces** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [their enemies will dash their young children to pieces]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 13:16 (#7)

וְהָרִיּוֹתֶ֖יו יְבֻקָּֽעוּ

“and his pregnant women will be ripped open”

The expression **will be ripped open** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [and their enemies will cut open their pregnant women]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea - Chapter 14 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

Yahweh calls Israel to repentance and promises restoration

1. Call to Israel to come back to Yahweh in repentance (1–3)
2. Yahweh promises healing, restoration, and blessing (4–8)
3. The wise walk in Yahweh's ways (9)

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Repentance

The chapter urges Israel to "return" to Yahweh, abandoning idols and reliance on Assyria.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Shifting speakers

The chapter moves between the prophet, the praying people, and Yahweh himself, often without explicit markers, so track the pronouns to see who is speaking.

Hosea 14:1 (#1)

שׁוּבָה יִשְׂרָאֵל עַד יְהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ כִּי כָשַׁלְתָּ בַּעֲוֹנֶךָ

"Return, Israel, to Yahweh your God, for you have stumbled in your iniquity"

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because you have stumbled in your iniquity, return, Israel, to Yahweh your God]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Hosea 14:1 (#2)

שׁוּבָה יִשְׂרָאֵל עַד

"Return, Israel, to"

The speaker is speaking to the Israelites as if they had physically been walking away but could **Return** to walk back to Yahweh. He means that they should repent of living in ways that are displeasing to Yahweh and instead live in the manner in which Yahweh wants people to live. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You, Israel, should once again start obeying Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 14:1 (#3)

אֱלֹהֶיךָ

"your God"

The speaker is not using this possessive form **your God** to indicate that Israel possesses or controls Yahweh. Rather, he is using these words to indicate that Yahweh is the God whom Israel was meant to worship. Alternate translation: [the God whom you worship]

See: Possession

Hosea 14:1 (#4)

כָשַׁלְתָּ בַּעֲוֹנֶךָ

"you have stumbled in your iniquity"

The speaker is speaking of the ruin that the people's sin has brought upon them as if they had physically **stumbled**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you have fallen into ruin because of your iniquity]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 14:1 (#5)

בַּעֲוֹנֶךָ

"in your iniquity"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [because of your sinful ways]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 14:2 (#1)

קְחוּ עִמָּכֶם דְּבָרִים וְשׁוּבוּ אֶל־יְהוָה אִמְרוּ אֵלָיו

"Take with you words and return to Yahweh. Say to him"

Here, the words **Take** and **Say** are imperatives, but they communicate an exhortation rather than a command. The speaker is encouraging the people to say the following words of repentance in order to **return to Yahweh**. If the imperative does not communicate

an exhortation for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates an exhortation or invitation. Alternate translation: [You should repent and return to Yahweh and say to him]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Hosea 14:2 (#2)

כָּל־תִּשָּׂא עָוֹן וְקַח־טּוֹב

“Take away all iniquity and accept {what} is good”

The words translated as **Take away** and **accept** are imperatives, but they communicate a polite request rather than a command. If the imperative does not communicate a polite request for your readers, then use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [Please take away all iniquity and please accept what is good]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Hosea 14:2 (#3)

תִּשָּׂא

“Take away”

Here the people are speaking of Yahweh forgiving their sins as if they were a mark that he could erase or **take away**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Forgive]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 14:2 (#4)

עָוֹן

“iniquity”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **iniquity**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that we have done wrong]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 14:2 (#5)

וּנְשַׁלְּמָה פָרִים שְׂפָתֵינוּ

“and let us repay {with} bulls of our lips”

The phrase **and let us repay with bulls of our lips** is a translation of the written Hebrew text, which compares a sincere prayer of obedience to the sacrifice of a bull (see chapter 6:6). The ancient Greek translation, however, understood the word translated as “bulls” to be the word for “fruit.” Several modern translations follow this reading. You may want to follow the reading of the major translation in your area. Alternate translation: [and let us repay with the fruit of our lips]

See: Alternative Readings

Hosea 14:2 (#6)

פָּרִים שְׂפָתֵינוּ

“with} bulls of our lips”

Here, **bulls of our lips** represents the words of praise and the vows that the people offer to Yahweh in place of animal sacrifices. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [with the praise from our lips in place of bull sacrifices]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 14:3 (#1)

עַל־סוּסִ֣ לֹ֣א נִרְכָּ֔ב

“we will not ride on a horse”

In this context, **horse** represent military strength so the people are saying they will not rely on military strength. Here the word **horse** is singular in form, but it refers to all horses as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use the plural form of “horse” or explain the meaning in plain language. Alternate translation: [we will not rely on our military strength]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 14:3 (#2)

אֱלֹהֵ֖ינוּ

“Our God”

The people are not using this possessive form **Our God** to indicate that they possess or control a god. Rather, they are using these words to indicate the false god whom they worship. Alternate translation: [You are the god whom we worship]

See: Possession

Hosea 14:3 (#3)

לְמַעֲשֵׂ֣ה יָדֵ֔ינוּ

“to the work of our hands”

Here, **the work of our hands** represents the idols that the people have made with their hands. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent

expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [to the idols we have made with our hands]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 14:3 (#4)

אֲשֶׁר־בְּךָ

“who by you”

The pronoun **who** refers to Yahweh, to whom this speech is directed. It may be helpful to clarify this for your readers. It may also be helpful to start a new sentence here. Alternate translation: [It is by you, Yahweh, that]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 14:3 (#5)

יָתוֹם

“the fatherless”

The people are using the adjective **fatherless** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [the fatherless person]

See: Nominal Adjectives

Hosea 14:3 (#6)

אֲשֶׁר־בְּךָ יְרֻחַם יָתוֹם

“who by you the fatherless is shown compassion”

The expression **is shown compassion** is a passive verbal form. If it would be unnatural to use that form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [you are the one who shows compassion to the fatherless]

See: Active or Passive

Hosea 14:3 (#7)

יְרֻחַם

“is shown compassion”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **compassion**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [is compassionately cared for]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 14:4 (#1)

אֶרְפָּא מְשׁוּבָתָם אוֹהֲבֵם נְדָבָה כִּי שָׁב אַפִּי מִמֶּנּוּ

“I will heal their turning away; I will love them freely, for my nose has turned away from them”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because my nose has turned away from them, I will heal their turning away; I will love them freely]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Hosea 14:4 (#2)

אֶרְפָּא

“I will heal”

This is the beginning of what Yahweh says. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could mark that this is a direct quote of Yahweh. Alternate translation: [Then Yahweh will respond, “I will heal]

See: Quotations and Quote Margins

Hosea 14:4 (#3)

אֶרְפָּא

“I will heal”

Yahweh is speaking of forgiving the people and restoring their previous relationship as if he would **heal** them from a sickness. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will restore them from]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 14:4 (#4)

מְשׁוּבָתָם

“their turning away”

Yahweh is speaking of the people’s abandonment of worshiping him to worshiping idols as if it were a physical **turning away** from following him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [their abandonment of me] or [their rebellion against me]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 14:4 (#5)

אַפִּי

“my nose”

Yahweh is using **my nose** as part of a common expression of this culture, “the burning of his nose” which

means that Yahweh is angry. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my anger]

See: Idiom

Hosea 14:4 (#6)

שָׁ֣שָׁב אַפִּ֔י מִמֶּ֑נּוּ

“my nose has turned away from them”

Here Yahweh is speaking of his anger as if it had been moving toward them but now **has turned away from them**. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my anger at them has left] or [my fury with them has subsided]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 14:5 (#1)

אֶֽהְיֶ֤ה כַטַּל֙ לְיִשְׂרָאֵ֔ל

“I will be”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the dew** brings moisture and life to plants, so Yahweh will bring nourishment and new life to **Israel**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [I will again nourish Israel just as the dew brings life to plants]

See: Simile

Hosea 14:5 (#2)

יִפְרַ֣ח כַּשּׁוֹשַׁנָּ֔ה

“he will blossom”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the lily** blossoms with beauty, so the people of Israel will flourish and grow. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [he will flourish beautifully, like a blossoming lily]

See: Simile

Hosea 14:5 (#3)

וְיַ֥ךְ שָׁרָשָׁ֖יו כַּלְּבָנֽוֹן

“and he will strike”

The point of this comparison is that just as the great trees of **Lebanon** send down deep, firm roots, so the people of Israel will become strong and firmly established. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and he will become strong and firmly established, like the deep-rooted trees of Lebanon]

See: Simile

Hosea 14:6 (#1)

יֵלְכ֣וּ יֹנְקוֹתָ֔יו

“His shoots will go forth”

Yahweh is speaking of the people of Israel as if they were a plant whose **shoots** spread out and grow. He means that they will increase in influence and prosperity. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The people of Israel will spread its influence and prosper]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 14:6 (#2)

וִיהִ֥י כַזַּ֖יִת הוֹדֽוֹ

“and his splendor will be like the olive tree”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the olive tree** is beautiful and majestic, so the people of Israel will be splendid. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and he will be as splendid as the majestic olive tree]

See: Simile

Hosea 14:6 (#3)

הוֹדֽוֹ

“his splendor”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **splendor**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [how splendid he looks]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 14:6 (#4)

וְרֵ֥יחַ לֹ֖ו כַּלְּבָנֽוֹן

“and the scent of him like Lebanon”

The point of this comparison is that just as the cedar forests of **Lebanon** give off a pleasant fragrance, so the people of Israel will be pleasing and delightful. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and he will be as pleasing as the fragrant forests of Lebanon]

See: Simile

Hosea 14:7 (#1)

יָשֻׁ֖בוּ

“They will return”

Here the speaker is speaking of the people of Israel resuming a right relationship with Yahweh as if they would **return** to a place from which they had gone away. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [They will once again be]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 14:7 (#2)

יֹשְׁבֵ֣י בְצִלּ֔וֹ

“dwellers in his shadow”

The speaker is speaking of Yahweh’s protection as if it were a **shadow** in which people could dwell and find shelter. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [those who live under his protection]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 14:7 (#3)

בְצִלּ֔וֹ & זִכְרֹ֖ו

“in his shadow & His remembrance”

Here, **his** could refer to: (1) Yahweh, who covers the people of Israel with his **shadow**, Alternate translation: [in Yahweh’s shadow] or (2) the nation of Israel, which covers the people of Israel with its **shadow**. Alternate translation: [in its shadow … Its remembrance]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 14:7 (#4)

וְיִפְרְחָ֥ו כַגָּ֖פֶן

“and blossom like the vine”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the vine** produces an abundant harvest, so the people of Israel will flourish and multiply. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [and flourish abundantly, just as a vine produces a rich harvest]

See: Simile

Hosea 14:7 (#5)

זִכְרֹ֖ו כְּיֵ֣ין לְבָנֽוֹן

“His remembrance {will be} like the wine of Lebanon”

The point of this comparison is that just as **the wine of Lebanon** was famous and highly valued, so **His remembrance** will be renowned. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [People will honor his remembrance as much as they prize the famous wine of Lebanon]

See: Simile

Hosea 14:7 (#6)

זִכְרֹ֖ו כְּיֵ֣ין לְבָנֽוֹן

“His remembrance {will be} like the wine of Lebanon”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **remembrance**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [People will be as favorable to Yahweh as they are to the wine of Lebanon]

See: Abstract Nouns

Hosea 14:8 (#1)

אֶפְרַ֣יִם מַה־לִּ֤י עֹוד֙ לָֽעֲצַבִּ֔ים

“Ephraim, what to me still to idols”

Yahweh is using the question form to state emphatically that he wants nothing more to do with **idols**. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate this as a statement or as an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Ephraim, I want to no longer have anything to do with idols!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Hosea 14:8 (#2)

אֶפְרַ֣יִם

“Ephraim”

As throughout the book of Hosea, **Ephraim**, the name of the largest of the northern tribes, represents the entire northern kingdom of Israel. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [People of the northern kingdom of Israel]

See: Metonymy

Hosea 14:8 (#3)

מַה־לִּ֥י עֹ֖וד לָֽעֲצַבִּ֑ים

“what to me still to idols”

Yahweh is using **what to me** as a common expression of the culture to mean “I have nothing to do with.” Yahweh is expressing that he is disgusted by the people of Ephraim mixing idol worship with worship of Yahweh. If this phrase does not have that meaning for your readers, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Why are you still worshiping both me and idols] or [I am sick and tired of you worshiping both me and idols!] or [I do not want anything more to do with idols.]

See: Idiom

Hosea 14:8 (#4)

אֲנִ֥י עָנִ֖יתִי וַאֲשׁוּרֶֽנּוּ

“I, I have answered and I will look after him”

Yahweh is stating the pronoun **I** separately, even though the verbs translated as **I have answered** and **I will look after** already include this meaning. He is doing that to emphasize that he himself is the one who answers and cares for his people. If a speaker of your language would use an explicit pronoun for the same purpose, you may want to use that construction in your translation. If not, your language may have other ways of showing the meaning here. Alternate translation: [I myself have answered and will look after him]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Hosea 14:8 (#5)

אֲנִי֙ כִּבְרוֹשׁ רַעֲנָ֔ן

“I {am} like a luxuriant cypress”

The point of this comparison is that just as **a luxuriant cypress** stays green and provides shade and shelter, so Yahweh continually provides for and protects his people. If it would be helpful in your language, you could make this point explicitly. Alternate translation: [I continually provide for and protect you, as a flourishing cypress tree gives shade and shelter]

See: Simile

Hosea 14:8 (#6)

מִמֶּ֥נִּי פִרְיְךָ֖ נִמְצָֽא

“from me your fruit is found”

Yahweh is speaking of the blessings and prosperity that he gives to his people as if they were **fruit** that comes from him. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [your prosperity comes from me]

See: Metaphor

Hosea 14:9 (#1)

מִֽי־חָכָ֤ם וְיָבֶן֙ אֵ֣לֶּה נָבֹ֔ון וְיֵדָעֵ֖ם

“Who {is} wise? Then let him understand these things. Discerning? Then let him know them”

The speaker is using the question form to challenge his readers to be **wise** and **Discerning** enough to understand and heed his message. If a speaker of your language would not use the question form for that purpose, you could translate these questions as statements. Alternate translation: [Let the one who is wise understand these things, and let the one who is discerning know them]

See: Rhetorical Question

Hosea 14:9 (#2)

נָבֹ֔ון

“Discerning”

The speaker is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You can supply these words from the context if that would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [Who is discerning]

See: Ellipsis

Hosea 14:9 (#3)

יְשָׁרִ֖ים דַּרְכֵ֣י יְהוָ֑ה וְצַדִּקִ֣ים יֵלְכ֣וּ בָ֔ם וּפֹשְׁעִ֖ים יִכָּשְׁלוּ־בָֽם

“the ways of Yahweh {are} right, and the righteous will walk in them, but the transgressors will stumble in them”

The speaker is speaking of how Yahweh wants people to live as if it were **the ways of Yahweh**, that is, paths to walk on. He speaks of obeying Yahweh as **the righteous will walk** on these paths and of disobeying as **stumbling** on them. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [what Yahweh commands is right, and righteous people will obey him, but rebellious people will disobey him and be ruined]

Hosea 14:9 (#4)

See: Metaphor

Hosea 14:9 (#4)

וְצַדִּקִ֖ים

“and the righteous”

The speaker is using the adjective **righteous** as a noun to mean a certain kind of person. Your language may use adjectives in the same way. If not, you can translate this adjective with an equivalent phrase. Alternate translation: [and righteous people]

See: Nominal Adjectives